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The Sunday EXPRESS



EYE

ADVANTAGE, INDIA

He made Kolhapuri chappals trendy in Florida, beat the best on tennis court, refused to surrender his Indian passport and made a generation of immigrants feel they belonged. Now, Vijay Amritraj has a Padma Bhushan to show for it

BOOKS

British-Irish novelist Maggie O'Farrell on her new novel *Land*



DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA



The three were arrested in Maharashtra's Thane, Saturday. DEEPAK JOSHI

Now, Maharashtra teacher exam paper leaked, 3 arrested

Exam was to be conducted today, SIT formed

Soham Shah & Mohamed Thaver
Pune, Mumbai, June 27

THE MAHARASHTRA Teacher Eligibility Test (TET), scheduled for Sunday, was postponed Saturday after a question paper leak was detected in the Bhiwandi area of Thane district.

While Thane police have arrested three persons in this connection, a Special Investigation Team has been formed to probe the question paper leak.

According to a press note issued by the Secretary of the Maharashtra State Council of Examination, a raid was conducted early Saturday morning in the Bhiwandi area based on information received by police. Police found a few individuals in alleged possession of pages

E. EXPLAINED

TET ever since 2013

The TET in Maharashtra has been held since 2013. There is no limit on the number of attempts. In-servicing teachers, unable to clear the test until August 2028, will have to take retirement. The TET is mandatory for appointment as a teacher in primary and secondary schools.

from the sealed TET 2026 question paper packet.

Police then called Council officials to the spot who confirmed that questions from the exam paper matched those in the possession of the individuals. An FIR was then lodged with Bhiwandi police.

The Council, which postponed the examination, did not announce a new date.

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Mass poisoning bid at Muharram rally in Mumbai, man held: Police

Faiyaz Premji gave capsules filled with poison: DCP

Manish Kumar Pathak & Mohamed Thaver
Mumbai, June 27

A MAN from Pune was arrested Saturday for allegedly distributing capsules filled with zinc phosphide, widely used as a rat poison, in an attempt to carry out "mass poisoning" at a Muharram procession of the Shia community in south Mumbai Friday night, police said.

Police identified the arrested man as 39-year-old Faiyaz Premji and said he told them he was a Shia, and that he had 14,000 capsules with zinc phosphide in a blue plastic bag.

According to police, Premji was a Pune resident who stayed in a dormitory in the city before checking into a hotel in south Mumbai where he received delivery of the capsules.

Police claimed he told them that he intended to harm those

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THE WORLD PAGE 10



IRAN-U.S. TRUCE UNDER TEST AS ANOTHER SHIP HIT IN HORMUZ

From Ganga to global pet markets: Police in MP map rail route of protected turtles

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 27

POLICE IN Madhya Pradesh are preparing their first coordinated crackdown on wildlife trafficking through the state's railway network after an analysis of six years of seizure data uncovered organised interstate networks smuggling protected freshwater turtles from northern India's river systems to markets in Southeast Asia and the Middle East, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Between 2020 and 2026, the State Tiger Strike Force (STSF) and Government Railway Police recovered 654 protected animals from passenger trains crossing the state — 647 turtles and seven vultures — across what enforcement records describe as four organised interstate networks.

Senior police officials said the analysis has convinced them that the animals seized over six years represent only a fraction of the wildlife being

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

•Turtles, trains, trafficking

647 freshwater turtles seized (2020-26)
4 Networks identified
24 People arrested



Happening today

• **THE FIRST RASHTRIYA** Gramin Vikas Sammelan begins in New Delhi. The two-day Sammelan will bring together Rural Development Ministers, senior officials and experts from all states and UTs to review key flagship programmes and formulate the future roadmap for rural India.

• **THE CONGRESS WILL** officially launch a statewide public outreach campaign in Uttarakhand to sound the poll bugle for the 2027 Assembly elections.

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WILL COME TO INDIA LATER THIS YEAR TO SET UP VISIT: U.S. SECY OF STATE

Trump could visit India early next year: Rubio

On visa curbs, Gor refers to Modi: 'He talks about no illegal migrants. We 100% agree with that'



US Secy of State Marco Rubio

Divya A
New Delhi, June 27

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump could travel to India early next year, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said in an interview to news agency IANS in Washington Friday. He added he would himself make another trip to India later this year to set the ground for the President's visit.

Rubio was in India last month for four days for bilateral talks as well as the Quad Foreign Ministers meeting.

If the visit comes through, this will be Trump's first visit to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Seychelles President Patrick Herminie at a ceremony to hand over Fast Patrol Vessel *Lesparwar* to the Seychelles Coast Guard, in Victoria, Saturday. PTI

PM arrives in Seychelles, to mark 50 years of relations, chart future

Three-day visit: 50th independence day of island nation, address to Assembly

Divya A
New Delhi, June 27

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi landed in Victoria Saturday to start his three-day state

visit to Seychelles, during which he will hold talks with President Patrick Herminie and attend the golden jubilee celebrations of the archipelago nation's National Day celebra-

tions as Guest of Honour.

At Seychelles International Airport, Modi was welcomed by Herminie and the two leaders drove together to Seychelles' National Botanical Garden. The PM received a ceremonial Guard of Honour, in the presence of Seychelles Cabinet ministers and senior dignitaries.

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Leaping past a legend

ASIAN GAMES SILVER medalist long jumper Ancy Sojan broke the 22-year-old national record held by legendary Anju Bobby George, at the National Inter-State Senior Athletics Championships in Bhubaneswar, Saturday.

THE JUMPER FROM KERALA recorded a massive jump of 6.88 metres in her fifth attempt, bettering George's previous mark of 6.83 metres.

Ancy Sojan in action at Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar, Saturday. AFI

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THEFT AT RAM TEMPLE

Trust confirms: Gen secy Champat Rai, trustee Anil Mishra have quit



Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust General Secretary Champat Rai (right) and trustee Anil Mishra. FILE

Will insist on strongest punishment to guilty, these clouds will clear: Treasurer

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, June 27

AS POLICE in Ayodhya began making recoveries and widened the probe into the alleged theft and embezzlement of funds and valuables donated to the Ram temple, the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust announced Saturday it had received the resignation letters of Trust general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra.

The Trust said a decision on the resignation letters would be

taken at its next meeting.

Rai's former driver Ram Shankar Yadav alias Tinnu Yadav is one of the eight men arrested for the alleged theft of temple donations. Currently in judicial custody, the arrested men will be produced before a Prevention of Corruption Act court Monday. Police have so far recovered Rs 79.80 lakh from seven of the eight accused.

An unsigned statement in Hindi by Trust treasurer Govind Dev Giri, posted on X by the Trust, said, "The Trust has

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Adani prosecutors must justify dropping criminal case: US judge

Luc Cohen
New York, June 27

A US judge has ordered the Justice Department to justify its decision to drop criminal charges against Indian billionaire Gautam Adani, declining to rule immediately on Adani's lawyers' request to dismiss the case.

Brooklyn-based US District Judge Nicholas Garaufis said federal prosecutors' May 18 announcement that they would no longer pursue the case, which charged Adani with securities fraud and wire fraud

stemming from an alleged bribery scheme, did not sufficiently explain their decision.

"The Government's terse, bland and conclusory statement affords the court neither a sufficient basis to reach any conclusion, nor the opportunity to conduct any analysis of the Government's request for dismissal," wrote Garaufis, who gave the Justice Department until July 13 to submit more information.

The Adani case was brought in 2024 at the end of Democratic President Joe Biden's

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

• MAMATA'S LOYALISTS AND THE REBELS TAKE SWIPES AT EACH OTHER, WITH BJP WATCHING FROM SIDELINES

A tale of two Trinamools, a less-than-whole Opposition in West Bengal Assembly

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, June 27

AS THE first half of the inaugural West Bengal Assembly Session after the state polls drew to a close Thursday, the only real Opposition in the House, the Trinamool Congress, was busy — fighting itself, sort of.

The bitterness left behind by a rancorous split even meant that often, one TMC faction appealed to the good offices of the new BJP government to take

action against leaders of the other TMC faction.

At the same time, past friendships also lingered. So when Speaker Rathindra Bose said he was giving TMC rebel faction chief whip Akhruzzaman (the

MLA from Raghunathganj, Murshidabad) 8 minutes to speak on the Budget proposals, the latter clarified that he had given 2 minutes of his allotted time to the rival TMC faction's chief whip, Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay.

Among those left bewil-

dered was Sabina Yasmin, Akhruzzaman's colleague in the rebel ranks, who had laid claim to those 2 minutes openly.

Then there was the rebel TMC faction's walkout during Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari's reply to the Governor's address. The TMC rebels said they were protesting against the fact that post-poll violence against the party's supporters was not mentioned by the Governor.

Firhad Hakim, also in the rebel camp but once seen as a close lieutenant of Mamata Banerjee, urged her loyalists such



The first Budget session of the West Bengal Assembly after the BJP government came to power in the state began on June 18. FILE

as Kunal Ghosh and Sobhandeb to join them in the walkout.

When they didn't, Adhikari, who was himself in the TMC

once, took the side of the group that had walked out (thus fanning belief about the BJP's "hand" in engineering the TMC split). "The Good TMC walked out but the Kalighat Trinamool remained in the House," Adhikari quipped, Kalighat being a reference to Mamata's residential address.

Those in the Mamata camp argued that they had chosen to stay in the House rather than "flee" like the rebels. Plus, Kunal Ghosh added: "We thought Suwendu Adhikari is giving his first speech in the Assembly as

CM, and we should not walk out, but hear his address."

With the TMC rebellion seen as far from over — though heavily tilted right now in favour of the rebels, with 62 MLAs out of the party's 80 — which legislator was in what corner also remained up in the air. During Ghosh's address, BJP MLAs were heard asking which side of the TMC he was on. "The ink on my finger has not yet faded. I am not a traitor," Ghosh shot back.

BJP MLAs were among the most vociferous in defending

the rebel TMC faction's chosen leader in the House, Ritabrata Banerjee, over another of Ghosh's statements. With the Mamata TMC group also laying claim to the Leader of the Opposition post, Ghosh asked Speaker Bose: "How can someone accused in a rape case be made the LoP?"

Bose told Ghosh to refrain from such remarks, and Ghosh objected to the way he had been spoken to. BJP MLAs took off from there against Ghosh.

To the bemusement of his

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Destination Seychelles

Indian Navy's indigenously built Survey Vessel (Large), INS Ikshak, arrives at Port Victoria, Seychelles, as part of its operational deployment to the South West Indian Ocean region. The ship will participate in Seychelles's 50th National Day celebrations. PTI

Gaganyaan uncrewed test flight may be pushed, likely to impact launch of human space flight

Express News Service
Bengaluru, June 27

THE WAIT for Gaganyaan mission's manned flight may just get a little longer.

The first uncrewed test flight for the Gaganyaan mission — ahead of the proposed maiden Indian human space flight launch — could be pushed back up to the third quarter of 2027, ISRO chairman V Narayanan indicated on Saturday even as he stressed that efforts were on for a launch by the end of 2026.

With this, the launch of Gaganyaan mission's manned flight could be pushed back to 2028, as against 2027-end that the ISRO had indicated earlier this year.

"The Gaganyaan programme is a very important technology intensive mission and human safety is very important. We are already working on this programme for the launch of a human-rated rocket and keeping the people in a safe environment because in case there is any problem with the rocket, we have to save the crew..." the ISRO chairman said. Delivering the Air Marshal L M Katre Memorial Lecture organised by the Air Force Association in Bengaluru, the ISRO chairman, indicated on a slide in his presentation that the first un-manned flight for the Gaganyaan mission would be launched in the third quarter of 2027.

Narayanan said the uncrewed mission could happen in 2026 as well.

"We are supposed to do three uncrewed missions: We are working for the first uncrewed mission this year and once we get the results, we will get back to the crewed mission. The Gaganyaan continuation programme has been approved

After Tamil Nadu gas leak, Jharkhand workers allege confinement

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, June 27

NEARLY A week after an ammonia gas leak at a seafood export unit in Tamil Nadu claimed 15 lives, around 40 Adivasi workers from Jharkhand employed at the factory have alleged they have been confined to a private marriage hall by the district administration since the day of the incident.

The allegations have prompted the Jharkhand government's intervention. The June 21 ammonia leak at St Peter's Paul Seafoods Exports Private Limited in Tiruvallur district has so far affected 83 workers. The death toll has risen to 15 after Preeti Devi from Dhanbad district died on June 26. Among those waiting to return home is Bablu Kumar (20), from Dhanbad district, who alleged that nearly 42 workers from Jharkhand have been staying in the private building, around 10 km from the factory, since the day of the incident. "We are getting food and there is no problem with that, but we are not allowed to leave. There is no reason for our confinement. Over 25 police personnel are deployed outside. My wife is admitted to the hospital. Whenever I have to meet her, police accompany me, allow me to meet her for a few minutes and then bring me back. We want to return home," he alleged. Chundri Pingua (18), from West Singhbhum district, had travelled to Tamil Nadu with her elder sister in search of work. "We have been here for the last



Around 40 workers have been staying at the private marriage hall since June 21. EXPRESS

one week. I just want to get out of here and return home." Mukesh Kumar, from Gomoh in Dhanbad district said, "We were moved here on the day of the incident. Around 60-70 workers from Odisha have already been taken back after their state government coordinated with the TN administration. Over 70 workers from Assam are also being facilitated. We are waiting for the Jharkhand government. We only want to go back home," he said. Tiruvallur District Collector S Kavitha confirmed Preeti Devi's death. She said the district administration is coordinating with Jharkhand Labour Department and that the body will be airlifted to Jharkhand Saturday or Sunday after her family completes identification formalities. On the workers' movement, Kavitha said they would all be sent home soon. Shikha Lakra from the State Migrant Workers Cell said the department was in touch with the TN administration. "We expect to bring back all Jharkhand workers by Monday,"

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Rubio on Trump visit

India in his second term.

Asked about Trump's possible visit to India, Rubio said: "We're hoping that's what we're working towards — sometime early next year to have the President come. I think it's very positive. India is such a close partner and ally of the United States, and the relationship between the Prime Minister and the President couldn't be closer, which I think is really important in diplomacy."

India was due to host the Quad leaders' summit last year. Trump dropped his plans to visit India, marking a period of strained diplomatic relations amid punitive tariffs, visa curbs, and Trump's claims of resolving a border conflict with Pakistan.

"We look forward to re-engaging again in another Quad meeting very soon, and I look forward to returning before the end of the year and setting up a presidential visit in the early parts of next year," Rubio said.

Earlier this month, on the sidelines of the G7 Summit in Evian, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Trump held a bilateral meeting, marking their first face-to-face interaction in 16 months, where the two leaders discussed the India-US COM-PACT, the US-Iran peace agreement, and ongoing discussions over the bilateral trade agreement.

While the US extended an invitation for Modi to visit the US, Trump had also promised to visit India, saying the trip would

take place "sometime in the future."

A reciprocal visit by the US president has been a sticky diplomatic issue after PM Modi made a state visit to the US in February last year, soon after Trump's inauguration for his second term. Trump had last visited India in February 2020, during his first term.

Rubio also spoke about India and the US working together to address energy concerns amid the West Asia crisis. "India has been focused for a very long time on diversifying its sources of energy and so that trend will continue and we certainly would love to be a part of that," he said. "We think we have some solutions in that regard. But beyond that I would say that one of the reasons why the President has given peace a chance in the Middle East is the desire to see more fuel enter the marketplace for our allies."

"But I think the long-term solution really is to diversify their supplies and I know India has been talking to not just the United States, but in Venezuela, we're working very closely to increase their production capacity. I think they could serve... India is one of the few countries in the world with their ability to refine the heavy crude that Venezuela produces. So I think that's a thing we look to facilitate as well," he told IANS.

Venezuela has rapidly re-emerged as a vital crude oil supplier for India, overtaking major

traditional exporters like Saudi Arabia. Driven by the need to diversify away from Gulf routes and supply disruptions, Indian refiners resumed large-scale purchases of Venezuelan heavy crude.

Rubio underlined the common links. "It's the largest democracy in the world and the oldest democracy in the world. We have so much aligned and in common that we can build and work on together, our interests — on economics, on supply chains, on critical minerals, on energy, on security, on the freedom of navigation. These are all issues that bind us together. I have a very strong Indian-American community as well, which is an additional link between our countries," he said.

Soon after the Modi-Trump meet at Evian earlier this month, US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer had visited India, to finalise the interim trade agreement. Also talking to IANS on the trade deal, US Ambassador Sergio Gor said, "A lot of it is, the language has to be written. I was in those meetings 48 hours ago with Greer in Delhi, and we met with Commerce Minister Piyyush Goyal, who is a great friend of mine. It was very productive."

Gor, who is in Washington, said, "There are a handful of issues that remain. A lot of it now is on the language that ultimately both sides will sign. We are confident that over the next few weeks and months, it will get done."

Gor also spoke about Trump's visit to India in the in-

terview. "I don't have exact dates yet, but I just left the President. I was with him for several hours in the Oval Office... and one of the things the President asked about is, so when am I coming?," Gor said. "And so, he's very keen to come. The Prime Minister invited him, and so I think that will happen at some point."

Asked about the arc of India-US relations since he first arrived in India, Gor said, "One of the biggest anchors of this relationship is the bond between the President and the Prime Minister. That relationship has always remained strong. Sometimes the media likes to portray it as if something has happened, but the President and the Prime Minister are great friends. That friendship goes back years and will continue for years to come. Every time the two speak, great things happen."

On concerns in India over the H-1B visa process and the reported increase in hate crimes in the US, Gor said, "this is not targeted at India."

"The United States had to take stock of the whole immigration system, every kind of visa. Unfortunately, under previous administrations, our borders were wide open. That's something the President wanted to fix on day one. It's actually something the Prime Minister (Modi) relates to. When I listen to the Prime Minister speaking in India, he talks about no illegal migrants. We 100% agree with that. And so, none of this is targeted at India necessarily. It's one of the things that we needed to take stock of."

Seychelles

"Seychelles is a valued maritime partner and a close friend in the Indian Ocean. Looking forward to a productive visit aimed at further strengthening our longstanding ties and enhancing cooperation for the benefit of the people of our nations," the PM said on X upon landing.

Ahead of his departure from New Delhi, Modi said Seychelles is a valued maritime neighbour and a key partner in the Vision Mahasagar (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions) and India's shared commitment to the Global South.

Modi further said that he looks forward to the bilateral discussions aimed at further strengthening the enduring friendship. "Together, we will work to advance the progress of our peoples, and promote secur-

ity and prosperity in the Indian Ocean region," he said.

Later in the day, the PM handed over Fast Patrol Vessel *Lespwar*, ambulances and utility vehicles to the Seychelles Coast Guard. "The transfer of the Fast Patrol Vessel *Lespwar* to the Seychelles Coast Guard marks another important milestone in the growing India-Seychelles partnership in defence and maritime security. It is also the latest in a series of capability-building initiatives that reflect India's steadfast commitment to supporting the security priorities of Seychelles," Modi said in a post on X.

On Sunday evening, PM Modi will participate in the country's 50th national day celebrations as Guest of Honour. When Seychelles attained freedom on June 29, 1976, a contingent from the Indian Naval Ship, *INS Nilgiri*, took part in the Independence Day celebrations. This year as well, an Indian

Armed Forces contingent and two Indian Navy ships are participating in the event.

During the talks between two leaders Sunday, the two sides are expected to review the full spectrum of bilateral cooperation and exchange views on regional and international issues of mutual interest. Modi will also address the National Assembly of Seychelles and interact with members of the Indian diaspora.

PM Modi last visited Seychelles in 2015, while President Herminie visited India earlier this year. "Prime Minister Modi's visit reflects the long-standing friendship and enduring partnership between Seychelles and India, which have enjoyed diplomatic relations since Seychelles attained Independence in 1976," the office of the President of Seychelles said in a statement.

Seychelles is a cornerstone of India's Global South strategy,

serving as a critical maritime partner in the Western Indian Ocean. The island nation also helps India combat seaborne terrorism, piracy, and illegal fishing. Situated close to Africa, Middle East, and Asia, Seychelles serves as a vital counterweight against expanding influence in the Indian Ocean.

Seychelles's recent full membership in the Colombo Security Conclave further strengthens this shared commitment to a stable, secure Indo-Pacific. India is also a security provider in the Indian Ocean.

Around 5 percent of the Seychelles population comprises people of Indian origin (about 6,000); while another 9,000 non-resident Indians work in Seychelles, mostly in the construction sector, as shop assistants and professionals, according to government statistics. A majority of them belong to the Gujarati and the Tamil communities.

Adani

term. The decision to drop the charges marked the latest instance in which the Justice Department has sought to end a high-profile white collar criminal prosecution during Republican President Donald Trump's second term in the White House.

Legal experts say US judges have little discretion to compel prosecutors to continue with criminal cases they no longer wish to pursue, but the charges remain officially pending until Garauufs orders them dismissed.

A spokesperson for the Brooklyn US Attorney's office, which brought the charges, declined to comment.

Adani Group, Adani's company, has consistently denied wrongdoing. Adani himself has not appeared in US court to respond to the charges.

Robert Giuffra, a lawyer for Adani, referred to the letter he wrote to Garauufs on Wednesday, arguing the case should be dismissed because it was beyond the reach of US law and prosecutors would be unable to prove the alleged bribery in India.

Adani was charged in 2024 with agreeing to bribe Indian government officials so a subsidiary of his Adani Group could win approval to develop a solar energy plant, then misleading US investors by providing reassuring information about his company's anti-corruption practices.

The US Securities and Exchange Commission also brought civil charges. The SEC has reached a settlement in which Adani would pay \$6 million and his nephew, Sagar Adani, would pay \$12 million.

Adani Enterprises Limited has separately agreed to pay \$275 million to the US Treasury Department to settle alleged violations of Iran sanctions. REUTERS

Turtles

trafficked through Madhya Pradesh's rail network. They said repeat offenders appearing across multiple cases indicate established rackets may have been operating along the same corridors for years.

Based on that analysis, Madhya Pradesh is now preparing its first coordinated crackdown on wildlife trafficking through the railway network, moving beyond isolated interceptions towards a structured enforcement response.

"We are coordinating with all sister agencies like the state wildlife task force and railway officials to enhance the vigilance and checking of these trains and routes," ADG (Railways) Raja Babu Singh told *The Indian Express*. "We are taking this very seriously and are formulating a strategy and working on curbing wildlife trafficking."

Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests (Wildlife) L Krishnamurthy confirmed to *The Indian Express* that turtles seized in Madhya Pradesh "are trafficked primarily as exotic pets", while Singh described the data on wildlife trafficking through the railways as "alarming".

The seizures suggest traffickers overwhelmingly rely on passenger trains rather than railway cargo systems. All 654 animals recovered during the six-year period were found concealed in passengers' luggage.

The route

The turtles begin their journey far from Madhya Pradesh.

The Indian softshell and Indian flapshell turtle — both listed under Schedule I of the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, in the same protection category as tigers and elephants — inhabit the river systems of the Gangetic basin. STSF officers said poachers and fishermen capture them from stretches of the Ganga and its tributaries in Uttar

Pradesh before selling them to collectors, who aggregate consignments until they are large enough to move by train. Madhya Pradesh is where they next appear in official records, usually after being detected during random checks.

Wildlife officials said the seizures in the state reflect a much larger interstate trade.

"Freshwater turtles are the species we encounter most frequently in trafficking cases," a senior wildlife official said. "The animals are sourced from river systems in northern and eastern India and transported through the rail network. Madhya Pradesh is largely a transit corridor in these cases, with consignments moving towards markets in western India."

Different species feed different markets.

"Indian roofed turtles and star tortoises are primarily sought for the illegal pet trade," officials familiar with the investigations said. "We have seen networks linked to cities such as Indore, Dewas and Ujjain, with further movement towards Gujarat."

Softshell and flapshell turtles follow a different route. "There is demand in parts of eastern India, particularly Odisha and West Bengal. Investigators have also found evidence of turtles moving through Bangladesh, where they are valued for traditional medicinal uses before being trafficked further."

The rarest species face the most organised extraction.

"Species such as the Batagur turtle, which is critically endangered and survives in very limited stretches, including the Chambal river system, are particularly vulnerable as they are trafficked to exotic pet markets in Southeast Asia," a senior forest officer said.

The seizures also show the scale of operations growing sharply.

In March 2020, just one man was arrested at Sagar station carrying seven turtles in a fertiliser bag. In September 2023, four people were arrested at

Itarsi with 282 turtles aboard the Lucknow-Yashwantpur Express. In February 2026, eight people were found carrying 311 turtles on the Patna-Indore Express at Sant Hirdaram Nagar station on the outskirts of Bhopal — the largest wildlife seizure ever recorded on the state's railway network.

"The alarming part is these animals were detected after a foul smell emanated from them," a senior wildlife official said. "We have intelligence that these animals are largely trafficked now in small batches through the rail network and are largely undetected."

The challenges

The 2020 Sagar case illustrates another challenge. Charges were filed in May 2020, but the matter remains pending before a magistrate's court, with six of the eleven witnesses yet to be examined. The next hearing is scheduled for August 11, 2026.

Madhya Pradesh's central location makes it a key transit corridor. Enforcement records identify three principal trafficking routes through the state: Patna-Lucknow-Indore, Kanpur-Bhopal-Mumbai and Lucknow-Itarsi-Bengaluru. Any consignment moving from Uttar Pradesh towards Mumbai, Indore or Bengaluru must cross Madhya Pradesh.

Eight stations are identified as particularly vulnerable: Sant Hirdaram Nagar, Bhopal, Itarsi, Jabalpur, Khandwa, Katni, Indore and Ujjain. Officials said traffickers deliberately prefer passenger trains. "The rail network allows traffickers to move live animals over long distances while blending in with regular passengers," a wildlife enforcement official said. "Many seizures have involved animals concealed in personal luggage or sacks inside passenger coaches, including air-conditioned coaches."

Of the 24 people arrested in the cases analysed, 15 are categorised as sellers, seven as passengers and two as coach attendants.

Trust confirms

received resignation letters from the General Secretary of Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra (Trust), Champat Rai, and Trustee Anil Mishra. The Trust will consider these in its upcoming meeting."

"We are shocked, hurt and extremely saddened by the incidents in the Shri Ram temple (Ayodhya) heard during the past few days. Serving here as representatives of all Rambhaks and Ramsevak, we are committed to get a fair investigation done and assure the Rambhaks," it said. "The Trust assures those devotees who personally handed over silver bricks, ornaments, and other items to the Trust officials as offerings to Lord Shri Ram are safely available with proper records."

"Regarding the money received from the donation boxes in the temple, the Trust has lodged an FIR on the basis of the interim report handed over by the SIT constituted by the UP Government following the request of the Trust and legal action is being taken," it stated.

"We assure everyone that no such unfortunate situation will ever arise in the future. We will

insist that the accused face the strongest legal punishment. We will not let anti-social, irreligious and selfish elements succeed in their attempts to defame Sanatan Dharma," the statement said.

"We believe that these clouds will clear, the darkness will disappear, the truth-light of the sun will shine, and the powerful stream of Rambhakti will continue to flow uninterrupted," the Trust stated.

After the Trust was constituted in 2020, Champat Rai took the lead in management of the temple. He used to coordinate with the construction committee and the construction agency. His word was considered final, be it on the management of temple affairs, appointment of staff, distribution of assignments, duty of priests and internal security of the premises.

Trustee Anil Mishra was also actively involved in the management of the Ram temple. He came into national limelight after he and his wife performed rituals as 'Pradhan Yajman' (main hosts) during the January 2024 consecration of the temple idol.

Maharashtra exam

"The exam has been postponed to ensure transparency," the Council said.

The exam was to be held at 1028 centres this Sunday.

"Keeping in mind the malpractices during the NEET 2026 examination, all security measures had been taken by the Maharashtra State Council of Examination," the Council said.

Addressing the media, Additional Commissioner of Police Ashok Dudhe said that on Saturday morning, Thane City Police DCP (Zone II) Dr Pawan Bansod received a tip-off that three persons had come to a hotel in the Kogona area of Bhiwandi to sell the TET exam question paper.

The police team conducted a raid and found three persons in the hotel room with four sets of exam papers.

"We asked an official from the education department to confirm if these were the same papers that were to be used Sunday during the exams. After getting confirmation that these

were the same papers, we placed the three accused under arrest. While one accused is from Haryana, the other two are from Bihar. All three had come to the city from Delhi," Dudhe said.

Police identified the three men as Rajiv Kumar, Aakash Kumar and Dheeraj Singh.

According to an officer, the accused hoped to earn Rs 1.5 crore from the buyers who were to take delivery of the question papers.

While the police did not reveal the identity of the buyers or the "mastermind" of the gang, Dudhe said that of the three accused, one had paid the other to get employment with a Kendriya Vidyalaya in the past while another had taken the TET exam unsuccessfully earlier.

Dudhe said a 20-member SIT headed by DCP Pawan Bansod had been formed to investigate the matter and some of their teams had fanned out across the country to track down the other accused.

Mass poisoning bid

who had gathered for the Muharram procession. Officers are now questioning him to determine the motive.

Zinc phosphide, a rodenticide, is commonly used to kill rats. It is also used as a single-dose poison in agricultural fields.

DCP Jayant Meena said the case came to light after employees of a hospital reported that a man had been admitted with vomiting and severe stomach cramps after consuming a "painkiller" capsule allegedly being handed out at the procession. Suspecting something amiss, doctors alerted police who zeroed in on Premji.

"He told us he wanted to target the procession and harm them. He had ordered 30,000 capsules online and 50 kg of zinc phosphide. He added 1 gram of zinc phosphide to each capsule and was carrying around 14,000 capsules with him Friday for the purpose of distribution," DCP Meena said.

While handing out the cap-

sules to people in the procession, Premji told them the capsules were painkillers, Meena said.

People from across the city came to south Mumbai on Ashura, the tenth day of Muharram when Shias mourn the death of Imam Hussain, the Prophet's grandson, in the Battle of Karbala in 680 CE. The procession begins from the JJ flyover junction and ends at Arambaug cemetery.

According to police, Premji offered the capsules especially to those resorting to self-flagellation, telling them these were painkillers. The person admitted to the hospital after complaining of uneasiness had also been involved in self-flagellation.

According to police, Premji is a BBA graduate who runs a Pune paint company owned by his father. His mother and sister are in Iran and he has visited Iran and Iraq several times since 2019, including two visits in 2025. He is married but estranged from his wife who lives separately, an officer said.

2 TMCs

fellow legislators, Ghosh also went on to ask why the Adhikari government was not taking action against "corrupt" TMC MLAs among the rebel ranks, claiming that it is because they are close to the BJP. The corruption is allegedly linked to Mamata's term in power, something the united TMC once outrightly denied.

The Budget itself, which marks a clean departure from the Mamata government — in that the state can now count on a generous flow of funds from Centre — required calisthenics from the two TMC factions.

Rebel Dinen Roy (Kharagpur) called it "an unprecedented Budget". "We have to accept what is good as good. We are welcoming this Budget."

BJP MLA Sajal Ghosh, the next speaker, couldn't resist a swipe. "After hearing the speaker before me, I got confused. Is he

an Opposition MLA or ruling? I think he is just expressing that he is keen to join the BJP."

In the process, the Budget proposals were passed without changes.

Outside the House too, the TMC's state of tizzy prevailed. With the Speaker accepting Ritabrata as the LoP, the rebel faction has got pride of place in the chamber and hall room where legislators mingle. Which means loyalists such as Sobhandeb, Madan Mitra, Ghosh and Ashima Patra refused to enter the room, sitting either in front of the House doors, or in the corridors. Chattopadhyay's demand for a separate room has so far not been met.

A senior BJP MLA said, "We are relishing this because a fight between Opposition groups is always an advantage for us. They are attacking each other rather than the Treasury Benches."

However, he added, tongue firmly in cheek: "I must say, this is not healthy for the Assembly or for democracy."

YouTuber arrested for harassing girls, women on two-wheelers

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 27

RISK TO public safety; harassment of two-wheeler riders, mostly women and girls, and uploading videos of people on social media without consent — the Delhi Police is probing these allegations against a YouTuber, based out of the Capital, who was arrested on Friday after a case was filed against under Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and various sections of the BNS, said officers.

On his YouTube channel, with roughly 70,000 subscribers, creator Gurman Singh (32) has been allegedly uploading similar clips nearly everyday with a common motive, according to officers. He is seen hitting a two-wheeler rider from behind, mostly women, then he apologises initially by saying "Sorry Didi!" (sorry sister), and then

passes objectionable comments against them, said police. With such clips, he aimed to amplify his social media following, as per officers.

Police said Singh, a resident of Subhash Nagar in West Delhi, allegedly operated the social media accounts on Facebook and YouTube, where he uploaded videos passing objectionable comments against mostly women riders without their consent. The arrest came after parents of a girl filed a complaint against Singh for allegedly stalking their minor daughters on his two-wheeler, passing objectionable comments, and then uploading the clip on his channel without consent, police said on Friday.

The complainant approached the police on June 2, alleging that two unidentified motorcycle riders had intentionally rammed their scooter from behind. The riders then

allegedly stalked the girls, passed inappropriate remarks, and abused them, an officer said. A few days later, the complainant found videos of the incident uploaded on YouTube and Facebook.

During the initial scrutiny of the social media accounts, investigators found that the content largely had women riders and girls, police said. "The team carried out extensive digital forensic analysis, technical surveillance and examination of electronic evidence before tracing and apprehending Gurman Singh," said DCP Hareshwar Swami.

Singh told officers that he intentionally targeted women riders because such videos generated higher engagement and also gave him personal gratification, police said.

Action has been initiated to take down Singh's social media accounts, as per officers.

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 27

THE NATIONAL Investigation Agency (NIA) has filed a supplementary chargesheet against three more accused, including an absconding prime suspect, involved in the blast in a car near Red Fort in Delhi that killed 11 people on November 10 last year, officials said on Saturday.

In the supplementary chargesheet, the NIA has named Zameer Ahmad Ahanger, Tufail Ahmad Bhat and Muzafar Ahmad alias Faraz alias Zafar — all from Jammu and Kashmir.

With this, the total number of persons chargesheeted in the case has increased to 13, including prime accused Dr Umar Un Nabi, who was driving the car



The site of the blast near Red Fort in New Delhi. FILE

that exploded near Red Fort and died.

According to the NIA, absconding accused Muzafar Ahmed, a paediatrician holding MBBS and MD degrees, is the elder brother of co-accused Dr Adeel Ahmed Rather and a founding member of AGuH Interim, which the agency has described as an offshoot of Al-Qaeda, and one of the principal architects behind the

vehicle-borne improvised explosive device (VBIED) blast.

Investigators found Muzafar to be among the key conspirators behind the blast, along with co-accused Umar, Muzammil, Adeel and Mufti Irfan.

"He had attended a secret meeting at Eidgah in Srinagar in June 2022, where AGuH Interim terror module was formed," an NIA spokesperson said.

"Probe has also revealed that Muzafar played a central role in the manufacture, testing and storage of TATP-based IEDs at a clandestine facility allegedly run by Umer and Muzammil at Al-Falah University, Faridabad. A non-bailable warrant has been issued against him, and efforts are under way to trace and arrest him," the spokesperson said.

Zameer, the NIA said, described as an overground worker of AGuH Interim, remained in active contact with handlers and acted as a courier for arms, ammunition and cash for the module. Tufail, whom the agency described as a former overground worker of Lashkar-e-Taiba, allegedly served as the module's arms supplier.

The chargesheet stated that

Tufail procured an AK-47, a Krinkov rifle, a pistol, magazines and live ammunition via dead drops arranged by a handler and delivered them to the deceased main accused Dr Umar for Rs 3 lakh.

In the chargesheet filed before the NIA Special Court at Patiala House Courts in New Delhi, arrested accused Zameer and Tufail have been booked under sections 13, 18, 20, 23, 38 and 39 of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, and Sections 61(2), 147, 148 and 152 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

The agency said it had established linkages among the accused through forensic testing, geo-location mapping of conspiracy sites and financial trail analysis, and that further investigation in the case is continuing.

• Skywatch

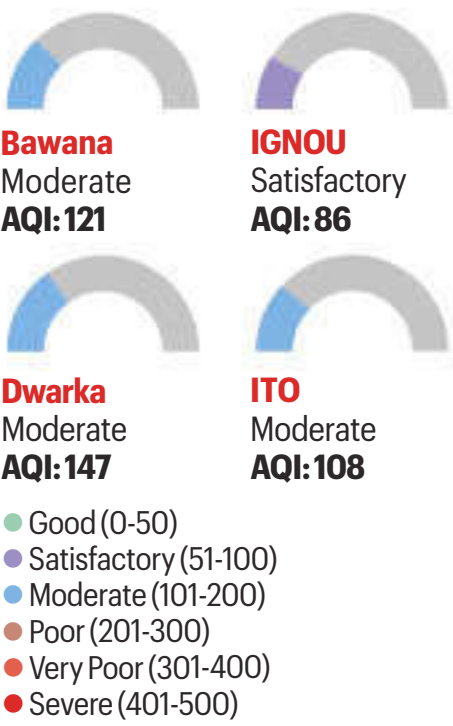
 **Forecast: June 28, 2026**
Partly cloudy sky. Possibility of thunder, strong winds
MAX: 39-41

3.8°C above normal

MIN: 28-30
0.1°C above normal

• **Sunrise:** 5:26 AM (June 29)
• **Sunset:** 7:23 PM (June 28)
• **Moonrise:** 5:27 PM (June 28)
• **Moonset:** 3:37 AM (June 29)

• AQI Tracker



EVENT MANAGEMENT PROFESSIONAL FROM GURGAON DIES TWO DAYS BEFORE TURNING 34

Man killed in hit-and-run, father says 'if accused took him to hospital, he could have been saved'

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 27

SARTHAK MATTOO, an employee of an event management company and a resident of Gurgaon's DLF phase 4, would have turned 34 on Saturday. But his family — still unable to cope with the news of his death — has to now learn to deal with his absence.

On Thursday, around 6:30 pm, he was returning home on his motorcycle when a speeding Thar allegedly hit him from behind near Rajokri flyover in Delhi.

As per the FIR, the bike — due to the impact of the collision — fell on the right side of the flyover. Identified as Apurv Singh (30), the SUV driver was arrested on Saturday, said officers.

DCP Amit Goel said, "A police team rushed to the spot after the accident while a medico-legal case was later received from the Indian Spinal Injuries Centre in Vasant Kunj, informing that the injured man had been brought to the hospital but was declared brought



The Thar and Sarthak Mattoo who died in the accident. ANI/EXPRESS



dead by doctors."

During the probe, investigators identified the vehicle involved in the accident as a Mahindra Thar registered in the name of a Bengaluru-based private company.

Police found that the vehicle had been leased to Sagar Saha (29), who hails from Bihar, and is employed with the company and currently posted in Bengaluru.

Saha, during questioning, told police that the SUV was being driven at the time of the accident by his friend, Apurv Singh (30), a resident of Ghazipur in Uttar Pradesh, who is employed with a private company. Sagar claimed he

was travelling in the passenger seat when the collision took place, police said.

The Mahindra Thar has been seized as part of the investigation. Police have apprehended Apurv Singh, and his medical examination was conducted at Safdarjung Hospital.

Speaking with *The Indian Express*, Sarthak's father, Surender Mattoo (66), a former logistics professional, said they only want justice now. "My son was working at an event management company in Gurgaon but had left for Noida for some work. I found the number of the

DCP from the website and he was kind enough to arrange a meeting today. I asked about the delay in conducting the blood alcohol tests of the driver (45 hours late)... he said specialised tests still exist to test for presence of trade amounts."

He added, "I was told the two accused are educated professionals, working with MNCs. They should have at least helped my son and taken him to the hospital instead of running away. That could have saved his life."

Sarthak, who had pursued a master's degree from London, would have turned 34 Saturday. For the 66-year-old father, one memory has become impossible to shake off — the expensive helmet he had bought for Sarthak and the promise he had extracted from him. "I got him a very expensive helmet and made him promise that he would always wear it so he remained safe. He was wearing the helmet, yet it couldn't save him."

Cap on number, registration must: Govt mulls policy for e-rickshaws

Valid E-rickshaw Compliance Certificate shall be made mandatory

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, June 27

EVEN AS e-rickshaws have been considered a lifeline for last-mile connectivity in the Capital, traffic and safety concerns have often been associated with the unregulated movement in several parts of the city.

With an aim to address these concerns, the Delhi government is planning to bring a policy to regulate the movement of e-rickshaws in the city and limit the number of vehicles on the road, according to officials.

Flagging that the rapid growth of e-rickshaws in the absence of regulation led to many accidents in the recent past, the Transport department said that the government is likely to cap the number of e-rickshaws in Delhi at 2.5 lakh. As per official data, over 2 lakh e-rickshaws are registered in the city. However, sources say the actual number on the ground is likely to be much higher.

"This mode of transit, which was started as an eco-friendly cheap transportation, has become a problem. The number of e-rickshaws in the city has increased rapidly, gradually slowing the traffic movements at key road stretches like Kashmir Gate ISBT and at several metro stations," said a senior official with the Transport department.

"To curb this, the government is considering a policy to regulate e-rickshaws. It might also be incorporated into the upcoming Electric Vehicle (EV) policy 2.0. We have seen that e-rickshaw drivers don't get the



Over 2 lakh e-rickshaws are registered in the city. FILE

vehicle's fitness checks done and register themselves with the Transport department," the official added. According to an internal document and proposed changes in the EV policy, "no registrations shall be issued beyond the cap, except where the cap is revised by the Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi (GNCTD)."

The e-rickshaw should be registered in the name of the owner, who should also be driving the vehicle, said officials.

"Only one vehicle will be registered on one e-rickshaw endorsed driving licence. Only Delhi residents shall be entitled to register e-rickshaw in the NCT of Delhi," explained another official.

Further, the Transport department also proposes to issue E-rickshaw Compliance Certificate (ECC) to all registered e-rickshaws in Delhi, including existing e-rickshaws possessing a valid fitness certificate. Possession of a valid ECC shall be mandatory for all e-rickshaws operating in the Capital, said officials.

SML MAHINDRA LIMITED
(Formerly SML ISUZU Limited) | CIN: L50101PB1983PLC005516
Regd. Office & Works: Village Asron, Distt. Shahid Bhagat Singh Nagar (Navanshahr) Punjab-144 535. Phone: 01861-270155.
Corporate Office: 1st Floor, T7 Tech Park, C-119, Industrial Area Phase-7, Sector 73, Mohali, SAS Nagar, Punjab-160055. Phone: 0172-2647700-02; 0172-4155901
Email: investors@smlmahindra.com | Website: https://smlmahindra.com/

NOTICE OF 42nd ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING AND REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION
Notice is hereby given that the 42nd Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Company will be held on **Tuesday, 21st July, 2026 at 11:30 A.M. (IST)** through Video Conferencing (VC) / Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM) to transact the business as set out in the Notice of AGM. The venue of the meeting shall be deemed to be the registered office of the Company i.e Village Asron, Distt. Shahid Bhagat Singh Nagar, (Navanshahr), Punjab-144533.
The Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") vide its Circular No(s) 14/2020 dated 8th April, 2020, 17/2020 dated 13th April, 2020, 20/2020 dated 5th May, 2020 and 09/2023 dated 25th September, 2023 and 09/2024 dated 19th September, 2024 and 03/2025 dated 22nd September 2025 permitted the companies for holding the Annual General Meeting ("AGM") through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM"), without the physical presence of the Members at a common venue. In compliance with the provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act"), SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("SEBI Listing Regulations"), and the SEBI Circulars and SEBI Circulars, the 42nd AGM of the Company is being held through VC / OAVM. Members attending the 42nd AGM through VC / OAVM shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.
In accordance with the aforementioned Circulars, electronic copies of the Notice of AGM and Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 have been sent today, i.e. on **27th June, 2026, Saturday**, to all the Members whose e-mail IDs are registered with the Company / Depository Participants/RTA. The Annual Report including Notice of AGM is also available on the website of the Company <https://smlmahindra.com/>, on the website of BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com, on the website of National Stock Exchange of India Limited (NSE) at www.nseindia.com and also on the website of NSDL www.evoting.nsdl.com.
Further, in accordance with Regulation 36 (1) (b) of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, a letter providing a web-link for accessing the Annual Report 2025-26 has been sent to those members who have not registered their e-mail IDs.
In compliance with the provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 including Rules framed thereunder and the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Company is providing to its Members the facility to exercise their right to vote at 42nd Annual General Meeting (AGM) by electronic means (remote e-voting). The facility for voting through electronic means shall also be made available during the AGM, for those Members who have not cast their vote by remote e-voting. The facility of remote e-voting and voting through electronic means during the AGM will be provided by National Securities Depository Limited ("NSDL"). For details relating to remote e-voting and e-voting during the AGM, please refer to the Notes forming part of the Notice of AGM. All the Members are informed that:
1. The business as set forth in the Notice of AGM may be transacted through voting by electronic means.
2. The remote e-voting facility shall commence on **17th July, 2026, Friday (9:00 AM) (IST)** and end on **20th July, 2026, Monday (5:00 PM) (IST)**.
3. The Board, at its meeting held on 20th April 2026, has recommended Final Dividend of 235% (Rs. 23.50/- per share). The Dividend, subject to the approval of the Members, will be paid after 21st July, 2026, Tuesday, to those Members whose names appear on the Register of Members as on the **Record Date i.e. 3rd July, 2026, Friday**.
4. Members may note that pursuant to the Income Tax Act, 1961, as amended by the Finance Act, 2020, dividend is taxable in the hands of the Members. The Company shall, therefore, deduct Tax at Source ("TDS") at the time of making payment of dividend. In order to enable us to determine the appropriate TDS rate, as applicable, the shareholders are requested to submit the requisite documents in accordance with the provisions of the Income Tax Act, 1961 at investors@smlmahindra.com by **10th July, 2026, Friday**.
5. The cut-off date for determining the eligibility to vote by remote e-voting or voting through electronic means during the AGM is **14th July, 2026, Tuesday**.
6. The remote e-voting shall not be allowed beyond the said date and time. Once the vote on a resolution is cast by the member, it cannot be changed subsequently.
7. The members attending AGM who have not cast their vote by remote e-voting shall be eligible to cast their vote through e-voting during the AGM. Members who will cast their vote by remote e-voting may attend the AGM but shall not be eligible to vote at the AGM. The instructions for joining the AGM through VC / OAVM are provided in the Notes forming part of the Notice of AGM.
8. A person, whose name appears in the Register of Members/Beneficial Owners (whether holding shares in physical form or in demat form) as on the cut-off date i.e. **14th July, 2026, Tuesday** only shall be entitled to vote, either through remote e-voting or through e-voting during the AGM.
9. Any person, who acquires shares of the Company and becomes member after dispatch of the Notice and holding shares as on cut-off date i.e. **14th July, 2026**, may obtain User ID and password by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.com or to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent at helpdeskdelhi@mcsregistrars.com.
If the member is already registered with NSDL for e-voting, then he/she can use his/her existing user ID and password for casting the vote through remote e-voting.
10. In case of any query relating to voting by electronic means, Members may refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) and e-voting user manual at the downloads section of NSDL's website www.evoting.nsdl.com or may send a request at evoting@nsdl.com or contact Ms. Pallavi Mahatre, at- 3rd Floor, Naman Chamber, Plot C-32, G-BLOCK, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra East, Mumbai-400051 (palavi@nsdl.com) or call at toll free no.: 022-48867000.
11. Members are requested to register/update their E-mail address/Bank account details of their KYC details with their Depository Participant(s) if they are holding shares in Demat mode and with Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent-M/s. MCS Share Transfer Agent Limited, at helpdeskdelhi@mcsregistrars.com if they are holding shares in physical mode.
For SML MAHINDRA LIMITED
PARVESH MADAN
Company Secretary | ACS-31266
Place: Mohali, Punjab
Date: 27.06.2026

No Eligible Voter to be excluded and No Ineligible Person to be included



SIR
in Delhi

SPECIAL INTENSIVE REVISION- 2026

Special Intensive Revision (SIR) 2026 Schedule

Phase	Period
House-to-House Visits by BLOs	30.06.2026 to 29.07.2026
Publication of Draft Electoral Roll	05.08.2026
Period for Filing Claims & Objections	05.08.2026 to 04.09.2026
Notice Phase / Disposal of Claims & Objections	05.08.2026 to 03.10.2026
Publication of Final Electoral Roll	07.10.2026

**What is SIR?**

Special Intensive Revision (SIR) is a house-to-house verification exercise undertaken by the Election Commission of India to verify eligible electors and ensure that the Electoral Roll is pure, accurate and updated.

Why is SIR Being Conducted?

- 18+** To include all eligible citizens aged 18 years and above.
- To remove Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate and Ineligible entries.
- To ensure the transparency and accuracy of the Electoral Roll.

Key Features of SIR

- House-to-House verification by the BLOs.
- Every Eligible elector must fill and submit the Enumeration Form.
- Electors are advised to update their Current photograph.
- Electors are advised to update/share their mobile number.

How to Fill the Enumeration Form?

- Please fill in the Enumeration Form provided by the BLO and enter your own details or those of your parents or grandparents, as available in the last SIR.
- Submit filled Enumeration Form to the BLO
- The Enumeration Form can also be filled up online

Website : voters.eci.gov.in

Important Information

- SIR is a time-bound exercise and requires active participation of all citizens.
- Information collected will be used only for Electoral Roll purposes.
- For assistance, contact your BLO, call Voter Helpline 1950, or use the "Book a call with BLO" facility available on ECINet and voters.eci.gov.in.

Download and get information.**ECINet app** voters.eci.gov.in

**Download ECINet App** and easily access voter services or check your name in last SIR.
Download Now

**Voter Helpline No. 1950**

Contact concerned District Election Help Desk

Watch the video and read the FAQs for information.

Forms Related Information:

- Form 6** - New Voter Enrollment.
- Form 7** - Deletion of Name.
- Form 8** - Shifting / Correction / Replacement of EPIC.

Chief Electoral Officer, Delhi
Old St. Stephen's College Building, Kashmir Gate, Delhi - 110006

Websites: www.ceodelhi.gov.in, voters.eci.gov.in
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epaper.indianexpress.com

Weeks after shanties razed, Surat civic body shifts affected residents to temporary shelter

Kamal Saiyed
Surat, June 27

NEARLY A month after over 100 families of Nasirnagar in Ved Darwaja area of Surat were rendered homeless after a controversial demolition on “private land” they had allegedly encroached for nearly four decades, the Surat Municipal Corporation (SMC) on Saturday shifted around 150 persons to a community hall nearby.

Earlier, 26 of the residents moved the Gujarat High Court (HC) seeking justice and rehabilitation, claiming that they were not issued any notices before the demolitions. The HC heard the matter on Thursday and sought an explanation from the municipal and police authorities while also directing representatives of Torrent Power Ltd to remain present in the court on Monday, when the matter will be heard next.

The demolitions were carried out on May 30, 31 and June 1, clearing 106 structures.

Municipal Commissioner M Nagarajan told *The Indian Express* on June 8 that his officers



Around 150 people have been shifted to a community hall — around 1.5 km away from their previous residence. *EXPRESS*

had gone there only to demarcate a road. “The land is owned by a private party who has contributed a portion under the town planning scheme for a road. Our team went to the spot for land marking (demarcation) the road area. As per the rules, a notice is to be issued to the inhabitants of slums and the slums are later demolished after hearing from them.”

The residents, however, have claimed they were not issued any notice. On June 11, Additional City Engineer and Central Zone deputy commissioner Ashish Naik claimed in a video that his team had carried out the

demolitions, “to clear a road”. Around June 20, he changed his stance and said the demolition was done by municipal officials. Nagarajan declined to comment further on the matter, saying it was before the HC.

“We set up a probe team headed by a Deputy Commissioner rank official of the SMC. They have given us a primary report in which statements from some of the officials are still pending... If any of our officials are found guilty... we will take necessary action against them as per the rules...” Nagarajan said.

The 150 people shifted to the municipal corporation-owned

Bharimata community hall, around 1.5 km away from Nasirnagar, include the 26 petitioners, sources told *The Indian Express*.

Salma Khatun Shaikh, 70, who lost her home in the demolition, said, “I have been staying in Nasirnagar for the past 50 years. I had a house with a ground floor plus two upper floors. The land is owned by a private person, so how did the SMC and police carry out demolitions? My children, who were at home, were taken out of the house and it was razed.”

She added, “Since the past 29 days, we have been living on the debris in the open sky with my small grandchildren...”

The bare community hall had no other facilities except toilets, which Shaikh complained were “dirty”. However, by Saturday evening, Surat Municipal officials had made arrangements for bedsheets, mattresses and water, apart from cleaning of the toilet blocks.

The SMC’s additional city engineer and Zonal Chief (Rander Zone) MD Chavda said, “We will provide all required facilities for the affected people.”

Arvind Kejriwal promises grand Sita temple in Amritsar

Express News Service
Amritsar, June 27

AAP NATIONAL convenor Arvind Kejriwal on Saturday announced the construction of a grand temple dedicated to Mata Sita and Luv and Kush in Amritsar, expansion of the Mukh Mantri Teerath Yatra Yojna, staging of theatrical play *Humare Ram* across Punjab, and organising devotional event ‘Ek Shaam Bhagwan Shivji Ke Naam’ across all 22 cities of Punjab.

Kejriwal made the announcement after he, accompanied by CM Bhagwant Mann, joined devotees for a bhajan during the ‘Ek Shaam Bhagwan Shivji Ke Naam’ event in Amritsar. Kejriwal said the Punjab government organised the event in Amritsar after receiving an overwhelming response to a similar evening in Jalandhar. “This is the first government to hold bhajan evenings in this manner to strengthen devotion...” he said, and announced that the event would now be organised in all 22 cities of Punjab.

AMID TEMPLE DONATION ROW

Will develop Ayodhya as Siyaram-Dham: SP chief

Lalmani Verma
Lucknow, June 27

AMID THE controversy over alleged misappropriation of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav on Saturday promised to develop Ayodhya into a peerless and exemplary religious city — ‘Siyaram-Dham’ — if his party comes to power.

In a post on X, Yadav said, “With devotion and integrity, we take this pledge that by forming a new government, we will develop ‘Ayodhya’ into a peerless and exemplary religious city, where devotees from across the world will experience the unparalleled essence of true spirituality.”

He said, “With the blessings of the lord, we will restore and flourish ‘sanatan maan’ of Ayodhya as ‘Siyaram Dham’ — with faith and devotion, unwavering belief, and genuine sentiment. Through this, we shall also reestablish the traditional pride and



Will also reestablish traditional pride and rights of the residents of Ayodhya: Akhilesh Yadav

rights of the residents of Ayodhya.”

Akhilesh’s promise comes a day after UP CM Yogi Adityanath warned the SP and Congress not to “test the patience of Ram bhakts” by raising questions on the alleged embezzlement of temple donations.

Speaking to reporters after attending a wedding in Azamgarh on Saturday, Akhilesh said the theft of offerings made to the Ram Temple is a matter of concern. “Ayodhya is a place of faith for followers of the Sanatan

tradition... Following reports of the theft, the government was compelled to bow to pressure and constitute an SIT. However, the fact that the SIT’s report was submitted to a specific individual raises questions,” the SP chief said.

Akhilesh alleged that “for the BJP, money is the only religion”. “People’s faith has been played with,” he said, and asked how CM Yogi Adityanath could be unaware of the theft of offerings. “Where was his intelligence network,” he questioned.

Stepping up its attack in the Centre, the Congress on Saturday questioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s silence on the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ayodhya Temple.

Addressing a press conference, Congress spokesperson Akhilesh Prasad Singh said the investigation of this entire matter should be conducted under the supervision of a sitting Supreme Court judge because the corruption is “deep-rooted”. **WITH PTI INPUTS**

EXPRESS special

How a marathon is turning rural Kashmir into a community fitness movement

Over 1,000 runners are expected to participate in ZoonRun today

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, June 27

AWAY FROM the hustle of the city streets, the quiet roads of Baramulla are preparing for an unusual sight — hundreds of runners racing through the ancient town, its village orchards and paddy fields.

On Sunday, over 1,000 runners, men, women and children, are expected to participate in the ZoonRun, a marathon that attempts to make distance running a “rural movement” and encourage fitness beyond the valley’s urban centres.

The brainchild of two childhood friends, Chandeeep Singh



People from all walks of life in Baramulla have come forward to help organise the event. *FILE*

and Tufail Anayat, the effort has gained mass traction and support, and is set to become the first marathon outside Srinagar.

“The objective of this run is to inculcate and celebrate community fitness,” says Singh. “It is an exercise in community inclusion in sports and a

healthy lifestyle.”

ZoonRun got its name from a failed attempt at a marathon by some young runners from Baramulla. “One day, we decided to have a run at night. It was going to be a full moon night and we called it ZoonRun (Zoon means moon in Kashmir),” says Singh. “But as fate would have it, it rained heavily that night and we couldn’t go out for a run. It lingered on our minds till we came up with the idea of this marathon.”

Over 1,000 runners have registered for the marathon, including around 50 children below the age of 10. The run has been divided into four age categories and three distances — 21, 10 and 5 km.

The 21-kilometre run, which starts from Baramulla town and passes through the green fields of surrounding villages, will be participated in by several top athletes from Jammu and Kashmir, including Hans Raj, Yahya Khan and Bhushan

Singh. Air Force veteran and amputee S K S Kulbir will also participate.

“This is the first time I’m seeing a marathon organised outside Srinagar with local effort,” said professional athlete Hans Raj. “There are runners from outside the state who are participating in the event and it would go a long way in creating awareness and motivating people about fitness and lifestyle.”

The town of Baramulla is enthusiastic about the marathon, and people from all walks of life have come forward to help organise the event.

“It is a community event and our community has supported us in all ways possible,” says Tufail Anayat, one of the organisers. “You see, our co-sponsor is from Baramulla. All our sponsors are small-time businessmen from Baramulla, Sopore and surrounding areas. It is an effort by the community, for the community.”

Video row: SGPC resolution seeks FIR against Mann

Kamaldeep Singh Brar
Amritsar, June 27

THE SHIROMANI Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) on Saturday endorsed the Akal Takht’s edict declaring Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann ‘Guru Dokhi’ (anti-Guru) and ‘Khalsa Panth Virodhi’ (anti-Khalsa Panth) over a controversial video and passed a resolution demanding his immediate resignation and registration of criminal case against him.

“This is a grave mistake by the CM, one that is unforgivable. Bhagwant Singh Mann has lost the moral right to remain in office and must resign immediately,” the SGPC said in a statement after a special general meeting.

The meeting, led by SGPC president Harjinder Singh Dhami, was attended by Sikh religious leaders, jathedars, representatives of the five Takhts, and granthis of Sri Harmandir Sahib.

Reading from the resolution, Dhami said the purported video of Mann has “caused massive outrage and anger across the entire Sikh world.”

The Akal Takht edict against Mann came on June 15 after the supreme temporal seat of the Sikhs claimed that the video, purportedly showing a man resembling Mann and indulging in acts deemed sacrilegious by the religious body, was found to be “authentic” by two forensic laboratories. Mann has denied the allegation and claimed that the person seen in the clip was wearing a mask resembling his face.

Addressing the media, Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Kuldeep Singh Gargaj said that Akal



Mann has lost the moral right to remain in office, SGPC said

Takht Sahib is the supreme authority for Sikhs, and obeying its directives is every Sikh’s duty. He also termed Mann’s challenge to Akal Takht an affront to the institution.

The SGPC general house took serious note of what it described as a confrontational policy adopted by Mann towards the Akal Takht. “In order to defend himself, the CM used lies, government officials, and official influence to get a fake report prepared from a laboratory in Gurgaon — the truth of which has now come before the Sangat,” read the resolution.

राष्ट्रीय औषधीय शिक्षा एवं अनुसन्धान संस्थान कोलकाता
National Institute of Pharmaceutical Education and Research Kolkata
Department of Pharmaceuticals, Ministry of Chemicals & Fertilizers, Govt. of India
औषध विभाग, रसायन एवं उर्वरक मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार
Chunilal Bhawan, 168, Manikata Main Road, Kolkata-700054,
Website: www.niperkolkata.edu.in E-mail: info.office@niperkolkata.edu.in Tel: 033 23200086

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The 14th Convocation of the institute will be held on **1st July 2026**. All the graduating **M.S./M.Tech/Ph.D** students who have fulfilled the requirements of their degrees in the academic year 2025-26 are informed to register online through the link provided on the institute's website.
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(स्वास्थ्य एवं परिवार कल्याण मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार के तत्वावधान में एक संवैधानिक निकाय)
(A Statutory Body under the Aegis of Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, GOI)
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C	9,88,801	5,40,000
D	6,59,158	5,40,000
E, F	3,29,579	2,70,000
G, H	3,29,579	1,62,000

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कॉलोनी कैटेगरी	पहले राशि (₹)	अब राशि (₹)
A, B	57,67,871	8,91,000
C	41,19,896	8,91,000
D	24,72,002	8,91,000
E, F	16,47,974	4,45,500
G, H	16,47,974	2,67,300

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कॉलोनी कैटेगरी	पहले राशि (₹)	अब राशि (₹)
A, B	54,93,195	12,59,850
C	43,94,706	12,59,850
D	27,46,597	12,59,850
E, F	16,69,306	6,29,925
G, H	16,69,306	3,77,955

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Tagore played an instrumental role in the Congress's power-sharing talks with the TVK

Manickam Tagore made new Tamil Nadu Congress chief

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, June 27

THE CONGRESS leadership on Saturday appointed Lok Sabha Whip B Manickam Tagore as president of the Tamil Nadu Congress, replacing K Selvaperunthagai in a move that reflects not merely a change of faces but a decisive shift in the party's political instincts after Tamil Nadu's post-election upheaval.

The appointment comes weeks after the Congress broke its long-standing alliance with the DMK, joined Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vетtri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government and became part of a Tamil Nadu government for the first time in nearly six decades.

If Selvaperunthagai represented continuity with the DMK, Tagore became one of the earliest and loudest advocates of leaving it. Long before the Assembly election, Tagore openly argued the Congress should seek a larger political role instead of remaining a junior ally. He demanded a greater share of Assembly seats, raised questions over sharing power, and was among the first Congress leaders to suggest the party should explore an alliance with Vijay's TVK. At the time, those arguments unsettled both the DMK and sections within his own party.

Party leaders say the leadership change had been expected for weeks. A section of Congress leaders in Tamil Nadu, along with senior figures in New Delhi, had grown increasingly dissatisfied with Selvaperunthagai's stewardship. While Tagore and several others argued the Congress should reposition itself alongside the TVK, Selvaperunthagai remained committed to preserving the DMK alliance.

"He was one of those people who had played a pivotal role in securing power for the Congress in Tamil Nadu. That has played a role in Tagore's elevation to state president," said a state Congress leader.

The disagreement gradually evolved into a larger contest over the future direction of the party. Even after the Congress entered the TVK government, Selvaperunthagai often appeared politically out of step with his own organisation. On Friday, a day before his replacement, he criticised Vijay for mocking former CM M K Stalin in the Assembly, and questioned the government's administrative performance despite the Congress being a coalition partner.

The criticism only reinforced the perception that his tenure had reached its conclusion.

Can Vaiko go with Vijay? Buzz gains ground as MDMK snaps DMK ties

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, June 27

FEW POLITICIANS in Tamil Nadu have changed alliances as often, or as dramatically, as Vaiko. Over three decades, the fiery orator has crossed political rivers that once seemed impossible to ford, only to return later by another bridge. On Saturday, the 81-year-old Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (MDMK) chief added another turn to that long journey, announcing that his party was withdrawing from the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance after nine years.

The decision, adopted unanimously by the party's General Council, formally ended an alliance that began in 2017. Yet the announcement also exposed a familiar contradiction in Vaiko's politics: while the party has walked out of the alliance, parts of the party appear unwilling to leave with him.

The MDMK's two legislators, elected on the DMK's symbol in the Assembly polls earlier this year, have refused to resign

from the Assembly. Sirkazhi MLA Senthil Selvan stayed away from the party meeting altogether, resigned from the MDMK and announced that he would remain with the DMK. Kadayannallur MLA T M Rajendran has also reportedly expressed his unwillingness to vacate his seat. For a party built around Vaiko's personality, it is an unusually public display of dissent.

The resolution adopted by the MDMK said the party had remained with the DMK out of ideological commitment to prevent "communal political forces" from gaining ground in Tamil Nadu and to uphold the principles of the Dravidian movement. But it alleged that during the 2026 Assembly election, attempts were made to dilute the MDMK's independent identity despite its 32-year political history.

It also referred to the post-election efforts to install the AIADMK in power with support from the DMK after the fractured verdict, arguing that such negotiations had rendered the alliance's claims



Once considered a Karunanidhi protege, Vaiko broke away from DMK in 1994 after objecting to the elevation of Stalin within the party.

of ideological politics meaningless.

The party resolved that it would decide its future electoral alliances "at the appropriate time". That carefully chosen phrase has already fuelled speculation that the MDMK could eventually align with Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's TVK, although the party has made no formal announcement.

For the DMK, the exit adds to an erosion that has steadily unfolded since the Assembly

election defeat. The Congress, Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) and Viduthalaі Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) have already joined the TVK-led government. The CPI and CPI(M) now extend only outside support to the TVK government but are clearly outside of the DMK's circle.

Yet Vaiko's departure is also deeply personal. His relationship with the DMK has always oscillated between affection and estrangement. Once considered among the party's brightest young speakers and one of M Karunanidhi's political proteges, Vaiko dramatically broke away from the DMK in 1994 after objecting to the elevation of M K Stalin within the party. The split triggered intense emotional reactions among cadres; several supporters reportedly died by suicide in the aftermath, believing the party's future had been irreversibly altered.

Vaiko founded the MDMK the same year, carrying with him a section of district secretaries and a reputation as one of Tamil politics' most electrify-

ing campaigners. His politics since then has resembled a restless orbit around Tamil Nadu's larger parties. In recent elections, the MDMK has played the role of a junior ally, contesting a handful of seats and never winning more than six Assembly seats in 2006 and four Lok Sabha seats in 2004.

He allied with the BJP under Atal Bihari Vajpayee in 1998 and remained with the National Democratic Alliance even after the AIADMK withdrew support and toppled the Vajpayee government in 1999. Gingee Ramachandran of the MDMK became a Union minister in that government.

Vaiko later joined hands with the DMK, left over seat-sharing disputes, aligned with Jayalalithaa and the AIADMK despite having been jailed for 19 months under the Prevention of Terrorism Act (POTA) during her government, returned to and moved away from the DMK again, boycotted elections in 2011, rejoined the BJP-led alliance in 2014, and eventually entered the DMK-led front in 2017.

Defections a ploy against Fadnavis, says Uddhav

Mumbai: Days after six Lok Sabha MPs from Shiv Sena (UBT) switched to Eknath Shinde-led Shiv Sena, party chief Uddhav Thackeray on Saturday alleged that Union Home Minister Amit Shah was behind the defections, claiming the move was aimed at preventing CM Devendra Fadnavis from emerging as a future contender for PM's post.

Addressing party workers in Hingoli, Thackeray said the defections were not part of "Operation Tiger" but "Operation Devendra". He said, "There is a possibility that... Fadnavis can be in the race of becoming Prime Minister and therefore moves have started from now itself to cut his wings." ENS

IPS OFFICER UNDER FIRE OVER REMARKS

Quit if you want to praise RSS publicly: MNS chief

Express News Service
Pune, June 26

MAHARASHTRA NAVNIRMAN Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray on Saturday slammed newly appointed Nagpur Police Commissioner Vishwas Nangare Patil over his speech praising the RSS, saying that his loyalty should lie solely with the police force.

"If you have an affinity for the Sangh, keep it to yourself; or if you wish to speak publicly, resign from service and join the Sangh or the BJP," the MNS chief said in a social media post.

"It seems IPS officer Shri Vishwas Nangare Patil is

Vijay picks producer as TN's Delhi envoy, sparks 'conflict of interest' controversy

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, June 27

WHEN ACTOR-TURNED-CHIEF Minister C. Joseph Vijay travelled to Raj Bhavan in May to stake claim to form the Tamil Nadu government, one of the men walking quietly beside him drew little public attention. A month later, that man has found himself at the centre of the state's latest political debate.

On Friday, the Tamil Nadu government appointed K Venkata Narayana, chairman of the Bengaluru-based KVN Group and producer of Vijay's unreleased final film *Jana Nayagan*, as the state's Special Representative in New Delhi – a post carrying a Cabinet rank and traditionally entrusted with navigating the often complicated relationship between the state and Union government.

A government order issued by Chief Secretary M Sai Kumar sanctioned the creation of the temporary post for one year. The appointment drew criticism from Opposition parties, not merely because Narayana comes from outside politics, but also because of his close association with TVK chief Vijay.

The Special Representative functions as Tamil Nadu's political bridge with New Delhi. Beyond coordinating meetings between the CM and Union ministers, the office follows up on infrastructure projects, central funding, policy matters and parliamentary coordination. While states usually appoint senior IAS officers as Resident Commissioners for administrative functions, Tamil Nadu has historically reserved this role for experienced politicians.

This time, the government has chosen a businessman. Narayana heads the diversified KVN Group, with interests in real estate and entertainment. A former Chief Executive Officer of Prestige Group, he founded KVN Productions in 2020, the company now producing *Jana Nayagan*, the film widely ex-



K Venkata Narayana (above) is producer of Vijay's unreleased final film *Jana Nayagan*

pected to remain Vijay's final appearance on screen before entering full-time politics.

DMK Rajya Sabha member P Wilson said appointing a film producer to such a post would "belittle" its stature. He argued that the office exists to safeguard Tamil Nadu's interests before the Union government by coordinating with ministries, assisting MPs during parliamentary sessions and ensuring smooth engagement between the state and Centre.

BJP Tamil Nadu president Nainar Nagendran questioned how "a person close to Karnataka" could effectively represent Tamil Nadu's interests in New Delhi, describing the decision as "a great betrayal" of the people of the state. The AIADMK's IT wing similarly questioned whether the government was functioning as a "proxy" of the Congress government in Karnataka.

Inside the TVK, however, the appointment is viewed rather differently. A senior TVK leader described the decision as "nothing but gratitude". "This is not considered a lucrative position inside the party," the leader said. "It is a gesture towards someone who stood firmly behind the CM during one of the most difficult periods surrounding *Jana Nayagan*. He never sought publicity. He stood with him."

After BJP came to power, every officer became RSS: Vijayvargiya

Bhopal: Madhya Pradesh Urban Development Minister Kailash Vijayvargiya said Saturday that after the BJP came to power, many government officers and employees have begun identifying themselves with the RSS.

Addressing a programme in Bhopal, Vijayvargiya said of officers posted under the BJP government often tell him about their association with the organisation.

"After our government came to power, everyone became associated with the Sangh. Every officer became part of the Sangh," he said. ENS

• FEW PARTIES HAVE FOUGHT WITH THEMSELVES AS CONSISTENTLY AS THE CONGRESS AND PREVAILED. THERE IS ONE BIG REASON WHY

Congress's Punjab story: Eight decades of infighting, eight decades of resilience



NORTHERN LIGHTS

BY MANRAJ GREWAL
SHARMA

A WEEKLY DISPATCH ON THE POLITICS AND IDEAS SHAPING NORTH INDIA

LAST SUNDAY, when BJP national president Nitin Nabin asked why the Congress continues to find acceptance in Punjab despite the scars of 1984, he touched upon one of the state's enduring political mysteries.

After all, this is a state where memories of Operation Blue Star and the anti-Sikh killings that followed remain deeply embedded in the collective

consciousness. Yet, the Congress returned to power in 1992 under Beant Singh.

That paradox has repeated itself throughout Punjab's political history. Few parties have fought with themselves as consistently as the Congress and prevailed. The party dominated politics in undivided Punjab from 1947 to 1966 and after its trifurcation in 1966, won five of the 13 Assembly elections until 2022. It has given the highest number of Chief Ministers to the state: 12 distinct faces, including its first woman CM, against three by the Akali Dal, which formed the government seven times in this period.

The story of a quarrelsome Congress began right after Independence. Barely had the dust of Partition settled when Congress leaders were at each other's throats. The state's first CM, the genteel, polite-to-a-fault doctor-turned-freedom fighter Gopi Chand Bhargava, a Gandhian who spun his own

clothes, found himself locked in a bitter struggle with Bhim Sen Sachar, the legal eagle who would later become CM himself — his son Justice Rajinder Sachar authored the seminal report on Indian Muslims in 2006. The rivalry grew so intense that Punjab witnessed President's Rule in 1951, the first such instance in independent India.

Even its most memorable CM, the no-nonsense Partap Singh Kairon, widely regarded as one of the most qualified, with postgraduate degrees in political science from the University of Michigan and economics from the University of California, Berkeley, was hamstrung by squabbling colleagues during his eight-year tenure (1956–1964). Today, Kairon is considered a giant among Punjab CMs, credited with establishing Punjab Agricultural University and laying the foundations of the state's Green Revolution-era progress. A tough administrator, he used men



The party was perhaps most united under Beant Singh, who led the Congress government after the dark decade of militancy following the 1992 polls. EXPRESS ARCHIVES

disguised as sadhus to catch corrupt officials. The late Chief Election Commissioner M S Gill once recalled how Kairon would often keep his turban on the table while working at the Punjab Secretariat and tie it while descending the stairs.

The turbulent 1980s saw intense infighting between two Congress stalwarts: Darbara Singh, the then CM, and Gianni

Zail Singh, the former CM elevated as Union Home Minister and later President. It is widely known that Darbara Singh favoured strict action against the then-emergent preacher Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale, but Zail Singh's interventions often upended those plans.

The party was perhaps most united under Beant Singh, who led the Congress government

after the dark decade of militancy following the 1992 polls. But Singh, known for keeping an open house and meeting constituents on his lawns every morning, was killed by a human bomb in the foyer of the secretariat at Chandigarh in 1995. His grandson Ravneet Bittu is now a BJP leader and Union Minister.

The two-time CM Captain Amarinder Singh, the savvy Maharaja of Patiala whose ties with the Gandhis dated back to his Doon school days with Rajiv Gandhi, and his mother's friendship with Indira Gandhi, also could not complete his second term due to internal strife. Later, Amarinder left the party for the BJP, as did many of its tall leaders. Yet, the Congress survived the mass desertions, as was evident from its hand-

some showing in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls: it won seven of the 13 parliamentary seats despite each candidate fending for himself without a coherent,

centralised poll strategy.

That, perhaps, is the point. Unlike the Shiromani Akali Dal that traditionally drew strength from the rural Sikh peasantry, or the BJP whose influence remained concentrated among urban Hindus, the Congress is a catch-all platform. It accommodates people from all religions, has room for both landlords and labourers, Dalits and Jat Sikhs, traders and government employees, city slickers and village strongmen. Its leaders fight bitterly, but usually within the same tent. This broad social coalition has often proved more durable than ideological cohesion.

Today, however, Punjab's political landscape has changed. For decades, power alternated between the Congress and the Akalis, who aligned first with the Jana Sangh and then the BJP. That arrangement was disrupted by the victory of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in 2022, which enjoys an over-

whelming majority in the Assembly with 94 of the 117 seats. The party, for which a win in the polls is a matter of survival, is pulling out all the stops to reach out to every voter in the state with doles, jobs, and more. Then, there is the BJP beehemoth with the agility of a cat, making its most determined bid to win Punjab on its own.

Yet, the Congress enters the race as usual: a house divided with a contested leadership and a dithering high command.

The question facing the party today is not whether it can survive factionalism. History suggests it can. For nearly eight decades, Punjab's Congress leaders have displayed an extraordinary ability to wound one another without destroying the party.

The real question is whether that old formula of muddling through will still work in a Punjab that is changing faster than the Congress itself.

MANRAJGREWAL@EXPRESSINDIA.COM

As former PMCH principal takes on minister Nishant Kumar, Bihar’s health dept hits back

His transfer an administrative decision based on findings of negligence, absence, misuse of government resources, says dept

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, June 27

DAYS AFTER it transferred Patna Medical College and Hospital (PMCH) principal Dr Narendra Pratap Singh, the Bihar Health Department said it was an administrative decision based on prima facie findings of negligence, unauthorised absence and misuse of government resources, not a punitive action.

The rebuttal came after the doctor, who was relieved of the additional charge of PMCH principal and transferred as professor of Psychiatry to Government Medical College, Bettiah, alleged the action against him was “humiliating” and “authoritarian”.

He said he was not given a chance to explain his side. Dr Singh’s transfer order came following state Health Minister Nishant Kumar’s June 23 visit to the PMCH, during which the principal was absent.

Rejecting Singh’s claim that he had not been informed about Nishant’s visit, the department said, “PMCH Superintendent had spoken to him over the phone around 7 pm on June 22”. It said Singh was informed that the superintendent would welcome the minister while the principal would deliver the vote of thanks, “an arrangement to which he had agreed”.

The department also disputed Dr Singh’s claim that senior officials had been informed

in advance about his burn injuries. It said he communicated the incident “several hours” after the minister’s programme. “This makes it clear that the WhatsApp messages were sent by Dr Singh only after the matter surfaced in the media, in an attempt to defend himself,” it said.

It said it learnt through a “decoy patient” that Dr Singh was available at his clinic during office hours. “This was followed by inquiries at both the departmental level and through the Patna administration,” it said.

Investigators found the government vehicle allotted to the PMCH principal parked outside Singh’s private clinic, it said. “The patients leaving the clinic told officials they had received



The principal was absent during Bihar Health Minister Nishant Kumar’s June 23 visit to PMCH

treatment from him, despite his assertion that he had suffered burn injuries and was unable to speak on the phone,” it said.

It added that when officials entered the clinic, the compounder informed them “Dr Singh would see patients from 7 pm” and during morning and afternoon hours of 9 am to 10 am and 2 pm to 3 pm. “This clearly indicates that Dr Singh routinely

attended to patients at his private clinic during official working hours,” it alleged.

Based on these findings, it said Dr Singh was, at first glance, found to have shown “negligence towards official duties, dereliction of duty, misuse of government resources and unauthorised absence”. It clarified that relieving him of the additional charge of PMCH principal and posting him to Bettiah was “only an administrative transfer” and “does not fall under the category of punishment”.

It also criticised Dr Singh for holding a press conference instead of submitting a representation explaining his absence, saying this was against the Bihar Government Servants’ Conduct Rules. It said a high-level inquiry committee has been constituted and that “Dr Singh’s version would be obtained before any further action is taken”.

Dr Singh has been associated with PMCH since 1988, serving as a faculty member and professor for nearly three decades and training generations of doctors across Bihar. A prominent figure in the state’s medical community, he completed his MBBS and postgraduate studies at PMCH. His long association with the hospital has also seen administrative frictions previously; he was removed from a post around 2019 before being reinstated following court intervention.

At his press conference on Friday, Dr Singh said he had been absent because he suffered burn injuries the previous evening. He also denied allegations of engaging in private practice during office hours, saying, “My house itself has a clinic. If patients are sitting there, should I chase them away with a stick? They have interpreted that as private practice.”

• BRIEFLY



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the launch of Bharat Taxi service in Gandhinagar on Saturday. EXPRESS

GUJARAT

Bharat Taxi will not exploit any saarhi, says Amit Shah at launch

UNION HOME Amit Shah launched the Bharat Taxi service in 14 of Gujarat cities on Saturday. “Bharat Taxi will never exploit any *sarhi*. That is my guarantee,” Shah said at the event at Mahatma Mandir, Gandhinagar. India’s first driver-owned ride-hailing service, launched with the backing of eight major co-operative institutions including Amul brand’s parent company — Gujarat Co-operative Milk Marketing Federation — signed MoUs with several organisations. The event, attended by over 7,000 *sarhis*, outlined expansion plans to over 125 cities by March 2027. ENS

Over 100 kids fall ill after having food in school

OVER 100 girl students of Kastuba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya in Jharkhand’s Garhwa fell ill Friday after allegedly consuming contaminated food and overheated water from the hostel’s storage tank. Abha Rani, Kharaundi Block Pramukh, alleged that the premises and kitchen of the school were “unhygienic”. Garhwa DC Pashupati Nath Mishra said there was “negligence” on the part of the school management. ENS

Gulmarg: One dead, 4 injured in explosion

A PERSON was killed and four others injured in a blast in an “old explosive object” Saturday in the upper areas of J&K’s Gulmarg, officials said. The incident occurred near Asha Post, Sumli Wali Dhok, in Gulmarg resort in north Kashmir’s Baramulla district. The explosion left Zubair Ahmad Bajjad, a resident of Lateefabad Khudpora village in Chandoosa area of Baramulla, dead. Inquest proceedings have been initiated. PTI

Veteran Tamil filmmaker, writer K Bhagyaraj dies

Yashaswini Sri,
Hyderabad, June 27

K BHAGYARAJ, the veteran Tamil director, actor and writer died in Chennai on Saturday. He was 73.

Over a career spanning decades, he introduced actors Urvashi and Kalpana to Tamil cinema, and was known for films including *Mundhanai Mudichu*, *Chinna Veedu*, *Darling Darling Darling*, *Sundara Kandam* and *Enga Chinna Rasa*. As a filmmaker, he was known for his humour with socially relevant themes, carving a niche in Tamil cinema.

Long before he became one of the defining voices of Tamil cinema in the 1980s, Krishnaswamy Bhagyaraj was a college dropout from Coimbatore.

Born in 1953, Bhagyaraj grew up admiring two very different screen icons, MGR and Rajesh Khanna. Drawn to cinema, he moved to Madras and began working as an assistant to directors G Ramakrishnan and Bharathiraja, taking on small roles as a junior artist, often with no more than a few minutes of screen time, in films like 16 Vayathinile in 1977 and Sigappu

Rojakkal the following year.

It was during this period that his real talent began to surface, not in front of the camera but on the page, as he wrote scripts for Bharathiraja’s *Kizhake Pogum Rayil* and, a few years later, *Tik Tik Tik*. He stepped into direction with *Staravilladha Chiththirangal* in 1979, the same year he also made his debut as a leading man in *Puthiya Vaarpugal*, a film that earned him the Tamil Nadu State Film Award for Best Dialogue Writer.

His scripts were known for being elaborate and witty, often laced with double entendre, built around socially rooted, everyday situations. His breakout came in 1983 with *Mundhanai Mudichu*, which he wrote, directed and starred in, winning him the Filmfare Award for Best Actor in Tamil and introducing actress Urvashi to Tamil cinema. It was remade in Hindi as *Masterji* starring Rajesh Khanna.

When Rajesh Khanna had to step away from the Hindi remake of Bharathiraja’s *Oru Kaidhiyin Diary* due to date issues, Bhagyaraj directed it with Amitabh Bachchan, releasing it as *Aakhree Raasta* in 1986.

They said I have ‘double dad’ syndrome: Actor on ex-AMMA colleagues

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, June 27

ANSIBA HASSAN, whose role in the Mohanlal-starrer *Drishyam* films propelled her to fame, has alleged that she faced abuse and communal remarks from some actors, including Tini Tom and Lakshmi Priya, who were members of the Association of Malayalam Movie Artists (AMMA).

On June 19, Ansiba (34) filed a petition at the Ernakulam Judicial First Class Magistrate court against her co-actor Tini Tom, alleging he made abusive and communal remarks against her. She moved court after an alleged delay by the Kochi police in filing an FIR based on her complaint. On June 26, Ansiba filed a separate complaint at Palarivattom police station against actor Lakshmi Priya, the former vice-president of AMMA; Swetha Menon, the former president of AMMA; and Sukumar, the owner of an online entertainment channel, alleging a malicious campaign against her.

Swetha Menon, Tini Tom and Lakshmi Priya have denied



Actor Ansiba Hassan

charges levelled against them.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Ansiba said that during her tenure in AMMA, she stood for “what was good for the organisation”. “...What I have faced is character assassination in AMMA and in public at the hands of those who once were AMMA office-bearers.” Sources in AMMA said that Ansiba had raised allegations of financial misappropriation in the body.

Ansiba said even her stepfather was being dragged into the. “They said, I have ‘double dad’ syndrome in a WhatsApp chat,” she said. When *The Indian Express* contacted Kochi Police, an officer said they are looking for more evidence before booking anyone.

Lohagad fort murder: Cops question Siya’s parents

Express News Service
Pune, June 27

PROBING THE alleged murder of 25-year-old Ketan Agarwal who died at Lohagad Fort, Pune Rural Police on Saturday questioned his accused fiancée Siya Goyal’s parents on Saturday.

Siya’s father Pravin, mother Puja and brother Sahil reached the Lonavala Rural police station in the morning. Their questioning continued until Saturday evening. Sahil was also questioned by police on Thursday for about 10 hours. A police officer

said Siya’s parents and brother are not suspects in the murder case, but were being questioned and their statements recorded.

Siya got engaged to Ketan in February and they were to get married in Rajasthan’s Udaipur later this year. Siya (20) and her lover Chetan Chaudhary (22) allegedly murdered Ketan Agarwal by pushing him off the western cliff of Lohagad Fort on June 18. Initially, Siya pretended that Ketan died by slipping into the valley at Lohagad Fort. Police arrested Siya and Chetan on June 23.

Warehouse collapse: Kin identify victims, survivor recounts why he took the job

The Taratala warehouse collapse toll rose to 16 on Saturday as rescue teams continued clearing the debris to look for signs of life. At the SSKM Hospital morgue, families identified the victims from tattoos, old injuries, clothes and personal belongings

RAHUL CHOUDHURY (17), LABOURER



Rahul Choudhury dropped out after Class 8. Originally from Bihar, his family settled in West Bengal over 25 years ago. His mother sold vegetables while his elder brother Rohan worked at construction sites in Assam. About two months ago, Rahul joined a labour contractor and began working at Taratala site.

“He felt it was becoming difficult for his eldest brother to run the family alone, so he wanted to help,” Rohan said. “I told him to wait for one or two years and then I would take him with me.”

Recently, Rahul had received his first month’s salary. He was paid Rs 9,000 for a month’s work, his sister Sima Prasad said.

She added, “Initially, when I started looking for him, everyone said, ‘he is 16 or 17, he wasn’t there.’ Poor people need money, but it is the government’s job to create work and ensure no one hires minors as cheap labour.”

She alleged her brother told her there were no proper water arrangements on the site. “Only when the engineers visited, they arranged for water,” she said, “Why did no one check if the developers were following safety rules and SOPs?” Sima identified Rahul’s body from the clothes he had worn that morning.

GANESH KALINDI (45), CONSTRUCTION WORKER

Ganesh Kalindi had spent seven to eight years moving be-

tween construction sites in Gujarat, Maharashtra and Bengaluru. The Taratala project was his first assignment in Kolkata.

The worker from Dhanbad had come as part of an eight-member team for a 12-day contract. Four workers had returned home, while the remaining four, including Kalindi, were scheduled to board a train from Howrah Wednesday afternoon.

“My uncle stepped away just two minutes before the collapse to pack his bag,” recalled his nephew Premnath Badrekar, who was working alongside him. Kalindi was rescued after nearly five hours and was alive when relatives met him in hospital. He died the next afternoon.

PAPPU KUMAR RAJAK (40), MASON



Wednesday was supposed to be Rajak’s final day at the site.

A resident of Jagaddal, Rajak worked in jute mills and later in a factory before both shut. For the past decade, he had worked as a mason on construction projects across Kolkata to support his wife Siuli and their 13-year-old daughter Pushpa. He was the strongest member of the family, his brother Ashok said.

“As she (Pushpa) grew, we required a regular job. Almost all the jute mills and factories in our area had shut,” said Siuli. The family spent nearly five hours shuttling between the accident site and SSKM Hospital searching for him. “They showed me

four other bodies before I found my husband,” Siuli said.

KRISHNA CHOUDHURY (49), FORMER JUTE MILL WORKER



Krishna Choudhury, a former worker at the Reliance Jagaddal Jute Mill, had turned to construction work after the mill shut last November.

For the past seven months, he had been travelling to construction sites to support his wife Suchita, three children and his 80-year-old mother Jasoda Devi Choudhury, who lies bedridden, clutching a photo of her son. “I just want my son back,” Jasoda wept. “He was forced to take up hazardous work at such distant places just to feed us.” “He earned 600 a day,” Suchita said. “I have three children to raise.”

SWAPAN MONDOL (55), CONSTRUCTION WORKER

Swapan Mondol of Shyamnagar, also left his regular work after being promised higher wages at the Taratala site. He is survived by his wife and two married daughters. “My father never used to work far from home. He agreed because of better pay,” his elder daughter said. She said local construction work usually paid him Rs 500-600 a day. “A supervisor told him he would get Rs 1,000 a day for six days here. We identified him from the copper bracelet.”

SUMAN KARMAKAR (40), CONSTRUCTION WORKER

Sreechand Kumar was identified from his phone. His cousins, Manu and Ghee also died. Sahid Kumar, one of the cousins who survived, waited outside the morgue for bodies of his relatives. “We came here on June 12 and stayed at the site itself,” Sahid told *The Indian Express*. “We are from Munger... We thought we would earn more here and then move on to another site. We are now returning to Munger,” he said.

DEBASHISH DAS (43), SURVIVOR

Like others, Das from Shyamnagar too had accepted the Taratala job after being promised Rs 1,000 a day. Before leaving Kolkata, Das said, “We were working on the ground-floor concrete casting when the entire structure collapsed. I’ll never go for this kind of work again.”

SWEETY KUMARI & TANUSREE BOSE



Irfana Iqbal performs the last rites of 64-year-old Narayanan. EXPRESS

“Narayanan died of oral cancer at a medical college hospital in Kozhikode on Tuesday. He had been married to two women and had children from both relations. His family abandoned him months ago. Even after his death they did not come to claim his body. I spoke

to his close relatives and got their written consent to perform the last rites as per Hindu traditions. We have given him a decent adieu,” said Irfana. In a Facebook post she wrote, “...I performed Narayanettan’s last rites as a daughter. Humanity is above religion and politics.”

Irfana said she learnt about Narayan’s condition from a local panchayat member a month ago. “I got in touch with the District Collector and the District Medical Officer and got their consent to admit Narayanan to our old age home. But his health was deteriorating. We admitted him to the government medical college in Kannur. Our plan was to take him back to the old age home when his health improves,” she said.

Narayanan was diagnosed with advanced-stage oral cancer and had to be referred to Government Medical College Hospital, Kozhikode, where he died Tuesday. Irfana, who performed Narayan’s last rites Friday when Muharram was observed across India, said it was her decision to claim his body and give it a dignified cremation. “I could not abandon him in death.”

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, June 27

AT 94, Kondragunta Mahalakshamma has only one wish – to die an Indian. This week, the former US citizen’s wish was close to being fulfilled when she was administered the oath of allegiance to the nation at Bapatla, her native district in Andhra Pradesh.

“I do solemnly swear in the name of God that I will bear true faith and allegiance to the Constitution of India as by law established, and that I will faithfully observe the laws of India and fulfill my duties as a citizen of India,” she said as she stood by her son K Buchaiah at PGRS Hall of Bapatla Collectorate, Andhra Pradesh, on June 23. A US citizen since 2000, she had approached authorities for Indian citizenship after having given up her US citizenship. A video of her taking



Kondragunta Mahalakshamma took the oath of allegiance at PGRS Hall of Bapatla Collectorate on June 23. EXPRESS

the oath of allegiance on June 23 went viral on social media.

The oath of allegiance is mandatory under Section 38 of the Citizenship Rules, 2009, to become a citizen of India. It is administered by the district collector and magistrate. In the video, Mahalakshamma, who’s hard of hearing, is heard administer-

ing the oath in Telugu with help from her oncologist son K Buchaiah, who’s heard shouting the words to her. The oath had to be administered in Telugu as she does not follow English.

For District Collector V Vinod Kumar, the oath marked a “special day”. “We asked her why she wants to get Indian citizen-

ship at this late stage in her life. She said that she wants to die an Indian and be cremated here in Chithagumpala village of Chinaganjam area, Bapatla,” Kumar told *The Indian Express*. The collector quoted the 94-year-old as having said: “I’m nearing 95. My only wish is to spend my final days in my motherland and have my last rites performed in my village”. The application has been sent to the Home Ministry.

In 2000, Mahalakshamma moved to the US to be with her son’s family shortly after the demise of her husband in Andhra Pradesh. “She lived in the US until 2018 and then returned to India. She holds an Overseas Citizen of India card,” Collector Kumar said. Mahalakshamma has been living in Bapatla ever since 2018, the collector said. “But now she wants to be laid to rest in the country of her origin,” Kumar said.



Saini dials Dhambi, sends political secretary to Himachal to hold talks with Nihangs

Dehradun: A district and sessions court in Chamoli Saturday granted bail to four Nihang Sikhs arrested in connection with a clash in Karna-prayag on June 16, even as Haryana

CM Nayab Singh Saini dialled his Uttarakhand counterpart Pushkar Singh Dhambi urging early and peaceful resolution to the matter. Saini sent his political secretary,

Tarun Bhandari, to meet the Nihangs at Paonta Sahib gurdwara in Himachal Pradesh's Sirmara, where they are camping since Friday after postponing their march to Uttarak-

hand for two days. The move came after Haryana Sikh Gurudwara Prabandhak Committee (HSGPC) delegation met Saini over the issue. Following discussions with Sikh

groups, Bhandari said Saini has assured the Sikh community of a peaceful and speedy resolution. "This is not a major dispute. Such minor clashes occasionally occur, but some individuals aggravate the situation by politicising these issues." In a separate development, intelligence agencies issued a security alert for Delhi and Uttarakhand following a possible terror threat, with key religious sites and government establishments put under surveillance, sources said Saturday. PTI

Murder of two Elenas in Goa: Charges framed against Russian national

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, June 27

A GOA sessions court on Friday framed charges against a Russian national, accused of murdering two Russian women in Goa earlier this year.

Alexie Leonov, a fire display performer, was arrested in January 2026 for allegedly murdering two Russian women, Elena Kasthanova, 37, and Elena Vaneeva, 37, in Goa. According to the police probe, the accused allegedly murdered Vaneeva — a bubble performer and an artist — at her rented room in Morjim on January 14 night by slitting her neck with a sharp knife. On January 15, Leonov allegedly tied up Kasthanova in her rented room in Arambol by and slit her neck with a sharp weapon.

The court framed charges against Leonov under various sections of BNS 2023. The prosecution argued that there was sufficient material on record to establish the accused's involvement in the murders. The accused's counsel submitted that necessary orders be passed upon considering the material.

In the murders' immediate aftermath, the Goa police had claimed that the motive behind the crimes was a "monetary dispute amongst them." However, Leonov told police in his disclosures that he was in a relationship with both women and was "living-in" with them. Police said Leonov claims he suspected Kastha-

nova was in a relationship with another man, while he allegedly killed Vaneeva over a monetary dispute. Leonov had also told the police in his disclosure statements that he killed "multiple women".

The police, however, dismissed his claims, stating he was involved in killing two women as per the probe. According to the police's charge-sheet, Leonov occasionally visited Vaneeva, and on the day of the murder, he came to her house around 11.30 am to help her in shifting some articles.

He was in her room until 11 pm, according to a witness's testimony. Vaneeva was found murdered on January 16 in the bathroom of her house in a slightly decomposed condition. A knife was found on her upper chest.

In the chargesheet, the police cited the statement of a material witness, Elena Loginovich who saw Kasthanova lying on the floor with her body facing towards the floor and her head towards the bathroom door and a pool of blood around her head.

She claimed she saw Leonov standing with his right leg placed on Elena's body. In a state of panic, she yelled "ambulance" and "police" and ran to the ground floor, where the owner stayed asking them to make the calls. "The statement of Elena Loginovich, prima facie, shows the involvement of the accused in the crime," it said.

3 teens drown while bathing in Narmada

Jabalpur: Three friends including two minors, drowned while bathing in the Narmada river in Jabalpur on Saturday afternoon, police said.

The trio had gone to bathe at Dadda Ghat around 3 pm without informing their families, said SHO Brijesh Mishra. A water supply plant is located at Dadda Ghat and the river is quite deep near the spot, he said.

While bathing, one of the teenagers ventured near the plant and began to drown. The other two tried to rescue him but they too drowned, Mishra said.

Police initiated a search operation with the help of local divers, and the bodies were recovered after two hours of intense efforts, the official said. A case of unnatural deaths was registered. PTI



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
DEPARTMENT OF WATER RESOURCES
Office of the Additional Chief Engineer,
Drainage Circle, Balasore.
Email id: sedcbis@yahoo.com

32001/461/2627

"e" PROCUREMENT NOTICE NO.- ACEDCBLS-05/2026-27

1	Name of Works	: Drainage works (Under D.I.P. Scheme)
2	Total No. of Project	: 01 No of Individual work.
3	Estimated cost of individual works	: Rs. 2,97,04,185.00 (Excluding G.S.T.)
4	Period of completion	: 11 (Eleven) Calendar Months
5	Bid Identification Number	: ACEDCBLS/DDIPR-01-05/2026-27
6	Date & Time of availability of Bid document in the Portal	: From Dt.30.06.2026 at 10:00 hours to Dt.14.07.2026 at 17:00 hours
7	Date & Time for receipt of Bid document in the Portal	: From Dt.30.06.2026 at 10:00 hours to Dt.14.07.2026 at 17:00 hours
8	Date of Opening of Technical Bid	: Dt.15.07.2026 at 11.30 hours in the Office of the Additional Chief Engineer, Drainage Circle, Balasore.
9	Date of Opening of Financial Bid	: To be uploaded in portal.
10	Cost of Tender Paper	: Rs.10,000.00
11	Procurement Officer/Name & address of the officer inviting Bids	: Additional Chief Engineer, Drainage Circle, Balasore

Further details can be seen from the Govt. Web site www.tendersorissa.gov.in

Sd/-
Additional Chief Engineer,
Drainage Circle, Balasore

OIPR-32001/32128/1/26-27/0005



CHOLAMANDALAM INVESTMENT AND FINANCE COMPANY LIMITED
Registered Office at: "CHOLA CREST", 3rd Floor, C54 & C55, Super B-4, Thiru V. Ka Industrial Estate, Guindy, Chennai - 600 032

DEMAND NOTICE UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT 2002

You, the under mentioned Borrower / Co-Borrowers is hereby informed that the company has initiated proceedings against you under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and that the Notice under 13 (2) of the Act sent to you by Registered Post Ack. Due for Borrower/s has been returned undelivered. Hence, you are hereby called upon to take notice and pay the outstanding loan amount mentioned against the said account with interest accruing there on within 60 days from the date of this publication, failing which the company will proceed against you by exercising its right under Sub-Sec (4) of Section 13 of the Act by enforcing the below mentioned security to realize its dues with interests and costs. It is needless to mention that this notice is addressed to you without prejudice to any other remedy available to the company.

Sl.No.13 Loan Account No. PR00034350 & PR00036254, Name and Address of the Borrower / Co-Borrowers 1. Navgrah Enterprises, (Borrower) 231/C Ground Floor, KH, No. 32, Gali No. 11, Gamri Extension Delhi-110053. 2. Sumit Kumar, (Co Borrower), 3. Prafulla Kohkar, (Co Borrower), 4. Mahinder Kumar, (Co Borrower), 5. Anupama (Co Borrower), S.No.2 to 5 at: H.No.119, Pocket- 1, Near Aman Vihar, Police Station, Sector-22, Rohini Begumpur North West Delhi- 110086. Loan Amount: Rs. 1,28,00,000/- & Rs.1,43,00,000/- Date of Demand Notice: 20.06.2026, Amount Outstanding : Rs.1,11,02,138/- & Rs.26,20,755/- as on 16.06.2026 with further interest thereon & NPA Date : 04.06.2026.

SCHEDULE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY: All that piece and parcel of the mortgaged property being the second floor and entire third floor along with exclusive roof / terrace rights still parking rights and usage rights of the flat installed in the building, forming part of the build-up property bearing No. 119, constructed on land admeasuring 90 Sq.Mtrs., situated at Pocket-1, Sector-22, forming part of the Rohini, Delhi- 110086, together with proportionate undivided, indivisible and impartible rights in the land underneath the said property and together with all fittings, fixtures, easements, liberties, privilege benefits and appurtenance attached thereto, including common rights of ingress, egress, passage, staircase, lift access and other common facilities available in the building, and all other rights, title and interest attached thereto. **Bounded as:** North: Entry of the House, South: Service Lane, East: Plot No. 120, West: Plot No. 118.

Sl.No.23 Loan Account No. TL01NDL0000063296 & TL01NDL0000072581, Name and Address of the Borrower / Co-Borrowers 1. L B Traders, (Borrower) Ground Floor 16/6346 Block No. 7B Dev Nagar, Karol Bagh Central Delhi-110005. Also at: Ground Floor 6176/4 Block No. 1 Dev Nagar Karol Bagh Central Delhi - 110 005. 2. Lal Babu Mahto, (Co Borrower), 3. Rekha Devi, Sl.No.2 & 3 at: A 247-248 Harsukh Block Prem Nagar - 1 Kirari Suleman Nagar North West Delhi- 110086. Loan Amount: Rs.1,46,50,000/- & Rs.35,70,000/- Date of Demand Notice: 20.06.2026, Amount Outstanding : Rs.1,49,14,654/- & Rs.36,96,319/- as on 16.06.2026 with further interest thereon & NPA Date : 04.06.2026.

SCHEDULE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY: Built up Property bearing No. 247 and 248 With roof and above rights, Land area measuring 150 Sq.yds., i.e. **125.415 Sq. Mtrs.,** Out of Khana No. 7/10, situated in the area of village Nangoli Jat, Delhi state Delhi and the abadi known as Nangoli New Delhi-110041. **Bounded as:** East: Other Plot, West: Other Plot, North: Road 25 feet, South-Road 15 feet.

Date : 28.06.2026
Place : Delhi

Authorized Officer
For Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company Limited



UJVNL Limited
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, GMS Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866, Website: www.ujvnl.com

Tender Notice
RO No. 537
Dated : 27/06/2026

The Office of the Executive Engineer (E&M), Joshiyara Barrage Joshiyara (Uttarkashi), invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below :
Tender No : NIT- 06/EE(E&M)/MB-II/Barrage/2026-27
Name of work / Supply/Services : "Sealing of gates of Joshiyara Barrage with caulking material by under water diving team"
Estimated cost : Rs. 7,80,940/- Only (Taxes extra)
Date of availability of bid document on website : 28.06.2026
Last date for submission of tender : 19.07.2026 up to 16:00 Hrs.
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvnl.com"

Executive Engineer (E&M)

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"



ADITYA BIRLA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED
Registered Office: Indian Rayon Compound, Veraval, Gujarat
362266 Branch Office: Aditya Birla Housing Finance Ltd, Unit No. 710 A | 7th Floor | Corporate Park | B-109 | Sanjay Place | Agra -282002.

ABHFL: Authorized Officer AMANDEEP TANEJA : 9711246064
1. Auction Service Provider (ASP): - M/S e-Procurement Technologies Pvt. Ltd. (AuctionTiger) Mr. Ram Sharma - Contact No. 8000023297 & 9265562819

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Asset(s) under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with provision to rule 8(6) and 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable properties mortgaged/charged to the Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited/Secured Creditor, upon classification of availed loans as **Non Performing Asset (NPA)** on 03-06-2023, issued a notice under Section 13(2) on 09-06-2023 of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002 (54 of 2002) (hereinafter referred to as 'the said Act') calling upon you, the Borrower(s) to discharge the liabilities in full within a statutory period of 60 (Sixty) days, amounting to **INR 768118.95/- (Rupees Seven Lakhs Sixty Eight Thousand One Hundred Eighteen and Paise Ninety Five Only)** and further interest and other expenses thereon till the date of realization, due to Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited/Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) & Guarantor(s) namely Govind Sharma, Anamika Sharma, Rohit Sharma.

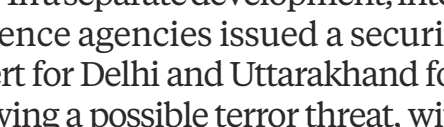
The reserve price will be **INR 983520/- (Rupees Nine Lakhs Eighty Three Thousand Five Hundred Twenty Only)** and the **Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)** will be **INR 98352/- (Rupees Ninety Eight Thousand Three Hundred Fifty Two Only)**. The last date of deposit of EMD is **03-08-2026** The date for inspection of the said property is fixed on **01-08-2026** between 11:00 am to 04:00 pm.

DESCRIPTION OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
All That Piece And Parcel Of Flat No. T-90, 3rd Floor, Admeasuring 707 And 44.91 Sq. Mtrs. (Carpet Area), Tower-E, Block-B, "Dream City Awas Yojna", Project Name "Singhal Dream City", Situated At Near Patholi Nahar, Jaipur Road, Near 100 M. Ring Road, Ladamada, Agra, Uttar Pradesh-282001, And **Bounded As:** East: Other's Property, West: Other's Property, North: Other's Property, South: 24 M. Wide Zonal Road (Proposed) & Other's Property.

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited/Secured Creditor's website i.e. <https://homefinance.adityabirlacapital.com/properties-for-auction-under-sarfaesi-act> or i.e. <https://sarfaesi.auctiontiger.net>

Date:- 28-06-2026
Place: AGRA

Sd/- Authorized Officer
Aditya Birla Housing Finance Limited



ARCHIVAL RESEARCH AND IDENTIFICATION WORKS

E-Tender Notice No. GEM/2026 /B/7711041 Dated: 25-06-2026.
Works tenders through "E" Tendering system for and on behalf of the president of India are invited for the works as detailed below:-
Name of work: Archival Research and Identification of Land Associated with Darjeeling Himalayan Railway (DHR)/ Cart Road in Compliance with CCMP, ICOMOS, WHC Reports/Guidelines. **Tender Value:** ₹ 1,12,10,000/- **Earnest Money:** ₹ 2,06,050/- **Date & time of Closing of tender:** At 15.00 hrs. & opening at 15.30 hrs. on 16-07-2026. The complete information with tender documents of above e-tender will be available in the website <https://GeM.gov.in>
Director/DHR/Kurseong

NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile



NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
E-Tendering Tender Notice No.34/2026

Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.) N.E.Railways Itanagar For and behalf of President of India invites "OPEN" e-tender through on Line (E-tendering) for the following work.
S.N.:1- Description of works: Construction of S&T service building at interlocked LC Gate no 2 (PBE-NRY), 3(PBE - NRY), 11(NRY-MJZ), 12 (NRY - MJZ), 10 (GUB - BPZ), 34 (HPIL - BPZ), 41 (HPIL - KPVP) and 42(HPIL-KPVP) (Total=08 Nos) under jurisdiction of Sr DENVI/ZN Division in NE Railway, (under the sanctioned work of Construction of S&T service building at interlocked LC Gate (Total=19 Nos). Approx. Value (Rs.): ₹ 1,51,94,519.86. E.M.D Money (Rs.): ₹ 3,03,900/- Cost of Tender Forms Rs. NIL. Completion time /period from the date of issue of acceptance letter 06 Months.
1. On line e-tender can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs of dated 17.07.2026.
2. For Full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways IREPS website www.ireps.gov.in.
Divisional Railway manager(Engg) CPROW-198 Itanagar

Never travel on roof and foot boards.



CONSTRUCTION OF MINOR BRIDGE

E-Tender Notice No.: 26/W-2/ APD/J, Dated: 24-06-2026; E-Tender are invited by the undersigned for the following works; Tender No.: 06-AP-III-2026; Name of Work: Construction of minor bridge 1x4.00 m span box at Km-38/0-1 between section Sivok-Bagrakot to channelized stagnant water under the jurisdiction of ADE/N Maibazar. **Tender Value:** ₹ 93,81,497.47/-; **Earnest Money :** ₹ 7,87,600/-; **Date & time of closing of tender at 15:00 hrs. and opening at 15:30 hrs. on 16-07-2026. Complete information alongwith the tender document of above e-tender will be available in the website www.ireps.gov.in**
DRM (W), Alipurduar Jn.
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile

BRIDGE

Our last week's problems was taken from an old OKBridge column by Matthew Granovetter. This is what he has to say: One of the most unusual defensive gambits is the Grosvener. It's defined by the Bridge Encyclopedia as a humorous psychological play by a defender who deliberately makes a clear error, giving declarer an opportunity that he will probably refuse because he expects a rational defense. The hope is that the declarer will be demoralised for later deals. Dealer: South Vulnerable: Both

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ K 10 8 7 2	♠ A 9 6 5		
♥ A 6 5	♥ K 4		
♦ K 4 2	♦ A Q J 7		
♣ A 2	♣ Q 4 3		

WEST	NORTH	EAST	SOUTH
	1NT		
pass	2♥	pass	2S
pass	3NT	pass	4♦
pass	4♥	pass	5S
pass	6S	pass	pass
pass			

West leads the jack of clubs. Plan the play.

THE WEST HAND: ♣ Q J 4 ♥ J 9 7 3 ♦ 10 6 ♠ J 10 9 8

THE EAST HAND: ♠ 3 ♥ 3 ♦ Q 10 8 2 ♦ 9 8 5 3 ♠ K 7 6 5

The slam is a good proposition, needing one of several chances, but as the cards were, it was doomed. West led a club and declarer played low from dummy. East won the king and returned a club. Declarer led a spade to his ace and West, a funny guy, dropped the queen. When declarer next led a trump toward the dummy, West produced the 4. Declarer scoffed at this and called for the king. Of course, West should never play an honour on the first round of the suit, because he has the contract beaten by playing low. But West was trying to be funny (or trying to irritate South). When East showed out in trumps, declarer was indeed irritated! He conceded down one and shook his head in dismay. Another problem on dummy play. Dealer: South Vulnerable: None

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ K J 8 5 4 3	♠ A Q 10 6 2		
♥ A Q 10	♥ 9 4 3 2		
♦ A	♦ 5		
♣ 6 3 2	♣ A K J		

SOUTH	WEST	NORTH	EAST
1S	pass	3H	pass
4C	pass	4S	pass
6H	pass	6S	pass

West leads the four of diamonds. Plan the play.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Natural ability without ____ has more often attained to glory and virtue than ____ without natural ability - Cicero (9,...,9) (same word twice)

CANOE

BGISNU

INAPT

CURLED

ANSWERS: Natural ability without education has more often attained to glory and virtue than education without natural ability - Cicero

SOLUTIONS: Ocean, Paint, Busing, Pundit

• SUNDAY CROSSWORD

QUICK CLUES
ACROSS
1. Language of Karnataka (7)
5. Invokes God's favour on (7)
9. Destiny (5)
10. Tribal leader (9)
11. Toy (9)
12. Bed, stratum (5)
13. Deep breath (4)
15. Indian mountain range (8)
18. Ancient Hindu art of medicine (8)
19. Big showcase (4)
22. Thing of great help and value (5)
24. Confirming or preserving, defending (9)
26. Journalist (9)
27. Church instrument (5)
28. Lack of vanity (7)
29. At little cost (7)

DOWN
1. Flightless parrot of New Zealand (6)
2. Usual state (9)
3. Stand by (5)
4. Become accustomed (9)
5. Fetch (5)
6. Peel off in thin fragments (9)
7. Serpentine (5)
8. Military guard (6)
14. Difficult circumstances to bear ? (4,5)
16. Indifferent (9)
17. Receiving enthusiastically ?

SOLUTIONS TO 2587 QUICK CLUES ACROSS: 1 Shelving, 5 Aikido, 9 Affinity, 10 Ushers, 12 Overdraft, 13 Meets, 14 Boer, 16 Wriggle, 19 Omitted, 21 Nick, 24 Grief, 25 Nathaniel, 27 Extras, 28 Alcatraz, 29 Street, 30 Advanced **DOWN:** 1 Season, 2 Eiffel, 3 Vinod, 4 Not fair, 6 Insomniac, 7 Icebergs, 8 Obsesses, 11 Stew, 15 Out of date, 17 Congress, 18 Sinister, 20 Dane, 21 Nettled, 22 Citric, 23 Blazed, 26 Agoma **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Impacted, 5 Warsaw, 9 Lectures, 10 Appeal, 12 Well begun, 13 Amado, 14 Mobs, 16 Busload, 19 Get a job, 21 Lust, 24 Serac, 25 Warplanes, 27 Unlaid, 28 All right, 29 Ending, 30 Michener **DOWN:** 1 In-laws, 2 Pickle, 3 Crumb, 4 Emerges, 6 Appraises, 7 Sheraton, 8 Warlords, 11 Snub, 15 Objection, 17 Egg sauce, 18 Startled, 20 Bowl, 21 Lorelei, 22 One gin, 23 Ishtar, 26 Larc

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

5						1	8
	3			7		6	
		9	4				
	5	8	7				3
		1				5	
	6				5	2	8
					7	8	
		5		2			9
3	8						7

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6362

4	3	1	7	6	9	8	2	5
8	6	5	4	3	2	1	7	9
7	9	2	1	8	5	4	3	6
9	5	8	3	4	1	2	6	7
6	7	3	5	2	8	9	1	4
1	2	4	9	7	6	5	8	3
3	8	9	6	1	4	7	5	2
2	4	6	8	5	7	3	9	1
5	1	7	2	9	3	6	4	8

2588

make repeated cuts (7)
29. Former spouse sat in the open (7)

DOWN
1. Lieutenant carrying bladed tools is most careless (6)
2. Courted after having downed tools (6,3)
3. Delivery from the gun-runner ? (5)
4. Such a noise will leave your ears numb (9)
5. Gets wind of some strikes? (5)
6. With noble qualities, quite stylish around clumsy rival (9)
7. High church feature up to a point (5)
8. Think about being the one in the water? (6)
14. Woman will fit casual clothes (9)
16. Ego his duo obscured as a booklet on London restauranting (4,5)
17. Jade confused the sniper ! (9)
20. Not many people with a dog will keep one indoors (6)
21. Having been written, it's enclosed (6)
23. Is expression of disapproval from the East Rwandan? (5)
24. Surname every man has? (5)
25. Secure draw at college (3,2)

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY JUNE 28: This year you will reap the benefits of all your hard work. Expect a promotion, awards and the limelight. Seize opportunities and act on them.

MONDAY JUNE 29: This is a year of moving on. Let go of what is no longer relevant. Do some internal and external housekeeping. Clear the decks for a new cycle.

TUESDAY JUNE 30: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes in your life. Keep your eyes open for new opportunities. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future.

WEDNESDAY JULY 1: This year is the completion of a nine-year cycle for you. Take inventory of your life. Let go of people, places and things that have held you back. Do some internal and external housecleaning.

THURSDAY JULY 2: This is a year of new beginnings, adventures and major changes in your life. Keep your eyes open for new opportunities. What you do now will bring great benefits in the future.

FRIDAY JULY 3: This year is slower paced. Take time to rejuvenate your energy. Focus on relationships with people who are kind and helpful and have your back. Value yourself.

SATURDAY JULY 4: This is a playful, fun-loving year for you. Let your guard down and loosen up a bit. Enjoy yourself, but don't lose sight of your goals. Old friends might reappear again.

• YOUR WEEK AHEAD

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): You are creative and can do almost anything with your hands. Make improvements to where you live. Romance and socialising are blessed. This Week: Stock the fridge because relatives are visiting.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): This is a sociable time. Enjoy entertaining. Give yourself a chance to learn new things because you're ready to work hard to boost your earnings. This Week: Transportation delays and goofy mistakes.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Fiery Mars enters your sign today to stay until mid-August. It will boost your confidence and energy and make you work hard. You won't hesitate to defend yourself. This Week: Finances are slow.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): You have the Sun, Mercury and Jupiter all in your sign, with Jupiter giving you divine protection. This happens only once every 12 years. Reach out and help someone today. This Week: Misplaced items, goofy mistakes and people from the past are back.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Although this is an excellent week to buy wardrobe items for yourself, not today! There's a Moon Alert all day. Nevertheless, it's a wonderful day to chat and enjoy creative projects and make art. This Week: It's a great week for research and digging into your past.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): This is a wonderful day to chat. But it's not a good day for serious discussions or decisions. It's a great time to listen to what others have to say and enjoy good company. This Week: Old friends are back in your world.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You feel a strong need to share your ideas. If you want to make travel plans, wait until tomorrow to act because there's a Moon Alert in effect all day. This Week: Contact with parents and bosses from your past. If looking for work, reapply where you tried before.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Be careful because you might be having money discussions today. You will also be tempted to shop. Restrict spending to food and gas. This Week: Travel delays. It's a great time to finish writing projects.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Today the Moon is in your sign giving you an advantage over all the other signs. However, there is a Moon Alert in effect all

5 trends will determine future India



ACROSS THE AISLE
BY P CHIDAMBARAM

I HAVE OBSERVED social and political trends in India for many years. What appears to be a deep-running current may not be so, and may be only a passing cloud. A passing cloud can bring a welcome shower, but that is not an enduring feature of the climate.

1947 was a watershed year. Since Independence, many visible influences and trends were noticed but were short-lived; and many incipient trends that were unnoticed by most people have become enduring. For example, despite Gandhiji's near-divine status and hundreds of dedicated Gandhians, the Gandhian way of life, *ahimsa*, *satyagraha*, the *charkha*, non-violence and civil disobedience did not survive for more than a couple of decades after Gandhiji. On the other hand, few anticipated the rapid urbanisation of India, fewer noticed climate change, and still fewer understood the complex relationship between humans and science and technology.

The saying is, 'Prediction is very difficult, especially if it's about the future' (Nobel laureate Niels Bohr and legendary baseball player Yogi Berra). Nevertheless, I shall dare to venture into forbidden territory. I have observed five trends that may gain strength and mo-

mentum. Much as I dislike and dread some of them, these trends seem unstoppable:

'Decline of Democracy as government of the people....'

Democracy is government *of* the people. People are born free and have the right to many freedoms. A democratic government is a government that respects and upholds the rights of the people, and has established independent institutions that will protect and enforce the rights. *Freedom House*, *V-Dem Institute* and *Reporters Without Borders* (all Research Institutes) classify countries as 'free' or not on the basis of scores under various indicators. More and more countries have a declining score. India's score was 77 in 2005 and has declined to 63-67. India is likely to be a mere 'electoral democracy' and elections will be less free and fair. The Indian people seem to be unperturbed by the declining score in return for welfare measures, better infrastructure and no challenge to an oppressive social structure. China's score has been stuck at 9/100 for many years, but by all reports, the Chinese people are happy. India may take that path.

Monopolies vs Entrepreneurs

Several sectors of the economy are dominated by duopolies or oligopolies — air travel, telecommunications, cement, steel, power, pharmaceuticals, petroleum, defence production, mining, and retail. More sectors may go that way. Small businesses and MSMEs will become near-extinct. NGOs will be stifled. The distribution of economic power will be increasingly skewed in favour of the monopolists. The balance between capital and labour will continue to shift in fa-

The distribution of economic power will be increasingly skewed in favour of the monopolists. The balance between capital and labour will continue to shift in favour of capital

vour of capital. The distribution of income will be skewed in favour of the rich and super-rich. Income inequalities will increase, and we will be less egalitarian.

Farewell to Identities

Most large cities have become cosmopolitan and a medley of languages, religions, cultures and cuisines. Many towns are following suit. Urbanisation and mass transit systems will take the trend deeper into India. No one will 'belong' to a place; 'native place' will, like the joint family, become extinct. Most people one encounters will be strangers. The circle of friends will become smaller, and relationships will be forged through devices. Conversations will be mediated by machines. No (hu)man is an island may be disproved. Transactions, not emotions, will determine relationships between humans. Sexual relations may survive because sex has benefits beyond procreation.

Cultural Nationalism vs Fearful Minorities

The line separating science and pseudoscience will vanish. As Mr Vasudevan Mukunth wrote (*The Hindu*, dated June 23, 2026), educational authorities will institutionalise Puranic science as science, mythology as history, ritual as technology, and an open contempt for verifiability. More IITs may be goaded to do 'research' into mythological stories, reincarnation and Vedic biology. Cultural revival will revolve around the reconstruction of temples and the celebration of Hindu festivals. Meat shops may be banned in several towns. Following West Bengal, other states may remove eggs from the mid-day meal scheme. Uniform civil

codes will be passed in more States. Resistance to the Hindutva agenda will be broken down. More and more children and adults will be able to speak and write in only a single language, Hindi, closing more windows to growing STEM studies and the technology-driven world (until Hindi catches up with English and other languages). Minorities — religious, linguistic, ethnic — will live in fear, wondering whether a historically plural country will have a place for their children.

Super rich vs Mass of Poor

The trends noted above will have enormous consequences for the 144 crore people, who will plateau at 167 crore and begin to decline. India will grow — whether at 5 per cent or more — irrespective of the government, because Indians will grow food, produce goods, and consume or export. The numbers of the rich and the super rich will increase, but many millions will be massed at the bottom of the pyramid. Those millions will experience low demand, low consumption, low standards of life and low growth. Moreover, if millions of people are excluded from participation in the story of India, on one pretext or the other, their lives will be worse. India will be less equal and more divided and angry.

You may dispute the five trends or add to or subtract from them, but you cannot deny that the *direction* of the country, and the *trends* witnessed, will determine India's place in the world.

(Across the Aisle completes 12 years in June 2026. The author wishes to take a long break to pursue other interests. This column will now be an occasional feature in The Indian Express)

Double-engine, double trouble



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

THERE COULD not be a more perfect week to talk about corruption. Speaking for myself, I admit that my head has been reeling because of the number of times I have lately heard the word corruption uttered. From the 'cockroaches' protesting in Jantar Mantar to the dirty linen tumbling out of the temple in Ayodhya to the 'double-engine' chief minister caught in nepotistic land deals in Ujjain, corruption has become hard to ignore. On the day that this column's deadline looms, I make it a point to go to the gym and spend at least an hour on the treadmill watching the news. It helps me examine my thoughts and follow the latest events.

This time, as I was gloomily brooding over the way in which corruption has suddenly exploded onto the national political landscape, the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh popped up on my screen. It stunned me to hear him smilingly declare that it was because of the 'double-engine' government in Uttar Pradesh that the state has become number one. It has not. But, instead of being a basket case, the state Yogi Adityanath has governed with an iron hand (and many bulldozers) for nearly a decade has improved in some ways.

What struck me about Yogi's speech was that reference to his 'double-engine' government, because it is from these supposedly idyllic states that the biggest corruption stories are coming. The Ram temple in Ayodhya has been built under the direct supervision of Bulldozer Baba, so it is extraordinary that he never got a hint of gold, silver, expensive jewellery and cash being looted from the offerings that devotees made in good faith. It is just as extraordinary that the trustees of the temple's funds did not notice what was going on. They must explain why they disregarded advice, given long ago, to have the temple's offerings counted professionally. What we are beginning to see in all the cases that have surfaced is a criminal lack of accountability.

Last week, yet another young Indian committed suicide because he could not face another NEET examination. This adds to the grim count of around a hundred students committing suicide over NEET in the past five years, with the highest toll last year. The Cockroach Janata Party is right to demand that the education minister resign since he is directly responsible for the mess in the examination system. It is the demand for Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation that made them spend all last week in protest in Jantar Mantar. But, judging by the effusive birthday greetings the Prime Minister posted on Friday, there seems little chance of his resignation.

As citizens of this 'mother of democracy', we have a right to demand accountability from those who are supposed to be servants of us, 'the people'. But somehow, the man who calls himself the Pradhan Sewak (prime servant) has not noted how much his fair image is being damaged by the reckless absence of accountability that his ministers and chief ministers are showing. Does he know that corruption is now so publicly displayed that in Mumbai, when the Vidhan Sabha is in session, ministers stay in the Oberoi Hotel? Who pays for this and why? And who pays for the Range Rovers, Land Cruisers and BMWs that remain parked in the hotel's porch all day? Maharashtra, in case you may have forgotten, is another double-engine government.

Corrupt politicians are now so plentiful that people have stopped expecting that Modi will live up to that promise he made long ago, 'Na khaunga, na khaane doonga'. Loosely translated, because in English eating is the wrong word, what he said was that he would not be lining his own pockets, nor would he allow anyone else to line theirs. Corruption was one of the reasons why the Congress Party lost that Lok Sabha election twelve years ago, so this promise was electorally powerful.

What then has gone wrong? Why do BJP spokespersons when asked about some new tale of corruption respond cynically that the Congress era was much worse and that if the Chief Minister of Madhya Pradesh should honourably offer his resignation, then so should the Chief Minister of Karnataka, whose wealth is as mysterious. The truth is that there is no easier way to become very rich very quickly than to find a way of entering politics. The reason why so many big political leaders cling to power in their dotage and ensure that their children get into politics as well is because there is so much easy money to be made.

This is not something that has happened only since Hindutva leaders took charge, it has always been this way, but when Modi became prime minister for the first time, there was hope that he would change this very ugly political culture. It is one of his more glaring failures that he has been unable to do this and that the media has become too docile to do the kind of investigative story that appeared in this newspaper last week on the shady land dealings in Ujjain. It was excellent journalism after a very long time, and it made me proud to have a column in The Indian Express for nearly forty years now. It is true that we in the media have not been doing our job well and it saddens me to admit that I cannot go into reasons why.

When Court No. 24 became the legal preface to Emergency



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY SHUBHAM KUMAR

BEFORE THE Emergency became a midnight story, it had a courtroom preface. On the night of 25-26 June 1975, Opposition leaders were arrested, the presses were censored, and freedoms began to shrink. But the political chain of events that led to that night had been triggered two weeks earlier through a judge's verdict in Allahabad. The Emergency is remembered through Delhi's darkness. Its legal pre-history unfolded in daylight.

That daylight can be traced to two rooms of the Allahabad High Court. Justice Jagmohanlal Sinha sat in Court No. 5. When Indira Gandhi came to give evidence in the election petition filed by Raj Narain, challenging the then-PM's Rae Bareilly victory, the proceedings were held in Court No. 24. It stood at one end of the building — easier to secure without disrupting other courts.

The story began in the 1971 general elections. After the Congress split of 1969 and the early dissolution of the Lok Sabha in December 1970, the Opposition tried "Indira Hatao" and she answered with "Garibi Hatao". In Rae Bareilly, Indira Gandhi polled 1,83,309 votes, Raj Narain received 71,499.

For most candidates, that margin would have closed the matter. Raj Narain carried it to court. In April 1971, he filed an election petition under the Representation of the People Act, 1951, alleging misuse of official machinery, campaign expenditure, and the role of Yashpal Kapoor, who had worked in the PM's Secretariat before joining Indira Gandhi's campaign. Over time, the case narrowed around Kapoor and a set of dates. Kapoor had resigned from government service in January 1971. The court had to decide when that resignation took effect, whether



Court No. 24 of the Allahabad High Court is now Court No. 34 SHYAMLAL YADAV

he had begun election work before leaving service, and when Indira Gandhi had begun her Rae Bareilly run. Election law treats assistance from government servants, deployed to advance a candidate's prospects, as a corrupt practice. Officials, police, and public facilities belong to the Republic, not to a ruling party's campaign. In Rae Bareilly, this ordinary rule had become historic because the candidate under scrutiny was also the PM.

For three years, the case moved slowly until Justice Sinha took charge after the 1974 summer vacation and pushed it forward. In March 1975, Indira Gandhi's appearance as a witness enlivened the case. The arrangements outside Court No. 24 were an Emergency-like rehearsal before the Emergency. Police guarded the gates. Entry was restricted to lawyers, reporters, and pass-holders. A metal detector stood in the passage. There, a briefcase incident, involving an allegedly unlicensed country-made pistol, caused a stir in Parliament.

By the time Justice Sinha entered, the courtroom was packed. Raj Narain was present after he assured his counsel Shanti Bhushan that he would remain silent. Bhushan didn't want Raj Narain because he was known to be temperamental and outspoken. Rajiv and Sonia Gandhi were also there. Justice Sinha announced that court convention did not require anyone to rise when a witness

entered. Outside the courtroom, Indira Gandhi was the PM. Inside, she was a witness. When she entered, some still rose, as the habits of power and the discipline of law stood face to face.

The court accommodated the dignity of office. She was not made to stand in the witness box. After consultation with Shanti Bhushan, Justice Sinha allowed her to sit on a chair placed on a raised platform to the right of the judge. Her counsel, S C Khare, examined her first. Then Shanti Bhushan cross-examined her.

On 12 June 1975, Justice Sinha set aside Indira Gandhi's election and found her guilty of corrupt practices on limited grounds, connected with Yashpal Kapoor and official arrangements. The court granted a short stay for appeal. But the political crisis had begun. Congress rallied behind her. The Opposition treated the verdict as a crisis of legitimacy.

On 24 June, Justice V R Krishna Iyer of the Supreme Court allowed her to continue as PM but restricted her rights as an MP. The next day, Jayaprakash Narayan and other leaders demanded her resignation at a Delhi rally. That evening, Indira Gandhi advised the President to proclaim a state of emergency. On the night of 25 June 1975, just before midnight, President Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed signed the proclamation.

The Rae Bareilly case still did not disappear. Parliament changed the election law retrospectively. The 39th Amendment attempted to place the election of the PM beyond judicial challenge. In November 1975, a Constitution Bench upheld several election-law changes but struck down the attempt to immunise the PM's election from judicial review, applying the basic structure doctrine articulated in Kesavananda Bharati.

Fifty-one years later, Indira Gandhi v. Raj Narain remains the courtroom preface to the Emergency. Court No. 24 reminds us that constitutional crises do not always begin with a proclamation. Sometimes they begin when ordinary legal rules finally attain extraordinary political power.

The author is a lawyer with a specialisation in public law

The Instagram betrothal experience

THE CREEPIEST part of the death of 26-year-old Ketan Agarwal, allegedly murdered by his fiancée, Siya Goyal, 22, and her paramour, is the tearjerking video she posted on Instagram soon after his death. Agarwal was serenading her with a gigantic sunflower in a car filled with colourful bouquets. The roof opened to reveal gorgeous stems above as well, and the lyrics of *Aankhon mein teri ajab si ajab si adayein hain* played romantically in the background. The footage moves to the (ostensibly) happy couple close dancing, in this carefully orchestrated, made-for-Insta proposal. (In the light of facts emerging, a chilling reminder of the frightening gaps between projection and reality.)

Time will reveal if Siya Goyal really shoved Ketan Agarwal off a cliff. But his sor did end points to the disturbing performative pressure around engagements, driven by the "For-the-Gram" culture, a puzzling phenomenon inexplicable to anyone over 40. Since I am of the age where many of my classmates and friends' adult

children are "settling down", I often see highly staged, embarrassingly cheesy marriage proposals posted online. The setting will involve a pristine beach, the girl in a pale, gauzy dress with the man in smart linens, on one knee, brandishing what else but the predictable solitaire diamond. The hashtag will read #hitched, parents and other family members will gush and repost the congratulations. Weirder still is that many of these matches are completely arranged. The *roka* has already happened, but the families have hired fireworks, professional photographers and drone videographers to portray an entirely fictional, Hollywood-inspired, romcom scene. For what? To brag — on Instagram.

Splashy drama has always been part and parcel of the big fat Indian wedding. There's an ever pressing burden not just to walk down the aisle, but to do so in spectacular fashion. However, it's one thing to dance in a glittering *lehenga* on a Karan Johar film-inspired set, but entirely another to participate in a cinematically



ON THE LOOSE
BY LEHER KALA

recreated delusion, especially made for Insta. Does honest spontaneity for life's precious moments count for nothing anymore? Today, the Insta-engagement farce is totally legit, that celebrates a future no one has seen, while the present of the freshly betrothed couple is so fragile and new. It sounds almost old school to say there's value in protecting the sanctity of one's private life. To some of us at least, the Insta-brag of intimate details comes across as hopelessly cringe, and shallow.

Somebody needs to drill it into Indian parents' heads — getting married is not an achievement. It's a milestone, yes, but that's about it. Let I be accused of being an unromantic cynic (having myself agreed to marry in a weak moment on a drunken New Year's Eve), I genuinely can't believe an entire generation of affluent Indians need these curated grand gestures to feel validated. The wedding planners are the ones having the last laugh; the "pre-wedding shoot" is an integral part of their package. A beachside proposal in Goa — with props like rose petals

showering down, a make-up artist to doll up the bride and some banal monologue lifted from whichever third-rate romance movie is currently trending — can cost upwards of Rs 5 lakh. Agarwal and Siya Goyal were heading to Bali precisely for this sort of picture-perfect shoot when his passport mysteriously went missing, one of the many red flags preceding this tragedy.

The circumstances surrounding Agarwal's death are a hark-back to sobering Shakespearean wisdom, the famous paradox, fair is foul, and foul is fair. Appearances can be endlessly deceiving. What looks happy and pure may also contain heartbreaking evil. Judging situations based on face value is fraught because we all exist and act out from a headspace of perpetual moral confusion. A modern love triangle serves as a cautionary note to inherent human hypocrisy. It turns out, whatever our decisions, they will come back to haunt us — in this lifetime itself.

The writer is director, Hutkay Films

TOLL CROSSES 1,400; CHAOS AND TRAFFIC HAMPER RESCUE EFFORTS AS PEOPLE SLEEP ON STREETS

‘Every person saved is a miracle’: Crucial window for rescue narrows in Venezuela

Regina Garcia Cano,
Juan Pablo Arraez
& Megan Janetsky
La Guaira, Venezuela, June 27

THE SITUATION has grown more desperate by the hour in Venezuela as people dig through the rubble of collapsed homes and apartment buildings three days after the devastating one-two punch of 7.2 and 7.5-magnitude earthquakes, knowing time is running out to find survivors.

News Agency Reuters quoted Venezuela's top lawmaker Jorge Rodríguez announcing on state television that the toll has risen to 1,430, another 3,200 people were injured and 3,100 left homeless.

Authorities announced Friday night they would block access to La Guaira, the epicenter of the destruction, as chaos and traffic began to hamper search efforts. Officials said anyone who wants to enter would now have to seek official permits.

Venezuelans took the search for missing loved ones into their own hands, citing a scarcity of government rescuers. People reported seeing few state rescue teams in the hardest-hit areas, despite authorities projecting an image of a robust government response. Aid agencies consider the first 48 to 72 hours to be a crucial to retrieve people alive, though it can be extended if they have access to food and water.

“Each person saved is a miracle,” said Jorge Rodríguez, president of the National Assembly. “We are not going to hide absolutely anything about the magnitude of this tragedy.”

In La Guaira, just north of the capital, Caracas, Nazareth Jimenez sobbed into a loved one's shoulder as she watched neighbours use hammers and power tools to try to cut through slabs of concrete in a building reduced to debris. She was wracked with anxiety as she waited to see if her siblings, nephews, nieces and friends would emerge alive. “My God, how are we going to get them out of there?” Jimenez murmured. “We're making a call for help to government and countries across the world,” she said, pleading for machinery capable of moving collapsed structures. “There are still people alive in there.”

Government forces distributed food and water to sur-



Rescue workers search through rubble in La Guaira, Venezuela. AP

“My God, how are we going to get them out of there?” — NAZARETH JIMENEZ IN LA GUAIRA

WATCHED NEIGHBOURS TRY TO CUT THROUGH CONCRETE WITH HAMMERS & POWER TOLLS; HER SIBLINGS, NEPHEWS, NIECES & FRIENDS ARE MISSING

vivors in La Guaira, and acting President Delcy Rodríguez said her government was mounting a full response during these “critical hours for rescuing people alive.” She said La Guaira had been militarized and more help was on the way, even as residents said it was just a fraction of what they needed.

The disaster poses a huge challenge for Rodríguez as Venezuela has been facing economic disarray for more than a decade, and many people reject the legitimacy of the political movement Rodríguez represents.

Indeed, many continued to sleep on the street. Omar Reyes said around 20 family members died. “I've been left alone in this life,” Reyes said, walking through the rubble where two of his children were buried. In the city of Maiquetia, people lined up outside stores and pharmacies that served them one by one behind closed doors. At one point a woman in a crowd threw herself to the ground to protect

a package of diapers with her body, desperate to keep it.

Traffic and throngs of motorcyclists at times disrupted search efforts. Mexican soldiers and volunteers asked for silence to try to hear signs of life under the rubble, but bikers — civilian and uniformed — continued to honk horns and rev engines to the first responders' frustration. Some people began to carry off basic goods such as toilet paper and food from stores in Catia La Mar, adjacent to country's main airport. Others swarmed a truck that was giving out bread and water, until a soldier intervened.

A few miles away, Yuleidy Cadenas, 28, stood across the street from a collapsed public housing building, hoping her son, mother and brother would be pulled out alive. She fled barefoot from another building as it collapsed Wednesday and found her mother's apartment tower had pancaked. “I got on top of the rubble and told them to yell back, and nobody did...” AP

Families hope online posts will bring news of missing

Associated Press
Mexico City, June 27

A FATHER holds the hand of his daughter dressed as a fairy. A 24-year-old man in a pilot uniform stares proudly at the camera. A family embraces on a soccer field.

They are among the images posted by relatives within Venezuela and abroad desperately searching for their missing loved ones.

With communication patchy, social media and online registries have become a crucial tool for many Venezuelans seeking information and resources beyond sparse government statistics. One independent online registry documented 51,000 people missing, while another listed 24,000 people unaccounted for. While some rushed to search beneath the rubble, others created digital flyers on WhatsApp, Facebook and X with their relatives' details.

Vanessa Marciano, 31, posted photos from Madrid of her uncle and aunt, who live in La

Guaira state. Marciano posted the images hoping they were only unreachable due to damaged communication lines. Her uncle's daughter and his 7-year-old grandson were visiting from the US and also are missing.

“It's a feeling of impotence and uncertainty,” Marciano said by phone. Jhoysier Concalves, a Venezuelan from the northern coastal city of Catia La Mar, was talking to his partner and her daughter minutes before the shaking. When the earthquake stopped, Concalves ran out of his house to their apartment building. There was only debris.

Concalves posted a flyer reading “MISSING” on X and Facebook. “They are pulling people out of the building alive. So I still have hope that they are in there alive,” he said.

The search was stifled by restrictions on social media and messaging platforms, put in place by Nicolás Maduro in August 2024. Soon after the UN human rights mission in Venezuela called on the government to lift local restrictions Thursday, Venezuelans could access X.

WILL MEET VIOLENCE WITH VIOLENCE: VANCE

Truce strained: Ship hit in Hormuz as US, Iran trade strikes

Bahrain, hosting
US Navy's regional
HQs, struck by
Iranian drone

Jana Choukeir
& Eman Abouhassira
Dubai, June 27



A security wall in northern Israel on Lebanon border. Deal calls for Israel to initially withdraw from two small areas or pilot zones. AP

A TANKER reported being struck by a projectile in the Strait of Hormuz Saturday, Britain's maritime security agency said, after the US and Iran each launched strikes in the worst escalation since they signed their interim peace deal.

Washington said it hit Iranian targets overnight, while Iran said it had struck targets linked to US forces Saturday in response. Saturday's attack on a tanker in the strait followed an attack on a cargo ship Thursday that triggered the escalation. Iran has made a fresh bid to assert control over Strait.

US Vice President JD Vance said Iran was to blame for any return to conflict that might result from its actions. “Iran signed a ceasefire agreement. We have honored it. If they have disagreements about how the MOU is being applied, they can pick up the phone. But violence will be met with violence,” he said on X.

Britain's UKMT0 reported crew on the tanker were safe.

Iranian state television reported that the Revolutionary Guards had fired “warning shots” towards unspecified ships attempting to pass through channels not approved by Iran, and that this was now prompting other ships to seek Iranian permits before attempting to cross the strait.

Earlier, Iran's foreign ministry said it had launched “defensive” attacks on US-linked military targets, while Bahrain, which hosts the US Navy's regional headquarters, reported an Iranian drone attack. Bahrain said Iran's latest attacks violated the MoU. REUTERS

• BRIEFLY

Kids' social media ban: Australia to double fines for tech firms



Australian PM Anthony Albanese. REUTERS FILE

Australia said Saturday it would double the maximum penalty on tech firms found to have failed to uphold social media ban for children, as evidence mounts the ban has had little effect on teens. The government will also strengthen information-gathering powers of its internet regulator, the eSafety Commissioner, allowing it to compel firms to provide evidence of steps to stop under-16s from getting an account. The maximum penalty for failures to uphold the ban jumps to A\$99 million (\$68 million) from A\$49.5 million. “... It's clear big tech are not doing enough to comply with law, there are still too many children on social media,” PM Anthony Albanese said. REUTERS

Will quit soon: Serbia President

Serbia's populist president Aleksandar Vucic said on Saturday he will resign within weeks and announced early presidential and parliamentary elections. Vucic's announcement came after a year-and-a-half of anti-corruption protests, led by students, following the collapse of an awning at a railway station in northern city of Novi Sad in which 16 people died. Days ago in the city of Novi Sad, students marked the 2024 deaths and demanded snap general elections. REUTERS

Humiliation, won't give up arms: Hezbollah rejects Israel-Lebanon agreement

Bassem Mroue & Shlomo Mor
Beirut, June 27

HEZBOLLAH'S LEADER on Saturday criticised a framework agreement that Israel and Lebanon signed a day earlier in Washington to end months of conflict between the militant group and Israel. The deal was signed without Hezbollah. The agreement links Israel's withdrawal from Lebanon to the Iran-backed militant group's disarmament, something Hezbollah disarms.

It calls for Israel to initially withdraw from two small areas — called pilot zones, but didn't say where those two initial zones will be. The Lebanese army will gradually assume full security over those areas. The two countries will agree to future pilot zones for Israel's withdrawal, the agreement says.

The deal has a security annex that includes the details of deployment of the Lebanese army and redeployments of Israeli troops. The security annex was not made public.

As part of the deal, Israel stresses that the disarmament of Hezbollah and additional security measures to be agreed upon between the two countries will eliminate any future need for Israeli army's military action or presence in Lebanon. Judge Ahmed Rami al-Hajj, Lebanon's top public prosecutor, Saturday told heads of country's security agencies to take measures to prevent riots. AP

Terrorists storm paramilitary compound in Karachi, 4 killed

At least four paramilitary personnel were killed after terrorists rammed a vehicle into a Pakistan Rangers compound and stormed the facility in Karachi Saturday, officials said. The attack took place in the compound of the Sindh Paramilitary Rangers in Gulistan-e-Jauhar area. No terrorist or separatist group has so far claimed responsibility. As per a security source, four to six terrorists attacked the compound around 8.30 pm and were engaged in a gun battle in the compound. Initial investigations suggest terrorists rammed the main gate with the vehicle they were travelling in, said Sindh IGP Javed Alam Odho. Odho said an explosion was heard when the attack began. PTI

• RULES BAR DUMPING INTO RIVERS REACTOR WATER THAT'S TOO HOT AS CONCERN OVER TRACK EXPANSION CANCELS TRAINS; EUROPEAN ENVIRONMENT AGENCY FLAGS 'INSUFFICIENT LONG-TERM FUND' FOR ADAPTATION PLANS

In sizzling Europe, trains, nuclear plants and factories cannot take the heat either

Chico Harlan
Rome, June 27

THIS SWELTERING week, the signs of a breakdown have been everywhere.

Train networks across Western Europe were snarled by heat that threatened to buckle tracks. Several nuclear reactors in France shuttered or slowed because the cooling water they were discharging into rivers was getting too hot. Museums curtailed hours because they couldn't control the heat.

At a French auto plant, union leaders called for a strike, saying conditions on factory floor had become excruciating. And electricity outages knocked out power for hundreds of thousands in France and Italy.

The heat seeped through thick-walled apartments and turned cities into hotboxes that couldn't cool at night. Sleep-deprived Europeans staggered into parks after midnight, or joined in frenzies to buy portable ACs, or even sought refuge in hotels.

“Everyone is asking, Why are we not ready?” said Francois Gemenne, a prof and specialist in environmental politics at HEC Paris, a business school. “We are becoming aware of our own vulnerability.”

quickly during recent oil booms, and builders may not have adhered to best practices that mitigate the risks of serious seismic activity, according to experts.

Engineers said that older housing erected in the 1950s and 1960s — before modern earthquake standards were adopted — may not have been retrofitted to survive such violent shaking. And many buildings were constructed on geography and soft soils that compound the danger of the earthquakes, the experts said.

TALL BUILDINGS, OLDER CONCRETE: David Cocke, a structural engineer in California and former president of the Earthquake Engineering Research Institute, said that a combination of soft soils, tall towers and older concrete structures contributed to the widespread damage, particularly when buildings pancaked, or collapsed floor-by-floor. “They just

don't have the more modern reinforcing steel connections that we put in those kinds of buildings today,” said Cocke.

Since the 1970s, engineers have known that concrete buildings are particularly susceptible to earthquakes and seek to reinforce new construction with steel. While many rich nations have forced property owners to retrofit or tear down dangerous buildings, many poorer or middle-income countries have lagged in enforcing upgrades as they battled more immediate woes.

“Some of the more advanced countries like Japan and New Zealand and the US have made those changes, but some of the other countries have not,” Cocke said. “It's a very typical kind of construction all over the world.”

‘SOFT STORIES’ & SOFT SOIL: Other experts noted that a number of buildings that collapsed also had non-structural

walls comprised heavy bricks, or they had “soft stories” in which their ground floors consisted of garages or similar open spaces.

Such construction increases the risk of pancaking, they said. “Soft stories are a huge problem everywhere in the world,” said Eduardo Miranda, a professor of civil and environmental engineering at Stanford University. “And in Venezuela, they are particularly prevalent, and if you combine softer soils with a soft story, buildings can collapse.”

Marcos Ferreira, a geophysicist at the Geological Survey of Brazil, said the destruction in Venezuela was compounded by the back-to-back quakes, known as a doublet. A similar incident took place in Turkey and Syria in 2023, killing almost 60,000 people.

NEWER BUILDINGS ALSO COLLAPSED: Venezuelan government took steps following a deadly 1967 quake to update building codes. But it is unclear

how many buildings were retrofitted. In late 1999, former President Hugo Chávez's first year in office, floods and landslides destroyed housing, including in coastal northern Venezuela. The government went on a building spree to replace the demolished structures and house displaced people, said Juan Carlos Vielma, a Venezuelan civil engineer who is head of academic affairs of civil engineering school at Pontifical Catholic University of Valparaíso, Chile.

Some of the newer buildings appear to also have collapsed. “Something that leaves me perplexed is the fact that, among the collapsed buildings, more than one was recently designed and built in accordance with current standards,” Vielma said. “We need to embark on a process not only of reconstruction, but also of reviewing the applicable standards, since something might have gone wrong within our engineering processes, too.” AP



People at the beach on the island of Rügen, Germany, Saturday. AP

ture has deadly consequences.

On Thursday, France put its health system on the highest alert level, as its health minister,

Stéphanie Rist, described a four-fold rise in cardiac arrest cases. In Spain, statistics showed a bump in mortality.

While these are just early signals of a potentially larger toll, they match research showing the risks for Europe. A 2023 study compared 800 cities, looking at the rate at which mortality can curve upward as temperatures rise. While heat barely increases the risk of death in cities like Houston or Tokyo, it leads to drastic upward spikes in the cities of France, Spain and Italy.

Reduced access to ACs contributes to these differences. But that is far from the only factor. In Northern Europe, buildings that may have been built decades or even centuries ago tend to use insulating materials and end up trapping warm air. They rarely have external shutters. “They are not well prepared to cope with this level of heat,” said Anna Mavrogianni, an expert at University College London.

Policy makers for years have talked about retrofitting buildings and improving other infrastructure for an era of rising temperatures. France last year released a 388-page adaptation plan with 52 measures. And London this week rolled out a city heat plan that calls for widespread home renovations and upgrades to public buildings, citing more than 1,300 schools, 60 hospitals and 351 care homes at high risk.

The European Environment Agency said last year all EU countries have adaptation plans, but cited “insufficient long-term funding” as a common obstacle.

In France, the heat reached such a level it forced stoppages or slowdowns this week of reactors at four French nuclear power stations, said EDF, which operates France's nuclear plants. In normal times, plants keep their reactors safely cool with river water, and then discharge that water at a higher temperature. But regulations designed to protect the river ecosystem prohibit that discharge if temperatures get too hot. NYT

EFFORTS TO SECURE CONCESSION FOR SMALL INDUSTRIES WITH DEVELOPED COUNTRIES DIDN'T WORK

EU carbon tax: Govt to shoulder 90% compliance bill of MSMEs

The impact is likely to be felt the most by the iron and steel sector, where extent of decline in EU imports could be 24%

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 27

THE CENTRE is working on a scheme to absorb 90% of the compliance cost borne by micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs) to help soften the disproportionate impact of the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) compliance burden imposed by the European Union, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

India's efforts to secure a concession for its small industries in negotiations with developed countries have not worked, and the industry has been seeking assistance to meet the steep annual compliance costs due to the imposition of the EU's carbon tax since January 1, 2026.

The UK too has plans to impose its version of CBAM from 2027. CBAM is an EU policy designed to put a price on the carbon emitted during the production of carbon-intensive goods that are entering the EU.

Complying with the regulation is seen as a major global challenge, as declarants must track the embedded emissions of their goods, including direct emissions and, for certain sectors such as cement and fertilisers, indirect emissions. Industry sources said that the compliance cost for each

MSME unit to meet the requirement under carbon tax alone is Rs 15 lakh to 20 lakh and that they do not have the wherewithal to report the number of data points sought under the regulation by the EU.

India is the world's second-largest producer of both crude steel and primary aluminium.

Steeper challenge for MSMEs

An Indian exporter is required to submit CBAM certificates that correspond to the total embedded emissions. The regulation becomes a major challenge for MSMEs as the EU says that if exporters are unable to provide actual data, importers must use "default values" provided by the European Commission. The default values for CBAM goods have to be increased by a proportionately designed percentage 'mark-up' in their value.

"These mark-ups are 10% in 2026, 20% in 2027, and 30% from 2028 onwards. Default values, including mark-up, have been determined to ensure that embedded emissions are not underestimated when applying default values," the regulation said.

"For MSMEs, the principal challenge under CBAM is not necessarily the carbon levy



The UK too has plans to impose its version of CBAM from 2027. REUTERS

itself, but the cost of compliance. Unlike large corporations, MSMEs often lack the technical expertise, systems and financial resources to measure, verify and report embedded emissions in accordance with CBAM requirements. They may have to incur significant upfront expenditure on carbon accounting, third-party verification, digital reporting systems and capacity building," Ayush A Mehrotra, Partner, Khaitan & Co said.

"These are largely fixed compliance costs, which means they do not reduce in proportion to the size of the business or export volumes. "As a result, MSMEs bear a disproportionately higher compliance burden than larger

exporters, potentially eroding their price competitiveness in the EU market. If these costs are not addressed through targeted policy support, smaller exporters may find continued access to the EU market commercially unviable despite having competitive products," Mehrotra said.

CBAM impact on India

Imports from India would decline for all CBAM commodities, and the impact of the CBAM is likely to be felt the most by the iron and steel (I&S) sector, where the extent of the decline in imports by the EU could be about 24%, and the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Rela-

TAXING CARBON

CARBON BORDER Adjustment Mechanism is an EU policy designed to put a price on the carbon emitted during the production of carbon-intensive goods that are entering the block

COMPLYING WITH the regulation is seen as a major global challenge, as declarants must track the embedded emissions of their goods, including direct emissions and, for certain sectors such as cement and fertilisers, indirect emissions.

COMPLIANCE COST for each MSME unit to meet the requirement under carbon tax is Rs 15 lakh-20 lakh.

tions (ICRIER) working paper released this month. The fertilisers and aluminium products, followed by metal products, are next in line. India's global export of I&S will decline by 5.7%; for China, the corresponding estimate is 1.2%.

This reduction is primarily due to a reduction in exports to the European Union.

The report said that CBAM trade adversely impact India's trade with the EU and will have a negligible effect on carbon emissions, adding that the impact level on carbon emissions is hard to determine and depends on the type of inputs used to produce the finished goods in the sector.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

NSE, Jio listings could revive India's sluggish IPO market

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 27

INDIA'S IPO market has been sluggish so far in 2026 after record deals over the past couple of years, with weak market sentiment and uncertainty due to the ongoing war in West Asia causing companies to delay their fundraising plans.

However, with long-awaited big-ticket IPOs such as the National Stock Exchange and Jio Platforms finally announced over the last week and oil prices subsiding significantly as the US and Iran agreed on a peace deal during the same week, experts now believe that sentiment in the IPO market could turn positive as general market conditions improve with clarity on the geopolitical situation.

With around Rs 3.5 lakh crore to Rs 4 lakh crore of IPOs currently in the pipeline, factors such as geopolitical stability and the return of foreign investors to the Indian capital markets are key for an uptick in IPOs over the second half of the year.

Revival may be in sight

While the IPO announcements of Jio and NSE might bring back foreign investor participation in the primary market due to their established track record and large institutional holdings, the performance of India's IPO markets is heavily dependent on the performance of the secondary market, which in turn depends on the West Asia war ending soon.

"The global environment has improved due to the resolution of the US-Iran conflict, and crude oil prices have come off, thereby leading to ease in concern on inflation, deficit, USD/INR, and earnings growth prospects. This is the biggest sentiment booster for equity market sentiments and hence the rest of the year can witness revival in primary market activity," a head of research at a domestic broking firm said. The benchmark Nifty 50 and Sensex indices have gained around 1% since the interim peace agreement between the US and Iran last week, signaling a positive trend in the secondary market. Both indices, which had fallen over 11% at their lowest, are currently down just around 4% from their pre-war levels.

FULL REPORT ON
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CAUTIOUS STEPS

AS MANY as 22 companies have completed their mainboard IPOs so far this year, raising over Rs 20,663 crore in total, while another couple of public issues are currently live.

THE LARGEST IPO this year was the Rs 3,100-crore public issue of renewable energy producer Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions in February.

IN COMPARISON around 103 companies had raised a record Rs 1.76 lakh crore through IPOs in



2025, breaking the record of around Rs 1.59 lakh crore raised by 90 companies in 2024.

"It (the NSE and Jio IPOs) could also revive FII participation. FIIs have been a large contributor in the IPO space. I am reasonable that these IPOs could revive the overall sentiment in the broad market itself," according to A Balasubramanian, MD and Chief Executive at Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC.

Foreign investors have dumped \$28.4 billion of equities since the war started but have been net buyers over the past few sessions. The strong existing IPO pipeline also remains a big positive for the industry.

"As of May 2026, a total of 236 mainboard IPOs amounting to Rs 3,49,304.32 crore are in the pipeline. This strong pipeline signals an acceleration in investment banking activity,

though actual launch windows remain subject to geopolitical tensions," said Sumeet Lath, co-head of equity capital market execution at

Anand Rath Advisors. "This positive outlook is backed by a lineup of mega-IPOs like Reliance Jio, NSE, SBI Mutual Fund, Zepto, PhonePe, and Flipkart, which are set to raise over Rs 1 lakh crore from just six issues. The massive pipeline positions CY2026 as a watershed year for the primary market, though realistic valuations will play a major role in determining the final success of these issues," he added. But a section of experts have also sounded caution.

"The issue is not on the supply side. Issuers are in a wait-and-watch mode to see how things progress. For IPOs to happen, you need at least a stable, if not buoyant, second-

ary market," said Pranav Haldea, MD at Prime Database. Many of the companies filing their IPO papers aim to get the regulatory approvals so that they are in a ready-to-launch stage when market conditions improve, he added.

Muted IPO market in 2026 so far

Data from the NSE shows 22 companies have so far completed their mainboard IPOs this year, raising over Rs 20,663 crore in total, while another couple of public issues are currently live. The largest so far this year was the Rs 3,100-crore public issue of renewable energy producer Clean Max Enviro Energy Solutions in February. AI and analytics solutions provider Fractal Analytics' Rs 2,834-crore public issue ranks second. In comparison, around 103 companies had raised a record Rs 1.76 lakh crore through IPOs in 2025, breaking the record of around Rs 1.59 lakh crore raised by 90 companies in the previous year. For a like-to-like comparison, 16 companies had completed their IPOs last year till June 22, raising over Rs 26,000 crore in total.

This included big-ticket IPOs such as Hexaware Technologies' Rs 8,750 crore and Schloss Bangalore's (which operates The Leela brand of hotels) Rs 3,500 crore public issues. Weak market sentiment and geopolitical uncertainty have been key factors for this slowdown. The companies that have completed their public issues have also seen a weak listing-day performance, highlighting the damp market sentiment.

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HDFC Bank ex-chair: Board 'ignored' queries on legal review after resignation

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 27

FORMER HDFC Bank chairman Atanu Chakraborty on Saturday said he had repeatedly sought clarity from the bank's board on the scope and legal basis of the independent review initiated after his resignation in March but got no response from the lender.

According to CNBC-TV18, Chakraborty also inquired about the legal provisions under which the review was being conducted, but said those queries too went unanswered. Giving a "clean chit" to the bank, the law firms — Wilson Sonsini Goodrich & Rosati, PC and Wadia Ghandy & Co — said the contemporaneous evidence reviewed was inconsistent with Chakraborty's statement, and law firms' review did not identify any basis for the statement.

Chakraborty did not interact with the law firms which were appointed by the bank's board. On March 18, Chakraborty resigned as chairman of the bank with immediate effect, saying that "certain happenings and practices within the bank are not in congruence with my personal values and ethics".

Six days later, HDFC Bank said that the board of directors

have appointed external law firms to review the points highlighted by Chakraborty.

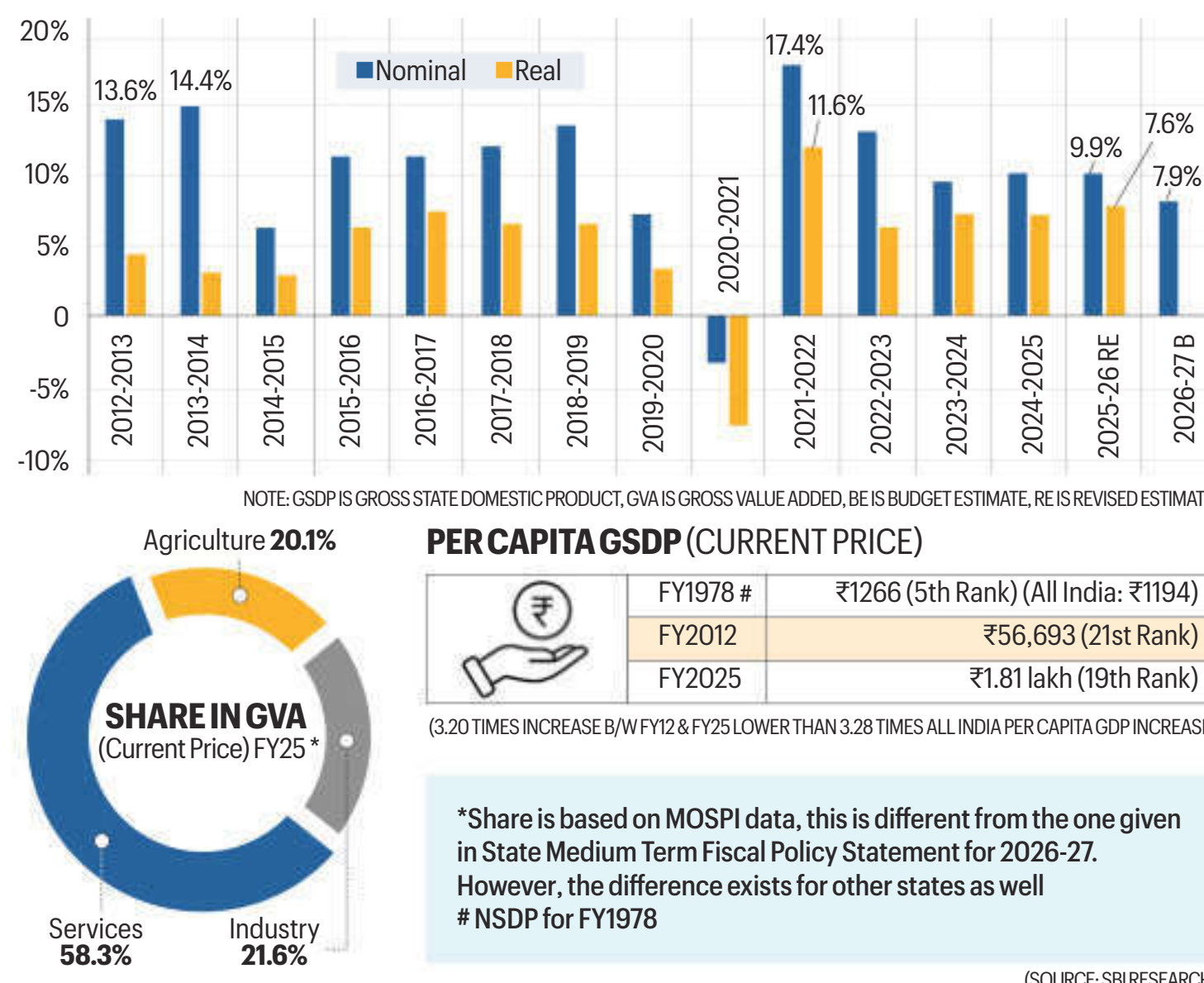
Chakraborty said that he had hoped his resignation would prompt the board to reflect on the concerns he had raised, rather than treat the matter as what he described as a "compliance exercise."

The law firms said the legal review was conducted over a three-month period and involved the review of thousands of documents and interviews of the independent directors and members of management.

"The bank and external law firms repeatedly requested that Chakraborty speak with them as part of the legal review, but ultimately the interview with Chakraborty did not occur," the law firms said. After the probe, law firms found that Chakraborty's statement and its implications were not substantiated by the record and witness interviews, they said. "Specifically, the minutes of the meetings Chakraborty attended were a product of a comprehensive drafting, review and approval process that afforded Chakraborty an opportunity to record any 'happenings and practices' that purportedly were not in congruence with his personal values and ethics," they said.

A steady slide: GSDP growth of West Bengal

The newly-formed BJP government in West Bengal tabled the state budget for 2026-27 last Monday. It made a host of announcements to boost the economy of the state, whose per capita income in 1977-78 was ₹1,266 — higher than the country average of ₹1,194. It ranked at fifth spot then, and now it has slipped to 19th position.



Vaswani to step down as Kotak Bank CEO

Mumbai: Ashok Vaswani, Managing Director & CEO of Kotak Mahindra Bank, has decided not to seek reappointment upon completion of his current term on December 31, 2026.

The bank said the decision to step down after the current tenure is due to personal reasons. "The board has, at its meeting held today, respected his decision and has initiated

the process for the appointment of a new Managing Director & CEO.

The process will be completed within applicable regulatory timelines," the bank said in an exchange filing.

The bank's board appointed him as MD & CEO for a three-year term, effective January 1, 2024. Uday Kotak, founder of Kotak Mahindra Bank, stepped

down as MD and CEO in September 2023. Kotak Mahindra Bank is the fourth largest private sector bank with a market capitalisation of Rs 4.06 lakh crore. With over 35 years of global banking experience, Vaswani held leadership roles at Citigroup, Barclays and Pagaya Technologies.ENS

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US allows Anthropic to release Mythos AI to 'trusted' US firms

Reuters
Washington, June 27

ANTHROPIC SAID on Friday that the US government has allowed it to release its powerful Claude Mythos 5 artificial intelligence model to some "trusted" US organisations, partially reversing an order two weeks ago to suspend access over national security risks.

More than 100 companies and institutions will now have access to Mythos 5, including many Fortune 500 companies, a source familiar with the new directive said, declining to be identified due to the sensitivity of the matter.

Concern that powerful AI systems could be misused by military intelligence users in

China, Russia or other countries of concern has prompted President Donald Trump's administration to take an aggressive approach to oversight of releases of Anthropic's and rival OpenAI's frontier models.

OpenAI said earlier in the day that it was delaying a full public launch of GPT-5.6 at the US government's request, limiting its access to a small group of vetted partners whose details were shared with the authorities.

Anthropic had abruptly disabled its most advanced AI models — Mythos 5 and Fable 5 — for all users after the government's June 12 export control order. "Today, the government notified us that Mythos 5, our strongest cybersecurity model, can be redeployed to a

set of US organizations that operate and defend critical infrastructure," Anthropic said in a statement on Friday.

"We're restoring access for these organisations quickly, and we're continuing to work with the government to expand access to Mythos 5 and make Fable 5 available for general use again," it added.

But, the US' vetting of which companies can gain access to Mythos has drawn much criticism. "No one knows how these companies are picked and why everyone else is excluded," said John Coleman, legislative counsel for the Philadelphia-based nonpartisan free speech organization, the Foundation for Individual Rights and Expression.

SIERRA'S ICE VARIANTS HAVE LAGGED BEHIND IN SALES OF ITS CLOSEST COMPETITOR, THE ALL-NEW KIA SELTOS

ICE didn't roll, can electric version jumpstart Tata Sierra's sales volumes

Vikram Chaudhary
New Delhi, June 27

Sierra may not have been able to match the sales of its closest competitor, the all-new Kia Seltos, so far, but experts said Tata Motors expects to close the gap once the Sierra EV, which launches on June 30, gives the brand incremental sales numbers (the Seltos isn't available as an EV model yet), and the auto major clears its backlog around the festive season.

Last five months' sales data shows that Sierra's ICE variants have lagged behind in sales of its closest competitor, the all-new Kia Seltos. Both these mid-size SUV heavyweights were

launched around the same time, but data from the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) shows that the Seltos (53,151 units) has sold almost 1.5 times the Sierra (37,319 units). Industry experts, however, argued that it isn't about slowing demand for the Sierra, but more about Tata facing production constraints.

When prices of the Sierra were announced in November last year, the SUV recorded a massive 70,000 bookings within 24 hours, which increased to more than 100,000 by February this year.

Customer deliveries, however, were muted — 291 units in December, 7,003 in January,

and 7,100 in February. The Seltos, on the other hand, took off the day deliveries started (January 2), and it sold 10,639 units in January, 10,308 in February, and 11,041 units in March.

In the next two months, Seltos maintained its sales trajectory (10,566 units in April, and 10,597 units in May), while the Sierra cooled off at 7,316 units in April, and 6,606 units in May.

A spokesperson from Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles, however, shared that the demand for the Sierra hasn't cooled off. "The current volume trajectory of the Sierra is primarily a function of supply-side constraints rather than demand. Since launch, we have



Industry experts, however, attributed the slow pick up to production constraints. REUTERS

faced limitations in the availability of certain supplier components, which have impacted

our ability to fully meet demand," he said. "Customer response to the Sierra continues

to be very robust, and we are actively working with our supplier partners to address the bottlenecks and progressively ramp up production in the near term." He added that the waiting period for the Sierra is up to 12 weeks, depending on the variant, colour, and location, and as supplies improve, Tata Motors expects growth in volumes, accelerated deliveries, and reduced waiting period.

Agreeing with this, Gaurav Vangaal, associate director, Light Vehicle Forecasting, S&P Global Mobility, said that when the Sierra was launched, it triggered an unprecedented surge in demand that far exceeded initial expectations.

"While a production ramp-up followed, it has lagged behind because bookings simply kept pouring in. But we expect that, by the upcoming festive season, Tata Motors will have scaled production sufficiently to substantially reduce waiting periods, driving much higher sales volumes for the Sierra in the months ahead."

Even as Tata clears its backlog, Kia India has leveraged its supply chain to keep its dealerships fully stocked. "Seltos has maintained consistent volume of over 10,500 units monthly, proving the strength of its long-term brand equity," an industry analyst said. But the strong performance of Seltos isn't just due

to consistent monthly dispatches, but also due to the trust that the brand has cultivated since 2019 when it was first launched.

Commenting on the SUV's sustained appeal, Atul Sood, senior vice-president, marketing & sales, Kia India, said that Seltos has the highest resale value among all midsize SUVs, pointing to a recent study that noted Seltos retains 79% of its value after one year, 67% after three years, and 57% after five years of ownership. "The findings affirm the enduring appeal of Seltos and reflect the confidence customers continue to place in its quality, performance and technology," he said. FE

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, MANPREET SINGH, S/o- HARJEET SINGH BHATIA, R/O-H NO.07, KH NO.37/17/2 18, GALI NO.07 A-2 BLOCK, SANT-NAGAR BURARI, DELHI-110084, have changed my name to MANPREET SINGH BHATIA, for all, future purposes.

0040862993-3

I, Satendra Singh S/o Nareesh Singh R/o House No.-112, Tehsil-Aster, Chomho, Bhind, Madhya Pradesh-477111, have changed my minor son's name from Karan Bhadoriya aged 13 years to Krashna Singh forever

0071044523-1

I, Mridula Chopra, w/o Ashim Chopra, R/o B-58, 2nd Floor, Gujranwala-Town Part 1st, Delhi-110009, have changed my name to Miridula Chopra

0040862994-7

I, Meena @Meena Devi, W/o-Late Rajpal Singh, R/o C-36, Ghaziipur-Village, East Delhi-110096, declare that Meena and Meena Devi both names are mine of one and same-person.

0040863000-6

I, Chhama W/o Hitesh Kumar R/o C-7/5, New Cottage Road, Adarsh Nagar, Delhi - 110033, have changed my minor daughter's name from Vertika Nadel to Vertika Choudhary for all future purposes.

0050292187-1

I, Simran Narang D/o Kamal Jeet R/o H-140 Ashok Vihar Phase -1, Delhi-110052, had changed my name after marriage to Simran Narula for all future purposes.

0040862964-1

I, Agnu Ram S/o Ram Sagar Gupta R/o L-1, House No-50, Gali No-6A, Sangam Vihar, Mehrauli, South Delhi, Delhi - 110062, have changed my name to Ram Kumar Gupta

0071044609-1

I, MOHD BURHAN, S/o-MOHD ISMAIL, R/?-7959, MOHALLA-SHEKHAN BARA-HINDU RAO DELHI-110006, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MUHAMMAD BURHAN, FOR ALL, PURPOSES.

0040862994-2

I, JASPREET SINGH S/O BHUPINDER SINGH ANAND R/O G-101, First Floor, Vikas Puri, Delhi-110018 have changed my name to JASPREET SINGH ANAND.

0040863003-1

I, Mohammad Imamuddin S/o Late Abdul Gafur, R/o-9/5617, Gali No.12, Subhash Mohalla, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi-110031, have changed my name to Imamuddin for all purposes.

0040862993-5

I, SHIFALI, W/O SUMIT KUMAR R/O FLAT NO 123-124, SECOND FLOOR, POCKET 25 SEC 24 ROHINI SECTOR 24 NORTH WEST DELHI 110085 have changed my name SHIFALI GOEL for all future purposes

0071044524-1

I, ANURAG SINGAL S/O PARVEEN SINGHAL R/O 340 DEEPALI ENCLAVE PITAMPURA DELHI-110034 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO ANURAG SINGHAL.

0040862997-8

I, Nityanand Jaiswal, S/o-Basantial Jaiswal, R/o-T-1309 VVIP-Addresses, Raj Nagar-Extension, Ghaziabad-201017, have changed my name to Nityanand Basantial Jaiswal.

0040862994-9

I, Sanjeev Kumar, R/O S-74B, 1-A Hargovind Enclave, ND-110068 hereby declare that Sanjeev Kumar Verma, Sanjeev and Sanjeev Verma are my names and belong to one and the same-person.

0040863000-8

I, Kritika Sareen W/o Davinder Walia R/o G-43, West Patel Nagar Delhi-8 have changed my name to Kritika Walia

0040862997-1

I, Belal Ahamed S/o Abdul Gani R/o E-159-160, Madipur, JJ Colony, Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110063 have changed my name to Bilal Ahmed. 0071044613-1

I, Zafar Malik, father of, Farhaan, R/o-F-95/4, Shaheen-Bagh Abdul-Fazal Enclave Part-2, New Delhi-110025, have changed my minor son name to Farhaan Malik for all, purposes. 0040863000-1

I, Usha Devi W/o Jitender Singh R/o Plot No-22, KHNO-2853/4, Min Jai Ambey Enclave, Shahpur Bamheta, Mansarovar Park, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201009 Change My Name to Usha New Name Permanently.

0040863003-3

I, Darshan Kumar Maggon, S/o-Late Sh. Devi Dayal Maggon, resident of-204, Sainik-Vihar, Pitampura, North West-Delhi, Delhi-110034, have changed my name and shall henceforth be known as Darshan Singh.

0040862993-7

I, NITIN KR JAIN S/o Basant Kumar Jain, X/3607, Gali No-4, Shanti Mohalla, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi-31 have changed my name to NITIN KUMAR JAIN.

0071044577-1

I, AJAY PANWAR, S/O BANWARI LAL R/O HNO.743/35 GALI NO.1 WEST RAJEEV-NAGAR GURGAON HARYANA-122001.HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO AJAY PAWAR.

0040862997-10

I, MAMTA MITTAL, W/O SUSHIL KUMAR MITTAL R/O-B-230, 2ND-FLOOR, LOK VIHAR, PITAM PURA, North West Delhi, 110034, Have changed My Name to MAMTA DEVI, permanently.

0040863006-1

I, SHALINI, W/O ANKIT NIGAM R/O T-3/405 ACE DIVINO PLOT NO GH-14-A NOIDA EXTENSION SECTOR 1 BISHRAKH SURAJPUR GAUTAM BUDDHA NAGAR UTTAR PRADESH - 201306 have changed my name SHALINI SRIVASTAVA for all future purposes

0071044519-1

I, JITENDRA KUMAR, S/O-SH.BHAGWATI SARAN, R/O-H.NO.488, MAIN BAZAR-CLOCK TOWER, SUBZI MANDI DELHI-110007, have changed my name to JITENDER KUMAR AGGARWAL.

0040862997-3

I, MOHAMMAD USMAN, S/O-MOHD HANIF, R/O-H.NO.C-16, RANI GARDEN-GEETA COLONY, DELHI-110031, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MOHD USMAN FOR FUTURE.

0040862994-4

I, Sujata Krishnamurthi Bhattacharya, W/o-Saugata Bhattacharya, R/o-173 Munirka-Enclave Nelson Mandela Marg, New Delhi-110062, have changed my Name to Sujata Krishnamurthi for all, purpose

0040863000-3

I, Simran Narang W/o Shaurya Narula R/o H-140, Phase-1, Ashok Vihar, Delhi 110052 changed my name to Simran Narula for all purposes

0040862962-1

I, Mumtaz Begum w/o Akbar Khan R/o-1300, Gali Sharif Wali, Kalan Mahal, Darya Ganj, Delhi-110002, have changed my name to MUMTAZ KHAN permanently.

0040862993-9

I, Ravinder S/o Pohap Singh R/o H.No.-208/3, Rajiv Colony, Gurgaon (Haryana)-122001, have changed my name to Ravinder Kumar.

0040862997-6

I, Rita Rani, DOB 11-08-1975, W/O Anil Kumar Ranga, D/O Ram Mehar, R/O D1, Sector-16, Rohini, Delhi, have changed my name to Rita Ranga after marriage for all purpose

0130066285-1

I, Mohammad Asim Zamir Khan, S/o-Zamir Ahmad Khan, R/o-D-226, Abul Fazal Enclave, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Mohd Asim Zamir khan, for all future, purpose

0040862997-12

I, SURESH CHAND S/o- MADAN LAL, House Number-C-100, Rishi Nagar Chawla Colony, Ballabhgarh, Faridabad, Haryana-121004 Have Changed My Name SURESH CHAND JAIN, permanently

0040863006-3

I, Pawan Sethi S/o Kedar Nath Sethi R/o QU-90A, Pitampura, Delhi have changed my name to Pawan Kumar Sethi.

0040863000-10

I, Jitender Kumar S/o Sher Singh R/O Sector-17, Rohini, Delhi, declare that Priyansh Nathale is my biological son. Our different surnames are by choice. We share a legal father-son relationship for all purposes.

0071044501-1

I, Sudesh W/o Ravinder Kumar R/o H.No. -208/3, Rajiv Colony, Gurgaon (Haryana)-122001, have changed my name to Sudesh Kumar.

0040862997-5

I, Ashim Kumar Chopra, s/o-Pashiri Lal Chopra, R/o-B-58, 2nd Floor, Gujranwala Town Part 1st, Delhi-110009, have changed my name to Ashim Chopra

0040862994-6

I, Ram Kishor Bhadana, S/o-Khajian Singh, R/o-F-1802, Ilibiza-Town, Sector-39, Surajkund-Faridabad, Haryana-121009, hav e changed my name to Ram Kishore for all purposes.

0040863000-5

I, HARJEET SINGH, S/o-BALBIR SINGH BHATIA, R/O-H.NO.07, KH NO.37/17/2 18, GALI NO.07 A-2 BLOCK, SANT-NAGAR BURARI, DELHI-110084, have changed my name to HARJEET SINGH BHATIA, for all, future purposes.

0040862993-2

I, Mohd Ikhlak S/o Nanu Malik R/o-Mohammadiganj, jalalabad, Shamli, UP have changed my name to Ikhlak Malik.

0071044607-1

I, Neha Singh Yadav, W/O-Ashish Gujral, R/O G-16/15, First floor, Lane G-16 Silver-Oaks Apartment DLF-City phase-1, Gurgaon-122002, have changed my name to NEHA GUJRAL Permanently

0040862994-1

I, JEYARAMULU RAJA alias J RAJA, S/o Jayaramulu Muthurajulu, R/o P.No-A1/A, F.No-G1, Intech-Santham APT, 3rd-Steet Santhikinetan, Colony, Madamb akkam Chennai, Tamilnadu-600126, have changed my name to RAJA JAYARAMULU.

0040863000-12

I, Ishaq Khan, S/o-Maqbool, R/o-H.No.787, Pragati-Marg, Hindon Vihar, Ghaziabad, UP-201001, have changed my name, from Ishaq Khan to Mohammad Ishaq (DOB-26/02/1986) Ishaq Khan and Mohammad Ishaq is one and the same-person. 0040862993-4

Janardhan Prasad S/o Mangla Nand R/O Village & Post Office: Karakot, Patti Gagwarsyu, Pauri Garhwal, Uttarakhand Have Changed My Name Janardhan Prasad To Janardhan Prasad Juyal For All Future Purposes.

0071044498-1

I, Manish Suryavansh S/o Jitender Singh R/o Plot No-22, KHNO-2853/4, Min Jai Ambey Enclave, Shahpur Bamheta, Mansarovar Park, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201009 Change My Name to Manish Suryavansh New Name Permanently.

0040863003-2

I, NITIKA YADAV, W/O SH. KRISHAN YADAV, R/o, H.NO.1110, NEAR GOVT. GIRLS SCHOOL, VPO WAZIRABAD, SECTOR-62, GURUGRAM, HARYANA-122003, have changed my name from NITIKA to NITIKA YADAV, for all, future purposes.

0040862997-7

I, VIPIN KUMAR GUPTA, S/o-Ved Parkash Gupta, R/o-8C/2, Rajpur-Road, Civil-lines, Delhi-110054, have changed my name to VIPIN GUPTA for all future purposes.

0040862994-8

I, Pratyaksh S/o Vivek Kumar, E-835, Lohiya Gali No. 4, Babarpur, Shahdara, North East Delhi, Delhi-110032, changed my name as Pratyaksh Singh Beniwal.

0130066256-1

I, Rajeev Bansal S/o Shri Harish Chander Bansal, R/o B-1 Balaji Apartment, Nai Basti, Deoli, Delhi-110062 have changed my name from Rajiv Bansal to Rajeev Bansal for all future purposes.

0040862966-1

I, Brij Pal Singh alias Bablu S/o Babu Ram Upadhyay R/o L1/1100/1625, Asthal Mandir, Sangam Vihar, Meharauli, South Delhi, Delhi - 110062, have changed my name to Brijpal Upadhyay

071044610-1

I, RAVINDER, S/o SATBIR SINGH, R/O H no 217, Pana Todran, Nangal Thakran, Delhi-110039, have changed my minor son name DEV to DEV THAKRAN.

0040862994-3

I, MD. Kamil, S/o Sabir Hussain, R/o-H.No.4302, Gali No.19, Shanti Mohalla Gandhi Nagar, East Delhi, Delhi-110031, have changed my name to Mohammad Kamil, for all purposes.

0040862993-6

I, Nishi Chaudhari W/o Sh. Tarun Kumar R/o Village-Chipyana Bujurg, Noida Sec-37 Distt- Gautambudh Nagar U. P-201303 confirm that Nishi Chaudhari and Nishe Chaudhary names are belongs to same person. Will be Known as Nishi Chaudhari. And My Right Date of Birth-10.09.1987.

0071044525-1

I, PARVEEN SINGAL S/O NEKI RAM SINGHAL R/O 340 DEEPALI ENCLAVE PITAMPURA DELHI-110034.HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO PARVEEN SINGHAL.

0040862997-9

I, Rajesh Singh, S/o-Sarvan Singh, R/o P-101, Antriksh Golf-1, Sector-78, Noida, G.B. Nagar, have changed my name to Rajesh Kumar Singh.

0040862994-10

I, Reena Malik D/o Ramesh Malik W/o Pawan Kumar Sethi, R/o QU-90A, Pitampura, Delhi have changed my name to Reena Sethi.

0040863000-9

I, Afaq Ahmed S/o Amanullah Khan R/o F-8, 4th Floor, Khajoorji Road, Joga Bai Extn Okhla, Jamia Nagar, South Delhi, New Friends Colony, Delhi, 110025, have changed my minor son's name from Arhaan Ahmed aged 05 years to Sulaiman Ahmed forever.

0071044510-1

I, Tajender Pal Singh, S/o-Jasbir Singh, R/O A-36 Third-Floor, Vikas Vihar Gali No-30, Chander-Vihar Nilothi Extension, have changed my name to Tajinder Pal Singh.

0040862997-2

I, Nazreen, W/o Zafar Malik, R/O-F-95/4, Shaheen-Bagh Abdul-Fazal Enclave, Part-2, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name to Nazreen malik for all purposes.

0040863000-2

I, Geeta Devi Srivastava W/O, Manoj Kumar R/o Flat 301, T5, Rise Organic Homes, Jaipuriya Sunrise Greens, Nh24 have changed my name to Geeta Srivastava.

0040862843-1

I, hithero known as Ruqayya Zaheer, W/o-Jasdeep Singh Marwaha, R/O-J.121, Kirti-Nagar, Ramesh-Nagar, Delhi-110015, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as MEHER KAUFER.

0040862993-8

I, Simranjit Kaur W/O Gurmeet Singh Kataria R/O 208 Tagore Park Near Model Town, Delhi-110009, Changed my name to Simranjot Kaur.

0040863000-7

I, Eshha Gupta W/O Shri Rajat Gupta R/O D-277, Vivek Vihar, Delhi-110095, have changed my name to Esha Gupta for all purposes.

0040862892-3

I, MAHIPAL SINGH JAIN S/o Sher Singh, I-1036, Block-I, Jahangir Puri, Delhi-33, have changed my name to MAHIPAL SINGH.

0071044582-1

I, Muzzamil Javed Khan, S/o-Abdul Salam Khan, R/o-F-13/6, Block-F Joga Bai, Extn. Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, have changed my name Muzzamil Javed Khan, to Muzammiljaved Khan

0040862997-11

I, SUSHIL KUMAR MITTAL, S/O DURGA PRASAD MITTAL, R/O-B-230, 2ND FLOOR, LOK VIHAR, PITAM PURA, North West Delhi, 110034, Have Changed My Name To SUSHIL KUMAR, permanently

0040863006-2

I, Shakeel Ahmad S/o Khalil Ahmed, R/o 8882, Naya Mohalla, Pul Bangash, Azad Market, North Delhi-110006, have changed my name to Shakeel Ahmed.

0071044497-1

I, SAHNARA KHANAM, W/O-MD AFROZ ALAM, R/O-GRAM-BISHNUPURA-NANHAKAR, POST-DARIYAPUR, MURLI, EAST CHAMPARAN, BIHAR-845417, have changed my name to SHAHIN ARA for all future purpose.

0040862997-4

I, SHABUDDIN, S/O-BABU C/O-Sabudeen, T-69, GROUND FLOOR, WARD NO-6, ISLAM-COLONY GALI NO-5, MEHRAULI, MEHRAULI, SOUTH DELHI, DELHI-110030, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME SABUDEEN, FOR ALL, FUTURE, PURPOSES

0040862994-5

I, Bhavesh Manila khona, S/o-Manilal Khona, R/o-J-4/18C 1st-floor right-side khirki-extn Krishna-Mandir Lane, new delhi-110017, have changed my name Bhavesh Khona for all purpose

0040863000-4

I, MANEET KAUR, W/o-HARJEET SINGH BHATIA & D/o-SARANPAL SINGH, R/O-H.NO.07, KH.NO.37/17/2.18, GALI NO.07, A-2 BLOCK, SANT NAGAR BURARI, DELHI-110084, have changed my name to MANEET KAUR BHATIA, for all, future purposes.

0040862993-1

I, Akbar S/o Ayub Khan R/o 1300, Gali Sharif Wali Kalan Mahal Darya Ganj Delhi-110002, have changed my name to AKBAR KHAN permanently

0040862993-10

I, Shyam Babu S/o Daya Nand Prasad R/o Ward No-08, Nasriganj, Rohtas, Bihar-821310, have changed my name to Satyanarayan Prasad

0071044600-1

I, Shaheen D/o Shamsuddin R/o-C/10 Street No-5 New Brijpuri Delhi, has changed my name to Shaheen Naaz for all purpose.

0040862997-13

I, DINESH KUMAR S/o Bhagirath Lal R/o-BD-77 Vishakh Enclave, Pitampura Delhi-110088, have changed my name to DINESH BANSAL.

0040863000-11

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0040862974-1

LOST & FOUND

LOST Original Allotment Letter, Possession Letter and Handing Over / Taking Over Letter, issued by Shubh Laxmi CGHS Ltd, Plot 13B, Sector 6, Dwarka, New Delhi 110075, in the name of Col. Onkar Singh Sehgal, Flat No.44 (S.No. 008, M.No.173) Finder please contact Jagdeep Singh Sehgal 9811394799.

0040862950-1

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0130066258-2

PUBLIC NOTICE
It is hereby notified for the information of the general public that my client Mr. Hitesh Kumar, intends to purchase property i.e. Plot R-5/11 consisting Ground Floor, First Floor & Second Floor (with right built on Plot No. E-11), area 180.99 sq. yds., at Mancha Luxury Flats, G.I.P., Sector-72 & 73, Faridabad, Haryana from M/s. Neelam Yadav W/o Mr. Rajbir Singh R/o House No. 163, Viji-Mallena, Ballabgarh, Haryana. That the original documents i.e. Builder-Buyer Agreement and Possession Letter in favour of M/s. Vanika Sharma & M/s. Lekhna Sharma in respect of subject property is not traceable. Any person having any rights or interest by way of agreement, sale, contract, encumbrance or otherwise may require to give notice of claim to the undersigned within 7 days from the date of publication, failing which any such right, title, interest, or claim, if any, will be deemed to have been waived and no binding or vest. Claims, if any, may be presented to conclude the transaction of sale without reference to the same, if any.

Gourav Nagar (Advocate) Office at- L-1, Block-I, Tis Hazari Court Complex, Tis Hazari, Delhi-110006

DEATH ANNIVERSARY



PUBLIC NOTICE

I am the sole and absolute owner of the property bearing No.M-40, Greater Kailash-I, New Delhi 110048, measuring 510 Sq. Yds. I have misplaced/lost the Original Sale Deed dated 28.11.1963 executed in respect of the aforementioned immovable property, by D.L.F. Housing and Construction Pvt. Ltd., in favour of my father, namely, Sh. K.B.Lal Seth (since deceased) as well as the Original Reimbursement Deed dated 13.11.2020 executed by my sister's namely, Mrs. Nita Nakra and Mrs. Rita Ahuja, both daughters of Late Sh. K.B. Lal Seth, whereby both my sisters had relinquished all their rights, titles and interests, in the said aforesaid immovable property, in my favour. MEMBERS OF THE PUBLIC ARE HEREBY CAUTIONED not to purchase the aforesaid Immovable Property or any part thereof, from any third Party/Entity, nor accept the same as security or mortgage on the basis of the last title document(s). Any person who finds or is in possession of the said document(s) is hereby requested to immediately deposit the same with the undersigned and is also forewarned NOT to use the said Documents, for any purpose whatsoever.

Promod Seth
S/o Late Sh. K.B. Lal Seth
R/o M-40, Greater Kailash-I
New Delhi - 110048.

Tiny nation, giant dream: Cape Verde stun world, Messi awaits

Sandip G
Boston, June 27

WHEN CAPE VERDE locked out Saudi Arabia, home to one of the richest leagues in the world and conquerors of Argentina at the previous World Cup, the tiny island nation battered by hurricanes were not yet certain of their progress to the knockouts. Their fate depended on the Uruguay-Spain game. After shaking hands with the Saudi players, they wandered around, searching for their messenger of hope. Finally, the news arrived: Spain had beaten Uruguay. The smallest nation ever to reach the knockouts of a World Cup were through.

Midfielder Deroy Duarte told reporters he wanted to cry. "Everyone was just waiting and praying," he said. "We deserved it so much, because we gave everything. There was so much

tension. The joy that came out is something I never felt before, and I hope to feel it again."

Soon he joined his teammates in a full-on party. Manager Pedro Leitão Brito, known as Bubista, strolled in furiously waving a giant Cape Verde flag. Some of his players had worn the flag like a cape. Forward Garry Rodrigues wore a mask resembling a blue shark, the team's nickname. The players sang and danced, inviting fans to join the revelry.

Bubista then wrapped himself in the flag and waltzed into the press conference room with a broad smile. Told that Cape Verde were the smallest country ever to reach the World Cup knockouts, he said: "It's us? I didn't know that." Then came the answer. "In that case we have become an example that small countries also can have big objectives provided they have focus,

determination and work with organisation. We have shown that nothing is impossible. We have represented our country but we also represent Africa and small countries around the world."

The archipelago spans 4,033 square kilometres, half the size of New Jersey. Its population is 530,000. Houston, the Texas city where they marked the achievement, alone has 4.15 million residents. More players in the squad were born in Rotterdam than in Praia, their capital. Their 26-member group plays in leagues across 14 countries.

To appreciate the enormity of it, consider who didn't make it. From their own group, two-time champions Uruguay, managed by Marcelo Bielsa, crashed out. As did Turkey, Czechia and New Zealand, all with greater



Cape Verde players celebrate their qualification with fans. AP

resources and deeper heritage. Scotland, who gave football to the world, are on the brink. Before the

tournament, barely anyone could name five Cape Verde players. Now they have the most loved goalkeeper at the World Cup in Vozinha.

The mood in camp before the tournament had been set by Dailon Livramento. "Let's have some fun. We got ourselves into the World Cup, now it's time to have fun together." They did. And they played serious football along the way. Three draws against teams far more accomplished in resources and personnel. Stopping Lamine Yamal and Nico Williams from scoring is not an accident of fate. It is defensive organisation and a heart that refuses to stop.

The day before the Saudi game, Vozinha had told reporters not to underestimate them. "We're from a small country," he said. "But we knew we would come here to compete. There's a lot of quality in our national team. Maybe a lot of you thought that Cape Verdean players don't have a lot of quality, but we've shown we are here to compete."

Next up is Argentina, the defending champions. Many Cape Verdean players will be smitten by the aura of Lionel Messi. But Bubista vows to fight as they have throughout. "First of all we are proud to be able to play Argentina.

This is a country with which we have longstanding ties. But above all our will is to do things with our identity regardless of who the opponent is. We will play our game with attitude and responsibility. Knowing that Argentina have some of the best players in the world plus Messi, who some believe is the best of all time."

Whether they shock Argentina or not, they will fight. By nature they are a resilient people, roughened by hurricanes, a long struggle for independence, fickle weather and the pangs of a developing nation. They may not be finished surprising anyone.

Goalie asks to be substituted after mistake costs Uruguay

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 27

FERNANDO MUSLERA has issued an apology to his teammate and fans, after yet another costly error contributed to Uruguay's group stage exit from the 2026 FIFA World Cup. The two-time champions were eliminated following a 1-0 defeat at the hands of European champions Spain on Friday, with Muslera's mistake proving to be decisive once again.

Alex Baena's shot in the 42nd minute, which ultimately earned Spain the three points, should have been a regulation save for the goalkeeper. Muslera was substituted in half-time, which coach Marcelo Bielsa later revealed as a decision taken by the veteran shot-stopper himself.

"I didn't make that decision. It was a decision Muslera himself made," he said.

Muslera's error against Spain was not an isolated incident in this tournament. In fact, he has been responsible for all four goals conceded by Bielsa's team in this competition, with the most glaring error being an ill-fated outing against Cape Verde which resulted in the equalizer. Had they held on to the 2-1 lead, Uruguay would have been in the round of 32.

Apologises to team

Speaking to media after the clash against Spain, Muslera acknowledged his mistakes and revealed he has apologised to his teammates. "I told the lads in the locker room after the game, when they'd calmed down a bit, 'Today it's my turn, I haven't had a good World Cup.' I apologised to them and to all Uruguayans, although it's too late now. Unfortunately, despite all my preparation, I failed to perform well at the World Cup," he said.

He further elaborated: "I've never been one to hide, but to face the music. This is the most direct way to speak to Uruguayans. I never imagined I would suffer so much with this sport. Especially with all the work I put in, with how I prepared."



(L-R) Desire Doue, Kylian Mbappe, Ousmane Dembele and Michael Olise. AP



Sandip G
Boston, June 27

BEFORE THE 1984 European Championship, the French manager Michel Hidalgo had a problem. He had four virtuosic playmakers, but not a centre forward. An idea was born, he made a midfield square with his gifted playmakers, helmed by the impeccable Michel Platini. It came to be known as magic square, or the Le Carre Magique, and they inspired their maiden championship triumph of note.

Decades later, Hidalgo's distant successor Didier Deschamps - whose France beat Norway 4-1 to top World Cup Group I - had a problem, too. He had a superfluity of riches that he couldn't configure the perfect deception code. Both, Kylian Mbappe and Ousmane Dembele, were wingmen repositioned to the centre by their clubs with staggering success. But he could slot only one. He could drop Mbappe or shunt him to the left for Dembele; he could not bench Dembele, the reigning footballer of the year, either.

The confusion did not end there. He had two exceptionally

versatile playmakers, Michael Olise and Desire Doue. Both could play behind the centre forward as well as on the wings. He had difficult choices to make, the pieces of the puzzle muddying his mind. He could drop none—for the clubs, Mbappé, Dembélé, Michael Olise and Désiré Doué scored 97 goals between them last season and, including assists, were involved in 157 goals—yet couldn't fit in all in their preferred spots.

A pragmatic manager, he chose the well-worn structure of his. A centre forward (Mbappe), two men on the flanks (Olise and Dembele), and one playmaker just behind them (Doue in the Antoine Griezmann role). The first half was a miasma of broken notes. Echoes of their horrid opening game in the 2002 edition against the same opposition whirled. France had too much talent for their own liking, and they crashed out in the first round without scoring a single goal.

During the break, though, Deschamps found his magic square. He shifted Olise to the centre, in the No10 role, so that he could keep the inert Mbappe busy. He had thrived

Manager finds the right combination as former champs France continue to impress with their attacking prowess

in the role at Bayern Munich, even though at Crystal Palace, he was a winger. Doue was the auxiliary playmaker, thus a playmaking double pivot. Consequently, Dembele was thus furnished the liberty and space to drive through the inside right channel, rather than being stretched to the right side, so that he wouldn't trespass on Mbappe's space.

The result proved devastating for their opponents. Everyone could perform what everyone loves to. Mbappe could drift a fraction to his left and find vast expanses of space; Dembele could cut inside and wreak havoc. Both were repurposed centre forwards, and the instincts are quite not those of a classical centre forward relishing the centrality of the role. Both love a bit of width on their side, yet not too much width like conventional wingers. The result: Mbappe 5 goals; Dembele: 4, including a brace, France: 10 goals in three games; 23 shots on target. Deschamps' biggest

DESCHAMPS' MAGIC SQUARE FRENCH EVOLUTION

Number Plate

97

● Number of goals Mbappe, Dembele, Olise and Doue scored between them in club football last season.

headache was solved—to harness the best of his two monumental forwards. It was the chief debating point in France before the tournament.

Former legends had criticised Deschamps' handling of Dembele, who, before the tournament, had only eight goals and six assists in 61 games for his national side. "There should be a campaign to save Dembele, the way they have handled him is lamentable," Bixete Lizarazu wrote in his column in *L'Équipe*.

Inadvertently, he unleashed the most attacking iteration in 14-year tenure. It's his last World Cup, and perhaps, it's how he

wants the world to judge him—the ringmaster of the most destructive French side of this century.

The jigsaw solved, everything fell into place. Olise pulls the strings with magnificent maturity. His assist for Mbappe, a splendidly disguised diagonal pass, for the opening goal against Senegal, was designed in footballing heaven. Endowed with dexterous feet and wits sharpened by playing chess in spare time, he has a preternatural spatial awareness. He can be an agent of chaos as well as exude control.

"He is a dream come true. He doesn't play the game, he thinks the game," Thierry Henry, his former U-21 coach, gushed on *Fox Sports*. He is only 24, yet he is the beating heart of this wondrous French quartet.

Doue, only 21, has a vast repertoire of jaw-dropping skills. But he restrains himself from the flourishes. When Olise is around, he is more like the studious apprentice, taking cues

from the master. He left Deschamps impressed after the very first sighting. "He has the ability to beat people, to cover a lot of ground, which isn't always the case (for players with his profile). So he is able to play in the attack and midfield," he once said.

All four bring different traits to the table: Mbappe has pace, precision and presence; Dembele is all slick, incisive movements; Olise has intuition, a through-the-roof genius in team play; Doue is a blithe spirit, unpredictable and wild, someone who could find a solution from nothing. The communication is telepathic. When Olise has the ball, Mbappe knows where exactly he needs to move, just as Olise knows where precisely Mbappe is heading to.

When Mbappe has the ball on his feet, Dembele's mind charts out the potential paths. Mbappe assisted Dembele's first two goals. All four could assist and score goals, all perform their defensive duties tidily. They could hound individually as well as collectively.

The destination of the World Cup would depend on who could dismantle Deschamps' magic square.

RESULTS

GROUP I

Norway 1-4 France
Boston Stadium
Senegal 5-0 Iraq
Toronto Stadium

GROUP H

Cape Verde 0-0 Saudi Arabia
Houston Stadium
Uruguay 0-1 Spain
Guadalajara Stadium

GROUP G

New Zealand 1-5 Belgium
Vancouver Stadium
Egypt 1-1 Iran
Seattle Stadium

MATCH SCHEDULE

ROUND OF 32

South Africa vs Canada
Inglewood, 12.30 am

(Monday)

ZEE5 OTT & UNITED CHANNELS



Egypt to assess Salah's condition, says coach

EGYPT COACH Hossam Hassan said **Mohamed Salah (in pic)** would be assessed after the captain asked to be substituted during Friday's 1-1 World Cup draw with Iran in Seattle, leaving his fitness uncertain ahead of the knockout phase. Salah appeared visibly frustrated as he was replaced 12 minutes into the second half. Hassan said it was too early to determine the extent of the issue though it did not appear to be serious. "He asked to come off. If a player asks to be substituted, it means he felt something," Hassan told *beIN Sports*. "We'll make sure what the problem is. We'll assess him." Hassan said left back Ahmed Fatouh would also be evaluated after suffering an injury. REUTERS

SA bank on goalie's strong penalty record

IF THE first knockout clash at the World Cup on Sunday is forced to post-match penalties, then South Africa's Ronwen Williams is just the man for the job. The 34-year-old goalkeeper has built his reputation on penalty saves and made some key stops to help both club and country. He could be a key factor if the opening last-32 tie against Canada in Los Angeles on Sunday goes to penalties following a stalemate at the end of extra time. Williams saved four penalties in a single shootout in 2024 against Cape Verde in the Africa Cup of Nations quarter-final in a dramatic one-man show that helped earn him the tournament's best goalkeeper award and a nomination later that year at the Ballon d'Or. REUTERS

Winner cancelled, distraught Iran lash out at the injustice meted out to them

Sandip G
Boston, June 27

STIFLING HIS tears, Iran captain Mehdi Taremi, lamented, more than complained, to the reporters after the dramatic 1-1 draw against Egypt that left their knockout hopes clinging by the slenderest of threads.

"It's a disaster World Cup," He repeated the word "disaster" like it's a chant, his eyes turning red with tears. A sub-standard error-strewn match in Seattle required late on-field drama to lift itself from being an academic footnote.

Taremi's tired face wore the vestiges of the heartbreak that had unfolded just moments ago, of the oscillating extremes of emotions they had experienced. Perhaps, the tepid pen-

alty - a horrendous attempt in the game's context - he missed in the first half was boiling in his mind too.

In a matter of seconds, in the discretion of machine-made dimensions on a pitch-side monitor, Iranian euphoria turned to misery. The moment that was to redeem them consigned them to an endless night of regret, and an agonising wait for the results of other games.

With three points from as many games, Iran can qualify as one of the eight best third-placed teams. But their fate is no longer in their hands. They have to sit, wait and pray throughout the day. They are used to waiting—until the start of June, they were uncertain whether they would even compete in the tournament, the war

with co-hosts US raging on.

Iran are sixth on the table and have a reasonable chance to progress. But a conjunction of unfavourable results could slam the doors shut on them. If Algeria and Austria draw their match in Group J, sending both through, DR Congo beat Uzbekistan and Croatia muster at least a point against Ghana, Iran's "disastrous" World Cup would end even more disastrously.

If it turns out that way, few teams would have suffered as much as them or made to pass through as many emotions. The last 10 minutes against Egypt was pure torment. In the 92nd minute of the game, Shojae Khalilzadeh became an unlikely hero when he slammed home a rebound from the edge



Egypt players react after the referee disallows a late goal by Iran, denying the Asian giants a crucial win in Seattle. AP

of the box, from a free-kick on the left. Pandemonium unfolded on the pitch and in the dugout. He almost tore off his shirt, sunk to the ground, found himself huddled in the shirts, sweat and tears of his team-

mates. An elderly support staff member kissed him on his forehead, someone else brought a pair of meme sunglasses and Khalilzadeh swaggered on the ground, like a hero. More than a hero. A legend.

From 21st to FIDE crown: 11-year-old Divi’s big comeback

Amit Kamath
Mumbai, June 27

INDIA HAD a reason to celebrate on the battlefield of 64 squares on Saturday after 11-year-old Divi Bijesh claimed the U12 title at FIDE World Cup in Georgia’s Batumi, prevailing over a field loaded with some of the biggest names in the age category like Alisa Genietta Yunker and Sharvaanica AS.

What was remarkable about her triumph was that after three rounds in the 11-round tournament, Divi was 21st in the 90-player standings after a loss to China’s Zixin Huang. It was a game where she held the upper hand but since she was running a temperature, she ended up losing the contest.

After sobbing herself to sleep that night, she responded the only way she knew: by fighting to victory. In fact, she went on a five-game winning streak after that defeat (her only loss at the event) and was in sole lead by the 8th round, a lead she never relinquished. “Divi is a real fighter,” said Sreejith GS, who trains her at Trivandrum’s Masters Chess Academy. “She’s done it before in open tournaments. But doing this in a FIDE World Cup shows what she’s made of.”

Among Divi’s conquests at the tournament were her victories over Kazakhstan’s Zhan-saya Sholpanbek (round 7) and compatriot Sharvaanica (round 10), besides her draws with the Russian duo of Viktoria Makhina (round 9) and Alisa Genietta Yunker (round 11). The battle with Sharvaanica was one that could become a regular feature in elite competitions in years to come as both of them, along with Charvi Anilkumar are starting to become flag-bearers of Indian chess at the U12 age group.

To put Divi’s title at Batumi



Divi Bijesh with her coach Sreejith GS. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

into perspective, she’s ranked 21 in the world in the U12 girls age group and eighth in the U11 category. Her triumph is the latest vindication of the risky move that her father Bijesh S made at the end of 2024: to quit his well-paying IT job to become a full-time chaperone for his chess-playing daughter. It’s a story that’s now becoming commonplace in Indian chess: one parent quitting their job to become a full-time travelling companion for their kids. World champion Gukesh’s father did it. So did Charvi’s mother. Sreejith, who has been sharpening Divi’s skills on the board since 2022 at his academy (where he also trains international masters like Goutham Krishna), says her ability to learn quickly from her mistakes and be single-mindedly focused on the board has led to her quick rise. “Most days, she spends six to seven hours on her chess. On week days, she’ll spend even more time,” said Sreejith.

At Batumi, her games would finish around 9 pm IST and then Sreejith and Divi would have online sessions for an hour and a half to figure out battle plans for the next day’s opponent. Sreejith hopes that her latest triumph helps her unlock one of the biggest doors for rising chess players that age: sponsorship.

Milkha’s biopic inspires Ancy to jump farther

Daughter of an auto driver from Thrissur goes past Anju’s mark that had stood since the 2004 Olympics

Pritish Raj
Bhubaneswar, June 27

Ancy Sojan hung in the air for a fraction longer than any Indian woman had in 22 years. When her feet hit the sand, she got up and looked anxiously at the board for her mark.

When the board read 6.88m, Ancy dropped on the track in joy. One of the longest-standing national records, held by Anju Bobby George, was overhauled in spectacular fashion at the inter-state athletics championships.

Ancy, the 25-year-old from Nattika in Thrissur, not only broke the national record of 6.83m, which had stood since the 2004 Athens Olympics, but also proved that all the sacrifices she had made over the years were well worth it.

“This national record is a statement that India has jumpers who have range and are rising,” Ancy said after her record-breaking moment.

While Ancy glowed in glory at the Kalinga Stadium, her father Sojan was at a loss for words back home in Thrissur.

“I don’t know what to say. It is a dream come true and a big moment for the family. Usually, I come and watch her compete but I couldn’t this time due to an injury,” an emotional Sojan told The Indian Express from Kerala. “We are a passionate family who loves sports. I used to compete as an athlete but had to leave it due to financial constraints.”



Ancy Sojan’s monster jump of 6.88m broke the 22-year-old Indian national record which was set by Anju Bobby George in 2004. AFI

Sojan had to give up on his sporting dreams and start driving an auto-rickshaw to make ends meet for his family. However, his passion never faded and he wanted the best for his daughter.

“She started with 100m and 200m but eventually settled for long jump. I really like watching her compete in the stadium,” he said. That’s something that Ancy wants to ensure – and not just in domestic competitions.

“My father drove an auto rickshaw his whole life so that I can reach here. I owe everything to my parents. They gave me all the support and trusted me. Never expected that I would do anything in return. He (Sojan) loves watching me in competitions. He hasn’t watched me in international competitions yet, and I want to take my parents there,” said Ancy after her event.

Ancy has been the most consistent Indian long jumper in the past two years. She started the 2026 season

strongly at the Asian Indoor Championships with a bronze medal and registered a personal best of 6.75m last month at the Federation Cup.

But despite consistently jumping over 6.50m, she wasn’t getting close to the national record. On Saturday, Ancy started with a jump of 6.73m and then followed it up with 6.67m and 6.72m. “The first jump was a good one and my body felt really good. I went to my coach after the fourth jump and he said, ‘your body is fine, just give everything,’” Ancy said.

When her coach Anoop Joseph said that she can get the national record, Ancy remembered a scene from Bhaag Milkha Bhaag, the biopic of one India’s greatest athletes.

“I just remembered the scene where he is wearing the India blazer, and other athletes come and beat him. Then his coach comes and tells him that if he wants to wear the India blazer, he will have to beat those guys. That scene in-

spires me a lot. I was thinking about that before the record-breaking jump,” she said. It is a cliché that it takes a village to raise a champion but clichés exist for a reason. Ancy, who started her athletics career from Government Fisheries School in Nattika and continued at St. Thomas College, Thrissur, received support in many forms. “She started from her school. First, she used to do sprints like 100m and 200m but then we met coach Kannan who asked her to switch to long jump,” said Sojan. She used to get injured a lot but everybody used to help her in the community. “All the school teachers, physios and coaches around our neighbourhood used to chip in,” he recalled.

Sarvesh sets NR

World championship finalist high jumper Sarvesh Kushare broke the eight-year-old national record held by Tejaswin Shankar, jumping 2.31m on Saturday. The athlete from Devargaon village in Maharashtra’s Nashik broke the record in his last attempt.

His father Anil Kushare had wanted his son to become a civil engineer. “But he was adamant to pursue a career in high jump,” Anil had told The Indian Express during the World Championships. However, there was no proper facility to train in the village. That’s when Jadhav, an enterprising school teacher who had introduced Kushare to the sport, teamed up with Anil to prepare a makeshift pit. They used corn husk, agricultural waste, old unused clothes and cotton. Kushare, then 18, would leap over the bar into a makeshift pit.

Years after his first jump at the pit made of corn husk, Sarvesh is one of the best jumpers in India and Asia.

WOMEN’S T20 WORLD CUP

With semis spot on line, India run into Oz

Shankar Narayan
Mumbai, June 27

“All set for Australia, one of our best oppositions. We’ll get a lot of confidence if we win that. Last win in Navi Mumbai gave a lot of confidence and broke barriers.”

Harmanpreet Kaur and her Indian side need no reminding of that magical October evening when the roof came off the DY Patil Stadium. Sunday’s must-win T20 World Cup clash at Lord’s gives them another chance to build on that belief. India have beaten Australia in two of their last three T20Is, but doing it again at a World Cup against the tournament’s form team will require their best performance yet. Despite winning three of four group games, they have looked far from their best.

The opening pair of Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma have been India’s biggest positive, but the problems begin after that. India’s desire to maintain a left-right combination has left the middle order in constant flux, with Yastika Bhatia and Jemimah Rodrigues alternating at No. 3 without either stamping authority on the role.

“I feel Jemimah did well at number three, and it will be good if she is there. It will give her more confidence,” former India player and coach Sudha Shah told The Indian Express. Harmanpreet has moved between Nos. 4 and 5 and has looked scratchy through the tournament. It has also denied Richa Ghosh the consistent platform she needs in the finisher’s role.

If the batting has lacked stability, the bowling has depended heavily on the spinners. Sree Charani has been India’s stand-out performer, taking 12 wickets in four matches and regularly striking across phases. Deepti Sharma remains a key bowler despite a quieter run after her five-wicket haul against Pakis-



India captain Harmanpreet Kaur’s form has looked scratchy. AP

tan, while the pace attack has lacked continuity, with Arundhati Reddy, Kranti Gaud and Nandni Sharma being rotated without any consistency in selection. The biggest concern, however, remains the catching. India have split 11 chances at this World Cup, with seven coming in the last two matches alone.

Australia arrived in England facing questions after Alyssa Healy’s retirement handed Sophie Molineux the captaincy shortly before the competition. Those doubts have quickly disappeared. They have won all four matches so far and 14 of their last 16 T20Is overall, with their only defeats during that period coming against India in February. Australia have crossed 170 batting first in each of their last three World Cup innings, showing how quickly they can put games beyond their opponents. Australia carry history into the contest, having won their last three T20 World Cup meetings against India. Yet India’s recent success proves the gap is no longer as wide as it once was. It may be a group-stage fixture on paper, but with a semi-final place on the line, it is a knockout in all but name. **LIVE: India vs Australia; 7 pm on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar.**

TEENAGE WONDERLAND

Will Sooryavanshi’s high backlift work in England? *YouTube* may have answer

Sandeep Dwivedi

VAIBHAV SOORYAVANSHI is 15, on his first tour with the Indian senior team, and everyone is asking the same question: will the high backlift survive tall pacers in English conditions? Before you worry, there’s a *YouTube* playlist worth putting together. Not of his sixes. Of something less discussed.

Starting with a video story of village cricket in rural Bihar. It’s from a time when the world hadn’t heard of Sooryavanshi. He’s barely 13, looks much younger. He is playing a game at Barauni refinery ground, a 50 km bumpy road ride from his home in Samastipur. It’s the final of the Shyamlal Sinha junior tournament – as the colourful banner says – where he has hit 218 from 121 balls in his team’s total of 289 in 40 overs.

The report starts with the anchor, in that delightfully Chand Nawab tone, showering unadulterated praise on the “*chhota bacha*” who he is blown away by. He repeats words like “*Karamat pe karamat kar rahe ho*”, “*century pe century diye ja rahe ho*”, “*taabad-tod batting kar rahe ho*”. They all mean broadly the same – the boy is killing it.

Soon the camera is on little Aryan, the captain of the losing side. He goes beyond the usual Sooryavanshi clichés. “*Shuru mai woh neeche neeche khel raha tha... pakad pakad ke khel raha tha ...last mai maara bhi ... koi galat shot nahi khela, koi rash shot nahi khela*.” (At the start of his innings he mostly played along the ground strokes, he was holding back but he started hitting later but he had no rash strokes), he says. It is clear, little Aryan has read the Sooryavanshi book beyond the cover.

There is someone at the higher echelons of Indian cricket who would agree with Aryan. That is because he, too, has followed Sooryavanshi and the few others like him, those who not only promised much but also delivered on it.

Vikram Rathour, back in the 90s, played his first ODI as Sa-



Ishan Kishan (L) with Vaibhav Sooryavanshi during India’s practice session in Belfast ahead of the 2nd T20I against Ireland. CREIMAS/BCCI

chin Tendulkar’s opening partner. As a batting coach he has worked closely with Virat Kohli, Shubman Gill and now has been on Sooryavanshi’s side at Rajasthan Royals. To say Rathour has seen every Indian batting prodigy since the 1990s more closely than anyone else, would not be an exaggeration. He is on a podcast hosted by the 2006 U-19 world champion batsman Taruwar Kohli. Rathour has coached this Kohli too. They talk serious cricket.

Batting flexibility

After calling Sooryavanshi the cleanest and most consistent hitter he has ever seen, he talks about a dimension of his batting that many don’t see. Here he mentions the IPL semifinal against Gujarat Titans, where at one point he had scored just 34 in 21 balls – a virtual crawl by the little smasher’s standards – but finished with a 53-ball 96.

“The wicket was up and down ... He showed a completely different side of his batting. Took time, took it deep. Once he was set he started hitting,” he says, sounding not too different from little Aryan at the Barauni refinery ground many years back.

It’s Rathour’s details on how Sooryavanshi avoided second-season IPL blues that gives an idea about the teenager’s batting flexibility. It starts with the Rajasthan Royals training staff

being aware that their star player would be on the target of rival bowlers. They knew they would try to exploit his high backlift. But Sooryavanshi had it in him to deal with this challenge.

“We knew bowlers would try bowling wide lines to him, some will bowl short or try yorkers at the start of the innings. But he was prepared for those challenges. His off-side game is better this year. So when people tried to go wide to him he started hitting them over covers and extra cover,” he says. “People tried to bowl full to him but he handled it pretty well. In between, they started bowling slow balls at him but he would change his swing. He would stop a bit and hit the ball. He is a special talent, it is this adaptability that makes him special.”

Another amateur vlog, a hidden gem, gives more clues about the making of a multi-dimensional player. It’s by a young man who first shows the world the route to the star’s home in Samstipur’s Tajpur village. He launches into a monologue outside the sprawling home that he says is painted in the RR colours. There is a barren plot close to it that has two pitches – one that has black soil and the other is cemented. There was also an uncle at home to explain Vaibhav’s training routine from the day he was barely 4 years old and the sacrifice of the family.

For close to 4-5 hours, Sooryavanshi would be asked to master one stroke at a time. So it could be cover-drive on Monday, a pull on Wednesday and lofted shots on Thursday.

Not a new challenge

The story is similar to many Indian batting greats whose fathers were their coaches. So Sooryavanshi Sr, Sanjeev, would ask bowlers from the neighbourhood to be at the net where his son is the only batsman.

As the father realised that his son needed expert coaches, he enrolled him at an academy in Patna. Coach Manish Ojha would give personal training to boys from Samastipur three days a week. The Sooryavanshi household would now have a new routine.

So thrice a week, Sooryavanshi’s mother would wake up at 4 am, cook lunch for her son and five of the bowlers who would accompany him. The entire party would stay all afternoon and early evening. Ojha had many hours to work on his pet student. The coach says he would design drills that would make him a complete player. For an entire day for close to 4-5 hours, Sooryavanshi would be asked to master one stroke at a time. So it could be cover-drive on Monday, a pull on Wednesday and lofted shots on Thursday.

Sooryavanshi wasn’t part of the Indian team that lost to Ireland in the tour opener. He will likely play the next game. In Tajpur, a mother who once woke at 4 am to cook lunch for five neighbourhood bowlers, is probably watching. She has seen this preparation up close, day after day, for years. The English conditions may be new. The challenge isn’t.

LIVE: Ireland vs India, 2nd T20I; 6 PM on Sony Sports Network and Sony Liv.

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Shape of What Remains

British-Irish novelist Maggie O'Farrell on her new novel *Land*, charting grief and starting afresh after the success of *Hamnet*



The promise of Vedang Raina

He made Kolhapuri chappals trendy in Florida, beat the best on the tennis court, refused to surrender his Indian passport and made a generation of immigrants feel they belonged. Now, he has a Padma Bhushan to show for it

Advantage, India

Sandeep Dwivedi

IT IS the early 1970s. Vijay Amritraj, barely out of his teens, enters an elite tournament at a posh Florida club, a popular watering hole for the city's elderly and influential. Fresh from Chennai, the son of a Southern Railway employee, he does not have deep pockets or formal for the evenings.

The tall Indian with a dense bushy mop and sideburns hangs around the club in Chennai cotton shirts and Kolhapuri chappals. He also carries the in-born Amritraj charm, worn beautifully with his convent-school English.

That week, Vijay beats two greats, Rod Laver and Jimmy Connors, and wins the title and the hearts of the club regulars. He remembers those tough days fondly. "Be it wearing a tennis shirt on court or going out in chappals, I was comfortable in both," he says. "For the final against Connors, everyone in the audience of 10,000 was White. Eventually, only two people were cheering for Connors. And when I came for dinner in the evening, several people in the room were wearing chappals."

This wasn't what it appeared to be — a breakout moment for young Vijay. It marked something bigger. Barely on New Delhi's radar, here was a teenaged tennis player, supremely confident about his slick serve-and-volley game and the colour of his skin, beginning to shift the perception of India and Indians in the Western world. Vijay's push for the country he was born in has not stopped. It has been mostly subtle or absolutely anonymous.

From refusing to surrender his Indian passport despite living in the United States for over 50 years, to wearing a Nehru jacket with a bold Tricolour strip for his Tennis Hall of Fame induction at Newport, Rhode Island, Vijay has always worn his Indianness on his sleeve. He introduced India to the world beyond the handful of nations that played cricket. He has been an honorary ambassador, without office or privileges, a walking billboard of everything that is nice about India.

He has not been a token Indian, a tick of the box or symbol of inclusivity. He was a big-draw player, Association of Tennis Professionals (ATP) president, and was picked by the late UN Secretary General Kofi Annan as a Messenger of Peace alongside Muhammad Ali, Luciano Pavarotti and George Clooney, among others. In his travels, Vijay has seen the change that he had contributed to.

ON MONDAY, Vijay, 72, stood at Rashtrapati Bhavan and received the Padma Bhushan, India's third-highest civilian honour, from President Droupadi Murmu. This was to acknowledge Vijay's many inspiring acts. In Delhi, many years after the Florida triumph, he recalled those 'champion in chappals' times.

Vijay says the screaming and yelling of his fellow countrymen abroad are etched in his mind forever. He often meets those who were at matches they could not afford. "In the early '70s, they didn't know where India was geographically. Did they have many Indian friends? And here was an Indian guy doing these unreal things against a champion like Rod Laver. So after watching the Indian, they try to look up: who is this guy, where is India, what do they do? It is a process that has taken India to be where we are today in the world."

Those times were recalled two years back on the Newport grass courts, where tennis's Hall of Fame induction ceremony is taking place. Vijay is not far from the other Indian inductee, his long-time friend Leander Paes. Martina Navratilova, Andre Agassi and Kim Clijsters sit alongside him. It is an elite gathering at a posh club and this time Vijay's dress is unmistakably Indian. Nehru jacket,

Tricolour strip.

Vijay's son Prakash gets the microphone. A top Indian pro in his playing days, he, like his father, is an eloquent tennis pundit with a radio voice and TV presence. He has been tasked to talk about his father.

As Prakash spoke, Vijay bit his lip, trying not to well up. In the front row, his wife Shyamala recorded the event on her phone. It was getting tough for her. She was wiping tear drops from the side of her eyes while trying to keep the camera steady.

The Vijay story, as his son Prakash would narrate, is also about the "importance of having a hero to look up to".

His son recalls the many conversations he has had with early Indian immigrants. He says they were from the time when "we people of colour felt we didn't belong, we weren't good enough, we were told we couldn't". For them, he says, Vijay "was a beacon of hope".

A young doctor in early 1970s Massachusetts, in the middle of his residency, was struggling to bond with his White senior who would unfailingly ignore him. One day that changed. It was after he had watched Vijay beat Laver on national television. "The very next day, he started talking to the young aspirational kid and asking questions: 'Where are you from? Are you from India?' They started building a bond, built a friendship," says Prakash. The kid went on to be among America's most successful surgeons.

He also spoke about an aspiring actor with Indian roots, who had grown up facing taunts and racial slurs at school. The boy with stars in his eyes got to see Vijay play a handsome, debonair Indian secret agent (in the 1983 film *Octopussy*) who helped James Bond save the day. Another life changed. From that day, he did not believe those who told him the best he could do was be Appu in *The Simpsons*.

IN HIS early years of globe-trotting, people would ask about India's place on the map and talk only about elephants and snake charmers. Vijay has watched that image die slowly. "Now the tagline for India is always the brilliance of the mind. There is this common adage among youngsters today: 'My phone is not working, go around the corner and talk to the Indian guy, he will fix it'. Where did that come from? The brilliance of the mind. All the chips that are in there, the future of AI, all of it has India."

He says Indians are not just cracking the toughest academic tests or winning Spelling Bee contests but are now earning Michelin stars. "If you look at top-notch Indian restaurants in the UK or New York, you're talking about them as Indian brands. They're not your hole-in-the-wall restaurants. These are the very fancy ones. High-end people, movie stars and musicians go there."

Finding Indian food in his early days in the United States was another matter. "It used to be so difficult in smaller towns," he says, with a what-do-I-tell-you chuckle. "So every time I saw an Indian kid somewhere on the road, I would go to him and say, 'I'm coming to your house tonight'. And not once did anyone say no."

Vijay paints an endearing frame of those evenings. They were strangers but their struggles were common, everyone trying to build their own American dream. The guests, like the hosts, would sit on the floor in furniture-less homes. "We would just have dal-roti and the next day they would buy expensive tickets to come and cheer for me."

Vijay would repay the favour with something priceless. He would give them their identity in an alien land.

SEEN UNIVERSALLY as an elderly statesman, Vijay has a word of advice for those Indians travelling abroad to work, study and settle. "Don't try to be something you're not. You have to believe in your-

self, which is why you're going where you're going, to something a bit better. You're going to improve your own style of what you want to do. The design needs to be completely different with an Indian touch to it," he says.

From his own experience, Vijay says it all starts from home and parents. "There are certain instincts and certain things that stay with you forever that are learned and embedded in you from a very young age. If you don't know where you came from, you will never know where you're going. And I think that is a very important factor for me that puts me in good stead around the world, especially in representation of my country and Indians," he says.

What about the Indian diaspora now and the newer challenges they face, the visa complications, the uncertainty about long-term stay in the United States for work? "When someone is doing exceptionally well, the need for more of them becomes vital. So in a few years, the importance of having them in great numbers starts to say, 'oh my goodness, we've exceeded all limits more than any other country'. But everything needs to be based on merit. For example, do we say: in the top 100 in tennis, there are more Spaniards, we should have some Indians in it too? I think you can't argue with merit," he says.

BORN WITH cystic fibrosis, a potentially fatal lung ailment, Vijay's mother Maggie ensured that he would turn out to be a spectacular sporting over-achiever. During Vijay's long and frequent hospitalisations as a child, she would

attend school for him, take notes, and read them to him from his bedside. Once discharged, doctors told him to pursue an outdoor sport. Tennis it was. To build her son's lung capacity, Maggie would be by Vijay's side as he took baby steps, one metre at a time. She would sit in her car as Vijay jogged to the courts to the point he lost his breath. There came a time when the vehicle was no longer

needed. Vijay was now covering the five miles that separated his home and the tennis courts on a canter. Maggie's tenacity is part of Indian tennis folklore. When she was in her thirties, she had a near-fatal accident. Her sari caught fire from the flames of a kerosene stove in the kitchen. She was burnt from the neck down and needed to be in hospital for close to nine months. Even when she was in terrible pain, she would keep asking if Vijay's tennis coach was paid. Years later, at the fag end of his career, playing a crucial Davis Cup match, Vijay would be reminded of his mother's obsession about his tennis classes when he was seven. He has not forgotten it. He never will.

IT IS March 1987 and Delhi is getting baked by an unforgiving sun. It is the final day of the Davis Cup tie against Argentina. India's chances of reaching the final seem all but lost. Vijay is on the train-



TRULY INDIAN

(Clockwise from above) A young Vijay Amritraj; with Sunil Gavaskar; receiving the Padma Bhushan



EXPRESS PHOTOS

ing table in the locker room, surrounded by a worried circle of teammates, trainers, coaches, a manager and a doctor. India's ageing star, at the fag end of his career, has been out on the draining grass courts for three days.

Day one: he beat his top seed (Horacio de la Peña) in singles. Day two: he lost a five-hour doubles match. Day three: after trailing 0-2, he has levelled it at 2-2, beating Martín Jaite.

In a ten-minute break, an exhausted Vijay is not ready to listen. The doctor gives him a warning. "You are taking the risk of permanent damage to your body." Champions are differently made, their limits are stretchable. Vijay gets up, picks his racket, and has a short exchange with the manager on the way to the court. "Keep an oxygen cylinder ready and park an ambulance by the courtside."

Neither is needed. Vijay wins. His teammates hoist him onto their shoulders. It is the mother of all comebacks, inspired by a mom.

Not a visit to Delhi goes by without Vijay remembering that day. "It's like it happened yesterday. That match was basically my life. Like the adage in the movie *Rocky*, where the guy stated that this whole life was a million to one shot for me. I think when I look at that, it's what my mother said when she was in hospital, coming out of a coma and making sure that the coach was paid and my tennis would not be hampered," he says.

THIS WAS Vijay's second Davis Cup final. The first was in 1974 but India had to boycott it as they were to play South Africa, a nation at that point in history pursuing racially discriminatory policies. India and its players took a tough stand and did not travel for the final. Nelson Mandela, from behind bars at Robben Island, took note.

"I was 20. As an athlete, it was a disappointment. But at the end of the day, you're looking at the people who are living under the most ludicrous of policies and circumstances. We can add one little bit to putting pressure on them to be able to change their way of life. It was an athletic disappointment, but a human triumph," he says.

Many years later, after the end of the apartheid era in South Africa, Vijay met Mandela. The tennis star was now a UN representative. The inmate was now president of South Africa. "We had the opportunity to shake his hand and have a few words with him. He said, 'Thank you for what you did,'" recalls Vijay.

Vijay also heard something during those days that he has never forgotten. Those wise words were from Muhammad Ali. "He always said that he was not a boxer. Boxing was just a journey for him to be able to accomplish what he was put on this earth to do. Once when he had Parkinson's, he told me: 'Keep in mind, the service you do for others on earth is the rent you pay for a room in heaven.'" Vijay has tried to pass this message to the next generation.

BACK TO Prakash and his speech. Among the many anecdotes there was one about an afternoon from decades back, when his mother Shyamala took his younger brother Vikram to McDonald's after school. The mother parked the car as the son walked in to pick up chicken nuggets. On the way out, Vikram held the door for an older lady. Back in the car, Shyamala said, "Son, that was so sweet. Why did you do that?" Vikram replied, "I see dad do it all the time."

Vijay didn't just open the door for older ladies at McDonald's. He opened it for a generation of Indians abroad.

ILLUSTRATION: SUVAJIT DEY

Ways of Seeing

In *Exit and Other Plays*, Makarand Sathe offers an insight into the act of producing an imagination that helps read a play



AS SEEN ON STAGE
A depiction of the battle between Duryodhana and Bhima in *Razmnama*

Sundar Sarrukai

READING PLAYS is always a challenge. Unlike other genres, the play demands more than just reading; it demands an imagination to ‘see’ the play on stage. In *Exit and Other Plays*, playwright Makarand Sathe offers exactly that — an insight into the production of an imagination that allows one to read plays as more than just political, philosophical or comic texts.

This ‘staging of reading’ produces a new world that can alert us to what our real world hides. Theatre produces a sense of time that forces us to listen, see and feel what everyday life masks. Reading Sathe’s plays makes us reflect on these questions, not merely as an intellectual exercise but as something that can jar our sensibilities.

The collection features translations of six of Sathe’s plays. They deal with a variety of topics but all of them draw upon mythical characters to comment on contemporary life. Through figures such as Narada and Krishna among others, he mines our cultural memories to provide a framework to see our daily lives.

Take *Four Billion Amnesiacs*, which deals with time as money, a theme often used in Hollywood films as well. Sathe, however, explores the idea through the characters of Ashwathama and Maruti, while touching upon the ideas of the ‘business of time’ and immortality.

Time and mortality reappear in *Mr Sapatnekar’s Child* but this time, through the theme of rebirth (of god) as well as the politics of motherhood.

Reading this play made me think about the ‘being’ of an unborn child in a culture that accepts the possibility of another soul inhabiting the unborn child. What does it say about a society that needs gods to constantly save them from themselves? Echoing Bertolt Brecht’s famous line from *Galileo*: ‘Unhappy the land that needs heroes’, Sathe could well be saying, ‘Unhappy the land that needs gods.’ The theme of marriage, which recurs in some of the other plays, including the titular ‘Exit’, pervades through the narrative. ‘Crossroads’ deals with the complexities of familial as well as conjugal relationships.

Two plays are particularly striking — ‘They Went Ahead’, which is a dramatic rendering of farmers’ suicides and ‘Time and Time Again, Men Take to the Battlefield’, a poetic rendering of the fight between Duryodhana and Bheema as seen from the perspective of an ordinary citizen. The latter has been wonderfully translated by Irawati Karnik who has retained the form of the original. In both these plays, Sathe’s fundamental concern is about the growing mass of members of a society that has lost the capacity to respond to injustice. Terrible actions are often ascribed to some agency such as the government, capitalists, communists, modern technology and the many other ‘ists’ and ‘isms’ that populate these plays.

But, at the end of it all, his question remains about the ease with which these systems erode the moral sensibilities of the well-off in society by co-opting them in every manner possible.

Sarukkai is Director, Manipal Centre for Philosophy and Humanities

Thick Boots, Thicker Notebooks

Fractured Communities by Umar Khalid offers a richly textured, astute history of Adivasis through the struggles of the Ho community of Jharkhand’s Singhbhum region

Pratap Bhanu Mehta

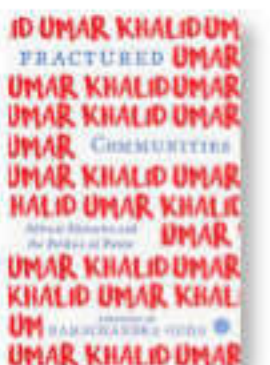
WRITING A history of Adivasi communities is an incredibly challenging methodological task. It requires a creative use of sources to piece together fragmented histories, combined with a sophisticated ethnographic imagination and ecological knowledge. But more challengingly, it requires unusual self-awareness and originality to push against deeply entrenched assumptions that have defined the field. Often, Adivasi historiographies deny that Adivasis have a history, reducing them instead to timeless custom. They deny Adivasis a sense of their own agency and ability to make and remake their world. They ignore the fact that what we think of as Adivasi customs and institutions were themselves shaped through interaction with wider political structures. They often fail to capture the internal politics of Adivasi communities and the ways in which this politics is either co-opted by, or becomes a source of resistance to, the outside world. Above all, they treat Adivasis as so exceptional and different as to make them exotic.

Umar Khalid’s *Fractured Communities: Adivasi Histories and Politics of Power* is, therefore, a rare achievement, a history written without a trace of condescension or exoticisation. It offers a richly textured and astute history of the Ho community in the Singhbhum region. It begins by showing how the region itself was politically produced through the administrative reorganisation carried out by the British. Khalid demonstrates with great sophistication how Adivasi structures of rule, centred around customary village organisation and the authority of the Munda (village head) and Manki (head of a conglomeration of villages), interacted with British power to produce a distinct modality of rule.

It is often argued, not just in the literature on India but in the study of colonialism more generally, that the British created structures of indirect rule in tribal areas by preferring to govern through local forms of authority. In the process, the colonial state invents new ideas of the “customary” even as it backstops particular forms of political organisation, both of which come to be defined as the essence of Adivasi communities. These communities had distinct identities, but states create the process of “tribalisation.” Mahmood Mamdani gave a powerful theoretical account of this process in his book *Citizen and Subject*. Khalid adds significantly to this account in the Indian context by showing that this modality of indirect rule, which frequently emerged under colonialism, was not simply a colonial at-



ON THE MARGINS
The colonial imperative to demarcate agricultural land from forests dispossessed Adivasis, depriving them of access to forests; (below) Umar Khalid



FRAGMENTED COMMUNITIES:
ADIVASI HISTORIES AND THE POLITICS OF POWER
UMAR KHALID
345 pages
₹499
Juggernaut

tempt to preserve custom. It arose out of contingent political struggles, in which contradictory strands of politics within Adivasi communities were co-opted by the colonial state.

Adivasi political structures were not stateless or primitive. Rather, institutions like the Manki and Munda became entangled in a complex politics of revenue extraction, creating new hierarchies within Adivasi society. Khalid shows how governing regimes, from the colonial state to the BJP’s spectacular success in making inroads into Adivasi politics, have drawn on these

structures. Colonial and postcolonial politics is not simply a tale of suppression; it is equally a story of transformation and political appropriation.

But at the heart of the story is the claim that the central conflict in thinking about Adivasis has not been between the customary and the modern, but between the rights of the community and the extractive demands of the modern state, whether under colonialism or independent India. Framing the argument as one between custom and modernity was, in part, an attempt to disable Adivasi political agency, which has always been expressed in demands for autonomy, control over natural resources and political voice. Constructing Adivasis as exclusive communities did not prevent them from being treated as resource frontiers, whether for expanding agriculture or mining. Exoticisation often served as a ruse for denying Adivasis full partnership in development and meaningful control over their own resources. Nor did it, contrary to stated intentions, protect their autonomy. In a remarkable chapter on land, forest fires and famines, Khalid shows how the colonial imperative to demarcate agricultural land from forest, combined with the rhetoric of

environmental protection, produced novel forms of dispossession by depriving Adivasis of access to forests. This denial generated new forms of hardship, including famine. In turn, it produced new forms of political resistance, including the extensive use of forest fires as a means of protesting dispossession.

Khalid is acutely aware that the most appalling burdens of development have fallen on Adivasis. But by restoring to them a politics and a history, Khalid sets out a new historiographical model, an extraordinary achievement for a PhD dissertation. It is a travesty of justice that a gifted young scholar, at the height of his powers, is languishing in jail without a proper trial. There is a monumental cruelty in Umar Khalid’s incarceration. The irony of denying political agency to someone who has thought so deeply about the political agency and dignity of Adivasis indicts the Indian state. But we hope Umar Khalid will soon be able to continue with his brilliant scholarship, which will be an asset in understanding the making of modern India.

The writer is contributing editor, The Indian Express



GOODDAY NAGAR
BY MAITHREYI KARNOOR
256 pages
₹499
Westland

SHELF LIFE

A Portrait of the Hood

MAITHREYI KARNOOR’S *Goodday Nagar* is a collection of 10 short stories set around people who are either from or come to the eponymous fictional Indian town. The book maps the emotional landscape of its inhabitants from the late ‘90s through the pandemic years — their aspirations, absurdities and conflicts.

Goodday Nagar is reminiscent of RK Laxman’s *Malgudi*. Like Laxman’s characters, those in Goodday Nagar are also

ambitious, jealous and morally questionable; essentially human.

The exact location of Goodday Nagar is never specified. In fact in ‘Return of the Salesman’, the town does not even exist. Through the next nine stories, the town grows but its character alternates between being a provincial town to a metropolis. Eventually, one realises that Goodday Nagar is more of a concept than an actual physical location. It is a idea of a place where the small and the significant coexist, where a vacuum cleaner salesman from the big city can become a quasi-mythic figure, and where a woman jilted by her husband can find solidarity in neighbourhood gossip.

Karnoor understands that it is within the ordinary life that real drama thrives — in the daily rituals, the staple food, the slow-burning disappointments. The residents of Goodday Nagar are largely

vegetarians: kheer, dhokla, jowar rotis, and soan papdi appear as often as character names. A mention of meat indicates the story has moved out of the neighbourhood. The divide between those who left for the big city and those who stayed back is also something the author puts to good use, as in ‘Ringa Ringa Roses’.

A circular tale of love and betrayal, the story has a reclusive artist, who abandons his college sweetheart for a younger mentee, at the centre. But it is in the unexpected ways Karnoor ties several other characters to build the narrative that leaves an impact. You don’t see the twist coming. ‘Mapmaker, Mapmaker, Make Me a Map’ is equally memorable. A 12-year old girl with vitiligo is convinced her skin is turning her into a foreigner. Her armour in the discriminatory world is academic excellence, which unfortu-

nately hits a roadblock during the COVID-19 lockdown. The story handles the pandemic with the kind of restraint and precision that a good pandemic fiction demands. In ‘Ladies of Lore’, Karnoor builds the story around the fragile relationship between a mother and her daughters. As it talks about the generational trauma left behind by the former, it shows how the siblings try to break the cycles for themselves.

What might catch a reader off-guard is the ambiguity of the physical area that the town is placed in. Don’t try to place the pieces geographically. Instead, find meaning in the peripheral, and recognise that the good people of any Indian city, dreaming of better days, navigating pandemic, heartbreaks and the temptations of consumerism, are also the conscience of the nation.

ANUSREE K C

The Shape of What Remains

British-Irish novelist Maggie O’Farrell on her new novel *Land*, charting grief and displacement, and learning to start afresh after the success of *Hamnet*

Paromita Chakrabarti

IN MAP, Polish Nobel laureate Wisława Szymborska writes:

I like maps, because they lie./ Because they give no access to the vicious truth./ Because great-heartedly, good-naturedly/ they spread before me a world/ not of this world.

It’s the kind of cartography that Maggie O’Farrell has always been fascinated by: not just the sort that traces landscapes, pencils in borders and marks out empires, but also the kind that maps what lies within — the particular topography of grief, of longing and loss, of small cruelties and a hundred indecisions.

It is what had led the British-Irish novelist to *Hamnet*, her moving pandemic novel on the life and death of William Shakespeare’s only son from bubonic plague at the age of 11, its devastating effect on his mother Agnes and how it led Shakespeare

to one of his greatest works, *Hamlet*. Now, six years and another novel later, it has brought her to *Land*, a novel sparked by the discovery that O’Farrell’s great-great grandfather was an Irish cartographer, drafted in by the British Ordnance Survey to map Ireland in the early 1860s, soon after the country had been blighted by the Great Hunger.

“I’ve been thinking about writing about it for 10-15 years. But for a long time, I couldn’t see a way to fictionalise it. It was when I went to the archives in Dublin, there was so much information — field notes, draft maps, drawings and measurements — that it became real. Even then, I couldn’t tell which of it might have been my great-great grandfather’s work because the British did not let the Irish cartographers sign their work. I did find his signature on an administrative memorandum that was sent to labourers — the Irish people were called labourers — even though my



HEATHER CHUTTER

NEVER FORGETTING
Land is sparked by the discovery that Maggie O’Farrell’s great-great grandfather was a cartographer employed by the British rulers

great-great-grandfather was educated. Just finding that piece of paper with his signature on it and holding it in my hands was extraordinary. It was also proof that the family myth did have seeds in truth,” says O’Farrell, 54, over a Zoom interview.

At its heart, *Land* is a novel about who gets to write history, whose labour is recorded, whose grief makes it on to the page. The act of mapmaking becomes a subversive form of resistance against erasure. From abandoned towns to mass graves, O’Farrell’s protagonist Tomás puts in the maps the human cost of the famine that devastated the land.

He is assisted by his 10-year-old son Liam, the writer’s great grandfather, who later becomes, for a brief period, a Jesuit priest travelling to Kerala. As it happened, O’Farrell had also been there herself about 25 years ago. “It’s vivid in my mind, Cochin — the colours, the spices and the fishing nets,” she says. But there was more to it. The same colonial impulse that sent O’Farrell’s

self or a doppelganger that walks alongside you. You always think who would I have been if we’d stayed? What would my life have been like if I’d grown up there? I would sound completely different, and I think I’d be a different person,” she says. It is the lives not lived, the selves not become, the maps of what might have been that forms the heart and soul of her novels.



LAND
BY MAGGIE O’FARRELL
436 pages
₹799
Hachette

Hamnet, her eighth novel, made O’Farrell one of the most celebrated novelists of her generation. It won the Women’s Prize for Fiction in 2020, and Chloé Zhao’s cinematic adaptation — for which O’Farrell co-wrote the screenplay — became an awards-season phenomenon this year: actor Jessie Buckley won Best Actress at the Oscars, BAFTAs and Golden Globes, and the film took Best Picture at the latter two. The same production company has now optioned *Land* for the screen.

The question of what comes after such a moment is one O’Farrell has thought about carefully. “I made a conscious choice for it not to be daunting. What happened with *Hamnet* was so extraordinary, it’ll probably never happen again. If you look at it in terms of pressure, you’re coming at it the wrong way. You have to see it as a joyful, extraordinary thing, a bit like winning the lottery. You can’t really think you are going to carry on in that same trajectory. You have to look at the joy of it — and then go on and write new books.”

The All-Round Act

Alaka Sahani

WHEN HE was pursuing his undergrad in business management, Vedang Raina joined a talent agency as a side hustle, mainly to find opportunities in music and “to land a few modelling gigs”. Following the agency’s suggestion, he auditioned for an acting job that he says went horribly wrong. That upended his original plan. But though he failed the audition, he liked the experience. “My focus shifted from music to acting,” says the 26-year old actor, who kept working on improving his skills and auditioning for over two years till he secured his first project, Zoya Akhtar’s *The Archies* (2023).

After debuting as Reggie in *The Archies*, which is set in a fictional Anglo-Indian community of Riverdale in 1964 India, and following it up with Vasan Bala’s *Jigra* (2024) in which he played Alia Bhatt’s brother who is imprisoned for a crime he didn’t commit, Raina’s next big challenge came when he was cast in *Main Vaapas Aaunga*. In Imtiaz Ali’s Partition film, he plays the role of Keenu, a Sikh teenager who loses his home in Sargodha and the love of his life. Raina says: “I’m 26 today, and I play the character of a 18-year-old boy. So, I had to lose weight and the muscles which I had gained after working so hard. Since I was playing a Sikh, I had to grasp the nuances of their culture.”

Playing young Naseeruddin Shah in the film was a formidable challenge. Though Raina didn’t get to share screen space with Shah, he did receive some memorable compliments from the thespian. “Apparently, the first time Naseer sir saw the film, he said ‘This young guy is brilliant’. When I met him, he said: ‘Vedang, because of you, people are going to think that I’m an amazing dancer’.”

When I met Naseeruddin Shah (during the shoot for *Main Vaapas Aaunga*), he said: ‘Vedang, because of you, people are going to think that I’m an amazing dancer’

Though *The Archies* and *Jigra* received mixed reactions, the response to *Main Vaapas Aaunga* has been rewarding. “I always feel like I need to keep moving ahead. That’s what I felt even when there were setbacks. I’ll continue to feel like that, the need to improve, and to keep on going (even after his film’s success).

Now, however, I believe I have taken one step closer toward the kind of actor I want to be,” says Raina, who found an emotional resonance with the film’s central theme. Raina’s family, who are Kashmiri Pandits, left Srinagar in the ‘90s, moved to Delhi and later to Mumbai.

While portraying the character of Keenu, the actor could connect with the feeling of leaving

Vedang Raina on portraying loss and displacement in *Main Vaapas Aaunga*, reconnecting with his Kashmiri roots, balancing acting and music and why he still misses mathematics



NEVER GIVE UP
(Above) Vedang Raina; in *Main Vaapas Aaunga*, where he plays a Sikh teenager

everything behind and having to start afresh. “Through the film and while researching about that period and the Partition, I felt more connected to my Kashmiri roots. I found myself asking more ques-

tions to my parents and grandparents,” he says. Raina visited Srinagar for the first time in 2023 with his family. During this visit, he was moved by the way they spoke about Kashmir and their childhood in Srinagar. “I feel like I belong there and I want to go back there. Maybe, I will be able to live there someday,” says the Mumbai-based actor.

His passion for cinema is not limited to pursuing a career in acting but extends to understanding filmmaking and “consuming movies as an audience”. A self-confessed cinephile, whose room at home is dotted with posters of Martin Scorsese’s *Taxi Driver* (1976) and *Casino* (1995), he grew up watching acclaimed Hollywood films and Indian classics. Later, he explored world cinema. “I watch all kinds of films. I enjoyed watching *Pyasa* (1957) and *Mera Naam Joker* (1970) as well as *Goodfellas* (1990). I love the movies of Quentin Tarantino and Akira Kurosawa. I

Through the film and while researching about that period and Partition, I felt more connected to my Kashmiri roots. I found myself asking more questions to my parents and grandparents

have watched Satyajit Ray’s *The Apu Trilogy* and the movies of Bimal Roy, recommended by Imtiaz sir, are on my watchlist,” says Raina.

Even though Raina has emerged as a young actor to watch out for, singing still remains an integral part of his artistic journey. In the film, he has given voice to *Mas-kara*, composed by AR Rahman. Previously, he sang *Jigra’s Phoolon ka taarka* and *Everything Is Politics* in *The Archies*. “Singing is something that I’ve always done in my life. I used to perform during inter-school and inter-college festivals. I feel so alive when I sing on stage. When I’m getting these opportunities to sing, I feel the same excitement, except that now it’s a much wider audience,” says Raina, who wants to resume his Hindustani classical training soon.

Raina’s talent, however, goes beyond acting and music. Recently, during a fun shoot, he surprised people with his cricketing skills as he hit most of the deliveries successfully. Does he have any other hidden talent? “I don’t know if this would be counted as a hidden talent. I am very good at a video game called FIFA. I used to play football too,” says Raina, who has been staying up at night to watch the FIFA World Cup 2026 matches.

Even though life has taken him away from academics, he still misses it. Raina, who had scored 97 per cent in Class 12 (science) board exams, recalls telling a school friend how he misses doing calculus or solving an integration question, and then referring to the textbook to make sure the answer is correct. However, he believes that more singing, acting demands “an academic approach”. “There is a lot of literature related to acting that you can study. I approach a performance or a character in a way similar to how I approached my board exams. It’s different in terms of the preparation, but it’s the same in terms of the effort put in,” says the actor, who eventually wants to dabble with screenwriting and direction.



THE LAST LAUGH
A still from *Pritam and Pedro*; (below) Rajkumar Hirani

Two is Company

Pritam and Pedro, *Rajkumar Hirani’s* first OTT series, brings together his son Vir and actor Arshad Warsi

Alaka Sahani

MORE THAN two decades after the release of *Munna Bhai MBBS* (2003), actors Arshad Warsi and Vir Hirani — who appeared together on screen in *Munna Bhai MBBS* as father and son, named ‘Circuit’ and ‘Short Circuit’ respectively — have reunited for Rajkumar Hirani’s maiden web-series *Pritam and Pedro*. Set in Goa, the series features Arshad as Pedro Gonsalves, a cop with no knowledge of computers, who is transferred to the cyber cell where he teams up with Pritam Parker, a hacker, to trace the kidnapped son of a minister.

For Rajkumar Hirani, the series happened by chance. “Every time I met Uday Shankar, he would ask me why I wasn’t making something for streaming,” says Hirani, who has produced and co-written the show. When he came across the writings of cybercrime expert Amit Dubey, he thought of weaving them and developing a larger narrative. Since that was not coming through, they created a warm buddy story featuring a cop and a hacker.

Hirani roped in cinematographer-cum-director Avinash Arun to helm the project. “We vibe well. We even share the same birth date,” says Hirani. For Arun, who has earlier directed shows like *Paatal Lok Season 2* (2025) and

School of Lies (2023), the project was a chance to work in Goa. Hirani says that while he had filmed a song of *Lage Raho Munna Bhai* (2006) in Goa, this was the first time he had set an entire narrative there. The making of a series, which combines cybercrime, friendship and comedy, had many fun moments too.

Even though Hirani considered other actors for the role of Pedro, he eventually offered the role to Arshad. Known for his comic timing, Arshad says it was a joy to work with Hirani’s son Vir who is making his screen debut. “Vir was a baby who was pushed into doing something when we shot for *Munna Bhai MBBS*. I never thought that we would be working together. It’s a wonderful warm feeling. He is special to me. He is not just a co-actor. I look out for him. It is hard to explain. But if my son were acting, this is what it would be like,” says Arshad.

Vikrant Massey plays the role of cybercriminal Martin in this comedy-drama, scheduled to release on JioHotstar on July 3. The *12th Fail* actor was drawn to the opportunity of playing “an anti-hero” in a series that examines society’s growing dependence on technology. Though he had explored darker territory in *Sector 36* (2024), he says this role offered a different challenge. “This is Rajkumar Hirani’s world, which gives an actor the opportunity to explore different skill sets,” he says.

Following the success of his movies, including *Munna Bhai MBBS*, *3 Idiots* (2009) and *PK* (2014), Hirani is known for feel-good comedies that pack emotions and social messages. However, both Hirani and Arshad agree that making audiences laugh has become significantly challenging in the age of reels, social media and stand-up comedy. “We have to reinvent ourselves while making comedy films,” says the director-producer. Arshad believes humour itself has evolved. “Gen Z has a very different sensibility,” he says, noting that younger viewers often gravitate towards sharper, more satirical comedy.

Yet, both of them underline the importance of exercising restraint. “There’s a fine line between humour and buffoonery,” says Arshad. “Once you cross it, it stops being funny.”

‘For the show, I satirise the truth’

Shekhar Suman on his short-lived political stint and why he needs to be apolitical while hosting Shekhar Tonite

Devansh Sharma

A COUPLE of weeks ago, Shekhar Suman’s cryptic yet scathing monologue on his talk show *Shekhar Tonite* left many wondering about its political undertones. The monologue, which spoke of a king who “smashed the mirror” when he did not want the truth about himself to be revealed, was even shared by the Indian National Congress on their official X handle with the caption: “Who is this king? Why did he smash the mirror?”

Shekhar Tonite is a late-night talk show, built around unscripted, free-flowing conversations with personalities from films, politics, music and others. The first episode premiered on Suman’s YouTube channel on May 15 this year. The episodes are released every week on Friday. Seven episodes of the show have aired so far, with Nitin Gadkari, Bobby Deol, Ali Fazal, Amruta Fadnavis, Manoj Bajpayee, Gippy Grewal and Farah Khan as guests.

In this interview, he explains why he believes it is important to remain apolitical while hosting a satirical talk show. Excerpts:

Do you think there’s scope for political satire in the polarised world of today?

I play it by the ear. So far, it’s been fine. A little irreverence and leg-pulling is okay with the guests. I think it’s also in the manner you speak to them. If the intention is to humiliate or run someone down, that’s what they don’t like. A little bit of nodding and nudging is fine. They also like it if you take them to a place where they haven’t been. In my monologue, I comment on the socio-political system of our country. What I say is basically satirising the truth that I read in newspapers.

You had Union Minister Nitin Gadkari in the premiere episode of *Shekhar Tonite*. Did being an ex-member of the

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) help in bringing him onboard?

No, I was a member of BJP only for 24 hours.

Why did you decide to join the party in the first place then?



I don’t know. Sometimes, you get pushed into a corner. There are reasons beyond one’s control. It’s happened to me twice. I had once contested on a Congress ticket (in 2011, lost to Shatrughan Sinha of BJP), where I was also pushed into a corner. I was a very unwilling candidate. Even now, I fail to understand why I did that. But it was just a

SPEAK UP
(Top) Shekhar Suman on his show; with Ali Fazal as his guest

membership, not a full-time political role.

How important is it to not be a part of any political party while doing a political satire show?

For a show like this, you’ve to be completely apolitical. You can’t take sides, leaning to the Left or the Right. You have to sit on the fence.

Javed Akhtar said in his farewell Rajya Sabha speech that politicians from rival parties are actually quite friendly behind-the-scenes. Was that your experience too?

Yes, they are (laughs). In the political arena, they have to take a stand. But I hope politicians have a human side to them as well. They’re not close buddies, but are friendly and enjoy a sense of camaraderie. It’s like two countries who are friendly, but when they go to war, they can’t cross paths.

Was Nitin Gadkari hesitant to come on the show considering you quit the BJP within 24 hours?

No, he was more than willing. My show *Movers & Shakers* (1997-2012) had a certain legacy of high-ranking politicians coming as guests. They all knew what they were getting into. When Sushma Swaraj (former Union Minister) came on my show, she told me, “Everybody warned me not to go on this show, except my daughter, who said, ‘If there’s one show you should go on, it’s this one.’” So, once they are there, they know what they have been hearing from others is nothing but a misconception.

You even got an endorsement from then Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee for *Movers & Shakers*?

Yes. At an event, he saw me, stopped the cavalcade, stepped out of his car, and hugged me. He told me, “This show must go on. When you took off on me, I laughed the loudest! I recorded it and saw it every day.” That’s the greatest compliment for an actor. Where else do you see a prime minister stop for an actor?

Late night shows are having a tough time in even the US now, with *The Late Show* with Stephen Colbert going off air. Right?

It’s surprising because America is known for democracy and free speech. Had it happened in India, I’d have still understood. In the UK, you could go to Hyde Park and openly say anything against the Queen or the monarchy. That’s how it should be in India as well. We should have a completely hands-off policy, and the latitude to talk about anybody. In a democracy, everyone has the right to free speech and if we have elected a government then we have the right to criticise it.

Theatre director Habib Naghmouchin says Shakespeare's prince is not indecisive but a relentless questioner of power

A Frenchman finds his Hamlet in Hindi

Rinku Ghosh

MANY MAY claim to be Indians but theatre director and filmmaker Habib Naghmouchin lives as one. Whether spending 12-hour days in rehearsal halls at Delhi's Shri Ram Centre for Performing Arts (SRCPA) or being on the road documenting India's diverse soils with his camera, the French artiste has found an enduring conversation here that keeps his eyes ever curious. Yet one fascination remains constant wherever he goes: Shakespeare, and Hamlet in particular. So much so that he is now directing the tragedy in Hindi despite never having formally learnt the language.

"Shakespeare is dynamic. Each of his characters can slip into any context and geography and yet remain relevant," says Naghmouchin, whose artistic journey has been shaped by collaborations with theatre giants Peter Brook and Ariane Mnouchkine. "Hamlet is a language of emotion. What matters are the vibrations

of the actors I work with," says the director, who plays both the flute and piano, and instinctively responds to sound and rhythm. The French avant garde director is in Delhi at the invitation of SRCPA for his Hindi debut because he wanted to contemporise Shakespeare in a foreign language. For many directors, staging Hamlet in an unfamiliar language would be daunting. But Naghmouchin is remarkably pragmatic about it. Having worked on Shakespeare for years, he knows the play intimately. The Hindi script has been vetted by ex-NSD theatre practitioner Chinmay Das while rehearsals are built around long readings and emotional exploration rather than linguistic precision. "Often there is confusion over the words," he says. "But we can understand the text by looking at the emotion of the actor. Emotion is universal and the truth of the actor is universal."

That search for emotional truth shapes his reading of Shakespeare's most discussed protagonist. While Hamlet is often viewed as a paralysed prince inca-

LANGUAGE NO BARRIER
(Above) Hamlet and Ophelia on stage; Naghmouchin rehearsing with his players



pable of action, Naghmouchin sees him differently. "The play is complex but not complicated," he says. What makes Hamlet enduring, he argues, is not indecision but inquiry. "There is a difference between doubt and dilemma. Hamlet has doubt, not a dilemma. And he asks questions of established structures by staying within the system, not abandoning it or turning into a rebel. He represents not the power we inherit but the power we choose to seize. How many of us can ask questions of power to authoritative regimes?," he asks. In an age of instant outrage and rigidities, that quality feels contemporary.

Naghmouchin believes the play resonates deeply with present-day India and the wider world because it interrogates power, corruption and moral responsibility. Drawing parallels with the Mahabharata, he sees Hamlet wrestling with a timeless question: how does one seek justice without blackening one's soul? "And although Hamlet gets sucked in by circumstance to act in a predictable way, he knows he is slipping. He is self-aware," says the director.

The production itself strips away period grandeur in favour of contemporary immediacy. Performed by a young repertory whose actors are in their early 20s, the play rejects romantic notions of Shakespearean tragedy. "My first task is to tell the story truthfully and simply," he says. "These actors come from today's social reality, so I ask them to be true to that reality." Rather than presenting Hamlet as a distant classical figure, Naghmouchin views him as a young man overwhelmed by forces larger than himself, struggling to navigate a chaotic world.

"I work with youth because I see hope in them as evidenced by youth-led movements globally. They can imagine another possibility. If they lose hope too, we will be lost forever," he says.

With identity politics, polarisation, conspiracy theories and declining trust in institutions shaping public life globally, many theatre lovers have described our times as Hamlet-like. "Do we need a Hamlet today? Absolutely," he says. Yet he rejects simplistic hero worship. Hamlet's integrity lies not in moral

purity but in his willingness to engage with difficult questions. "He goes to the end of the journey," Naghmouchin says. "He gets pulled into conflict. He reacts to context. The important thing is what he chooses to do with what is thrown at him."

His interpretation also foregrounds the contradictions at the heart of the prince. Hamlet speaks luminously of love, yet contributes to the destruction of both his lover Ophelia and mother Gertrude. "That is the paradox. Both are judged, become objects of Hamlet's anger and are denied full control over their circumstances. And both die." In fact, Naghmouchin wonders why Shakespeare sacrificed the two women. Across Europe, he notes, some actresses have become reluctant to play Ophelia or Gertrude because of the violence directed at

'Hamlet has doubt, not a dilemma. And he asks questions of established structures by staying within the system, not abandoning it or turning into a rebel'

HABIB NAGHMOUCHIN,
French theatre director and filmmaker

them within the narrative.

Naghmouchin has absorbed lessons from two of modern theatre's greatest directors. Mnouchkine, founder of Théâtre du Soleil, taught him the art of observation, making him sit beside her in silence for six months. Brook, by contrast, embodied generosity. "He would ask, 'What do you think of the scene? How were the actors today?'" recalls Naghmouchin. Brook believed the theatre itself was a space free of simplistic notions of good and evil. Those influences are visible in a production that draws lightly on Indian aesthetics. The stage is spare, furnished with Kashmiri carpets, while the music incorporates sitar, sarod and the evocative strains of Raag Bhimpalasi.

Ultimately, Naghmouchin's Hamlet is less about a prince seeking revenge than about a human being confronting the consequences of choice. "He is wise," the director says, "but he becomes a victim of circumstances. He cannot always control his actions. Still, he keeps seeking answers." For Naghmouchin, that act of questioning may be the most radical form of action of all.

The play will be staged at SRCPA, New Delhi, July 3-5



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Every time I land in a new country, before the sightseeing, before the landmark photos, sometimes even before checking into the hotel, I find the nearest grocery store. Mainly because I have learned, over years of travel, that you can understand more about a country in 30 minutes inside its supermarket than in three hours at its most famous monument.

I'm not sure when this habit started. It might have been in Japan, staring at a convenience store shelf that looked like a museum exhibit. Or maybe it was in Turkey, watching a shopkeeper weigh out dried apricots with the kind of care you would expect at a jeweller. But somewhere along the way, I stopped treating supermarkets as functional stops and started treating them as the most unfiltered cultural experience a destination has to offer. And here's the thing: apparently, the rest of the world has caught up.

The Trend That Nobody Saw Coming

In 2026, Hilton published a research report that found 77 per cent of travellers worldwide already visit local grocery stores as part of their travel experience. Not as an errand. As a deliberate activity. Skyscanner's India-specific data showed that 36 per cent of Indian travellers want to explore local supermarkets on their next international trip. The European Union even coined a term for it: 'Supermarket Safaris.' It sounds almost absurd when you first hear it. Are people skipping museums to walk through grocery aisles? But the more you think about it, the more it makes sense. Because what a supermarket stocks, how it's priced, how it's arranged, what's fresh and what's frozen, all of it tells you a story that no guidebook, no monument plaque, and no guided tour will ever tell you. So today, let me take you on a trip. A trip that I call 'The Supermarket Safari'.

The Kitchen Is Still Alive

Walk into a market in the Turkish city

The Supermarket Is the Real Sightseeing



intimate once you notice it.

The Scale of Everything

Nothing prepares you for an American supermarket. The cereal aisle is 30 feet long. Milk comes in gallons. A single rotisserie chicken at Costco costs less than a cup of coffee at the airport. Portion sizes that would comfortably feed a family of four back home are labelled 'single serving.'

It's overwhelming at first. But once you adjust, you start seeing the logic, or at least the cultural story behind it. America's relationship with abundance is baked into the design. Bigger is better. More is more. Value is measured in volume, not quality. The grocery store in America reflects how they think about choice, value, and excess. You learn more about the American economy walking through a Walmart than you would reading a hundred op-eds.

The Andes on the Shelf

Peru's supermarkets surprised me the most. Coca leaves are sold as casually as tulsi. Quinoa in bulk bins, not in premium health-food packaging, because here it's not a superfood trend, it's just food. Purple corn juice, chicha morada, in the beverage aisle next to Coca-Cola. Freeze-dried potatoes, called chuño, preserved using techniques that Andean communities have practised for centuries, sitting on a shelf in a modern supermarket as if no time has passed.

The geography of Peru, the altitude, the climate, the soil, is still the main character in what people eat. The Andes aren't just a backdrop for photos. They are on the shelf, in every product, shaping

what's available and how it's consumed.

Where Convenience Is a Craft

I have said this a hundred times already about Japan. Start at a konbini, a Japanese convenience store, 7-Eleven, Lawson, FamilyMart - take your pick. The first thing you notice is the onigiri. Each rice triangle is wrapped in a packaging system so precisely engineered that the nori stays dry and crisp until the exact moment you pull the tab. It's a ₹100 snack wrapped like a piece of technology.

Then you see the bento boxes. Grilled fish, pickled vegetables, perfectly portioned rice, restaurant-quality meals for the equivalent of ₹300. There are on-site microwaves if you want to heat them. There are recycling stations sorted into five categories. There's a hot coffee machine that asks how much milk you would like before it pours.

Convenience, in Japan, is a philosophy. The care that goes into a ₹100 triangle of rice and seaweed would put most sit-down restaurants elsewhere to shame. You won't learn this at a temple in Kyoto. But you will learn it in 10 minutes at a Lawson.

Immigration in the Aisles

In Australia, Vegemite gets all the attention. But walk deeper into a Woolworths in Sydney or Melbourne and you will find a shelf that tells a far bigger story. Tim Tams next to laksa paste next to Japanese curry blocks next to Indian mango chutney. Wonton wrappers next to sourdough. Kangaroo mince next to halal lamb.

The shelf isn't confused. It's a mirror. Australia is a country built by

immigration. Wave after wave, decade after decade. And nowhere is that more visible than in what its supermarkets stock. A single aisle in Woolworths carries the food identity of a dozen countries, sitting side by side without explanation, because no explanation is needed. That's just what Australia is.

India - Flip the Lens

Now flip it. What would a foreign traveller learn about us from walking into our stores?

The first thing they would notice is that India doesn't have one grocery shelf. It has dozens. And each one tells a story as distinct as any country on this list.

Maharashtra: The farsan shelf. Chivda, chakli, shev, branded and loose, side by side. Kokum syrup and sol kadhi mixes that wouldn't exist two states away. Aamras pulp in tetra packs, stocked seasonally like it's a limited-edition luxury, which, honestly, it is.

Gujarat: Jagery in varieties you didn't know existed. Khakhra in 15 flavours. The sheer square footage dedicated to snacks because the Gujarati palate treats snacking as its own food group, and the shelf respects that.

Kerala: Coconut oil in quantities that would confuse anyone from the North. Banana chips in every variant imaginable: sweet, salt, masala, jagery-coated. Appam and puttu batter in the chilled section, ready-made, because mornings here run on rice batter and coconut milk.

Punjab: The atta shelf with 20-plus brands, because in this part of India, the roti is an identity. Ghee in large tin containers meant for daily use, not special occasions. The pickle section, mango, lime, garlic, mixed, each in three regional styles.

Tamil Nadu and Andhra: The chilli section tells you everything. Guntur, Byadgi, Kashmiri, sorted by heat and purpose, not lumped into one 'red chilli' bin. Filter coffee powder sold by roast profile. Ready-to-eat formats dominated by rice: idli batter, dosa batter, murukku.

Northeast India: Bamboo shoot in jars. Fermented soybean, akhuni, sitting on a shelf next to regular dal. Smoked meat products. A grocery aisle that would feel genuinely foreign to someone from Mumbai or Delhi. And that's precisely the point.

A D-Mart in Pune and a local store in Imphal are separated by more than just distance. They are separated by entirely different food cultures sharing the same passport.

ADVERTORIAL

What the Shelf Knows

So now that we have walked through Japan and Turkey, France and Peru, Korea and America, Australia and six different versions of India, let me dwell on something that ties all of this together.

Monuments show you a country's curated past. What it chose to preserve, what it decided was worth freezing in time. A supermarket shows you the unedited present. The version of the country that nobody planned for tourists to see.

Pricing tells you about the lived economy, the one that decides whether a family reaches for olive oil or sunflower oil. Packaging tells you about design sensibility. The minimalism of a Japanese wrapper, the riot of colour on an Indian snack packet. What's fresh versus what's frozen tells you whether a culture shops for today or for the week. And the aisle a store gives the most space to tells you what that society values most. In America, it's cereal. In France, it's cheese. In India, it changes every 500 kilometres. None of this requires a guidebook, an entry ticket, or a queue. Just 30 minutes and open eyes.

So here's my suggestion. Next time you land anywhere, Narita or Istanbul, Sydney or Lima, or even a city in India you haven't visited before, find the nearest grocery store before you find the nearest landmark. Walk every aisle and just look. The lives will tell you what it is.

And if you do try it, write to me. What's the most surprising thing you have ever found on a supermarket shelf, at home or abroad? I have a feeling the answers will be as varied and fascinating as the shelves themselves. See you next week!

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